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THE NEW YORKER

APRIL 13, 2026



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Goings On

- [New Directors, New Films](#)

Goings On

New Directors, New Films

Also: Zendaya and Robert Pattinson in “The Drama,” Michael Schulman on spring fabulosity, Rachel Syme on the latest in trenchcoats, and more.

By Richard Brody, Marina Harss, Dan Stahl, Sheldon Pearce, Jane Bua, Michael Schulman, Rachel Syme

April 03, 2026



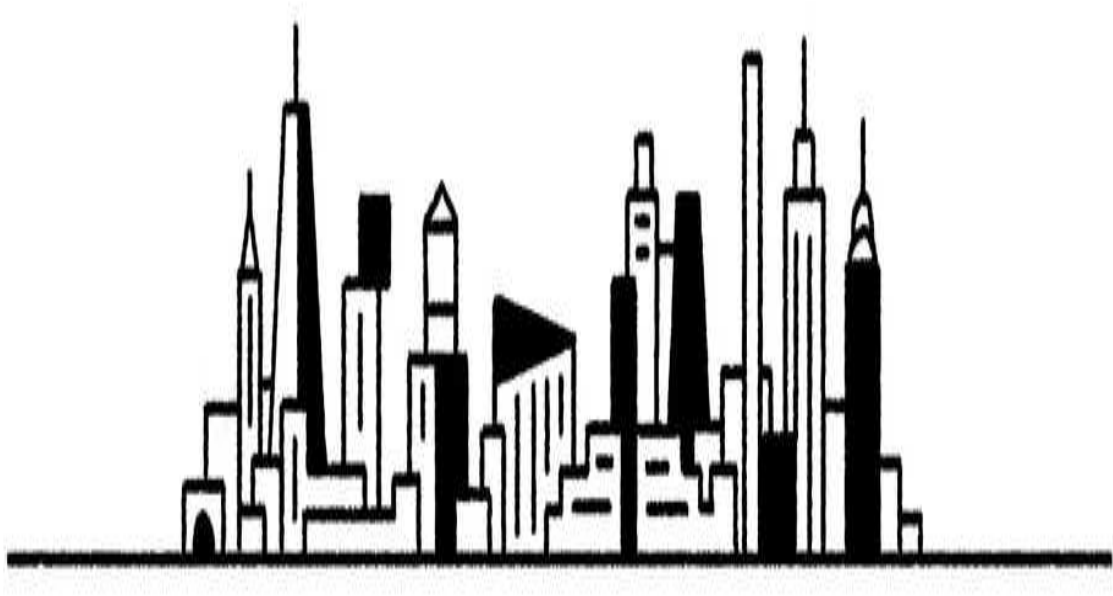
This year's edition of the [New Directors/New Films series](#), an annual collaboration between *MOMA* and Film at Lincoln Center that began in 1972, highlights a diverse array of movies with invigorating approaches to narrative form—foremost, **“Variations on a Theme,”** the second feature by the South African filmmakers Jason Jacobs and Devon Delmar, which weaves together multiple story lines in its hour-and-five-minute span. The film is set in a mountain village where an elderly woman named Hettie (Hettie Farmer) lives alone on a small farm, tending her flock of goats with increasing difficulty. The village's Black residents, including Hettie, are energized by a promising but tangled effort to redress a long-standing injustice—the unequal compensation received by Black South African soldiers in the Second World War. Meanwhile, a man obsessively seeks

buried treasure beneath his home. The life of the rural region is framed in airy and luminous wide-screen images that recur with a lyrical vision of vast arcs of time amid dramatic social change.



A simple setup gives rise to quiet complexity in the Tibetan American director Tenzin Phuntsog's first dramatic feature, **"Next Life,"** set in an unnamed American suburb (filmed largely in his parents' house, in California). There, an old Tibetan man (Tsewang Migyur Khangsar) requests a Tibetan doctor to tend to his ever more troubling ailments. As the patient weakens, he hopes to visit Tibet once more, prompting his son (Tenzin Phurpatsang) to seek out a visa for him from a Chinese consulate; meanwhile, the family turn toward their religious traditions, which Phuntsog strikingly and movingly embodies in poised and serene images of a rare, modest, yet exalted spirituality.

Pete Ohs's modernist melodrama **"Erupcja"** stars Charli XCX as a young woman who, while vacationing in Warsaw with her boyfriend (Will Madden), reconnects with an old friend (Lena Góra). The two women's powerful, mysterious bond is sketched in sharp yet subtle dramatic strokes that are all the more thrilling for their breathless rapidity. It will be released in theatres on April 17; its festival screenings are an enticement to the aptly impatient.—*Richard Brody*



About Town

Classical

Much has been said about opera recently—that it’s out of touch, that it’s a dying art, that it doesn’t have enough Ping-Pong in it. No matter what we’re willing to admit, there’s a reason why this is a prevailing perception, so how do we rise to the challenge of changing it? The Met’s latest attempt is by putting on **“Innocence,”** the final opera by the late Finnish composer Kaija Saariaho, which tells a story of grief and trauma after a devastating school shooting. Told in two time lines, one near-present and one past, with a libretto by Sofi Oksanen and Aleksis Barrière, “Innocence” dissects the personal impact of gun violence, taking on a tragically common occurrence. One can imagine more irrelevant things.—*Jane Bua* ([*The Metropolitan Opera*](#); select dates April 6-29.)

Off Broadway

Cannibalism, rape, a severed tongue and hands, filicide . . . Quentin Tarantino has nothing on Shakespeare. In the Bard's early tragedy "**Titus Andronicus**," acts of revenge pile up like so many bodies. The bloodletting begins with Titus (Patrick Page), a Roman general who returns from a victorious campaign against the Goths, carting along their deposed queen, Tamora (Francesca Faridany), and her three sons, one of whom is executed to avenge Titus's own sons slain in battle. It's a credit to the director, Jesse Berger (for Red Bull Theatre), that he doesn't shy away from the play's gore, especially vivid against the set's ghostly columns, whose sleekness aligns with the neofascist chic of the costumes. It's a credit to the agile cast that they find humor in the gallows.—*Dan Stahl* ([Pershing Square Signature Center](#); through April 19.)

Pop Soul



The 2021 album "Skin" introduced the bruised songcraft of the British singer-songwriter **Joy Crookes** to the wider world. After several EPs and a nomination for Rising Star at the 2020 Brit Awards, she met the moment with a soulful pop sound, smuggling in references to her London upbringing, as the child of Bangladeshi and Irish immigrants, and meditating on the awakenings of young adulthood. "Skin," shortlisted for the Mercury Prize,

cultivated a lithe, jazzy voice that eased through the hushed rhythms of mellow R. & B. production, and her follow-up, “Juniper,” from September, is just as subtle but even more refined, its sonic acuity mirroring its clarity of thought.—*Sheldon Pearce (Irving Plaza; April 13.)*

Off Broadway

In his twenties, the title character of Chekhov’s “**Ivanov**,” played by Zachary Desmond, was filled with passion and purpose. Now, at thirty-five, he’s a self-loathing, debt-ridden farmer who bemoans “a lethargy in my soul.” His disaffection baffles his acquaintances and pains his tubercular wife (a superb Quinn Jackson), whose doctor (Lambert Tamin) has only contempt for her husband’s agonizing. To convey Ivanov’s world-weariness without wearying the audience is a challenge that Michael DeFilippis’s production doesn’t always meet—despite its well-acted, artfully designed, energetic staging of Paul Schmidt’s resonant translation. There’s a built-in repetitiveness to the material, not unlike the thought patterns of depression itself, that constitutes a Russian rebuke to myopic American optimism: sometimes it doesn’t get better.—*Dan Stahl ([West End Theatre](#); through April 12.)*

Dance

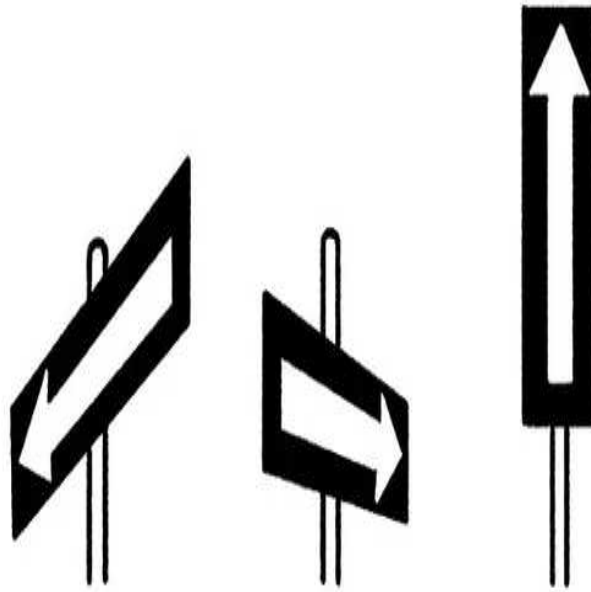


A century ago, the choreographer Martha Graham cobbled together an evening of original works at a Broadway theatre, her first. Could she have known then that it was the start of a momentous career? The troupe she created, **Martha Graham Dance Company**, has survived, despite tall odds. In its centenary season, it performs three of Graham's most well-known dances, all about love: "Appalachian Spring" (1944), with its spacious score by Copland, is about hopeful, expansive love; "Diversion of Angels" (1948), about different facets of love and its twin, passion; and "Night Journey" (1947), inspired by the Oedipus myth, chronicles love (and lust) gone horribly wrong.—*Marina Harss* ([New York City Center](#); April 8-12.)

Movies

"**The Drama**," the writer and director Kristoffer Borgli's earnest story of love forged and fraying, is set in Boston and spans about two years in the lives of Charlie (Robert Pattinson) and Emma (Zendaya); not even these stars' vibrant and thoughtful performances can rescue the film from ridicule. During a wine-drenched evening, the soon to be married couple, along with two friends (Alana Haim and Mamoudou Athie), confess the worst thing they've ever done; one such admission puts the wedding at risk, as well as friendships and even professional standing. Borgli offers a childish view of

romance, leaping from acquaintance to engagement with no substance in between, and the fancy editing scheme of flashbacks and leaps ahead merely calls attention to the underlying void.—*Richard Brody (In wide release.)*



Pick Three

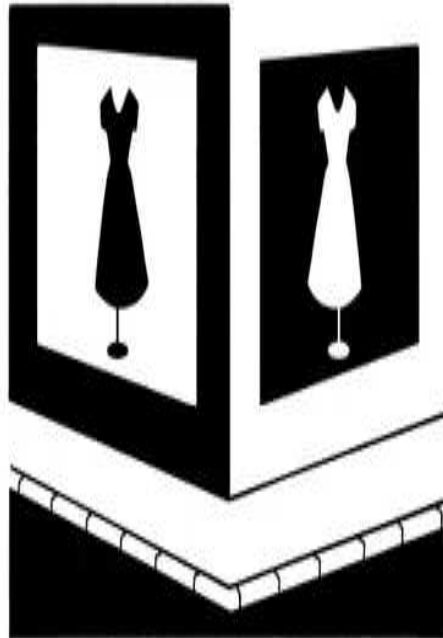
Michael Schulman on spring fabulosity.

1. “The Rocky Horror Show”—the louche sci-fi musical that went from underground stage sensation in London to cult movie and queer touchstone—returns to Broadway, directed by Sam Pinkleton (“Oh, Mary!”) and starring Luke Evans, Stephanie Hsu, Juliette Lewis, and Rachel Dratch. In anticipation, I suggest streaming the documentary “**Strange Journey**,” which came out last year, for the film’s fiftieth anniversary. It’s directed by Linus O’Brien, the son of Richard O’Brien, the British New Zealander who wrote the show (and played Riff Raff) and then went on a gender odyssey.
2. If your idea of heaven is flipping through a 1982 issue of *Interview*, good news: **Library180**, a chic, by-appointment magazine reference library, now occupies a bright room on the twenty-sixth floor of an office building on Maiden Lane. Created by Nikki Igol and Steven Chaiken, who worked

together at the fashion magazine *V* in the early two-thousands, the place is stocked with vintage issues of *Paper*, *Vogue*, and more. Through a red chain-link curtain is a back room containing the likes of *Screw*, Al Goldstein's erotic tabloid from the sixties and seventies.



3. Julio Torres, one of the most original minds in comedy, wrote surreal sketches for “Saturday Night Live” before unveiling his brilliant 2019 HBO special, “My Favorite Shapes,” in which he sat at a conveyor belt in futuristic silver garb and narrated the inner lives of objects that rolled by. He’s back on HBO with a companion piece, **“Color Theories.”** Using a synesthetic logic all his own, Torres explains why Dwayne (the Rock) Johnson is orange, Catholicism is purple, and navy blue is the nefarious color that secretly runs the world.



On and Off the Avenue

Spring in the trenches.



Springtime, at least in New York City, is, in this writer's humble opinion, somewhat overrated. Sure, it has its pleasures: the vibrant return of window-

box buttercups, the reopening of the Central Park boathouse, the ornate millinery of the Fifth Avenue Easter Bonnet Festival, the Brooklyn Botanic Garden's "Cherry Watch" live map tracking exactly when each Sakura blossom blooms, the thrift stalls at the Hester Street Fair, the annual New York Botanical Garden Orchid Show, the renewed chance to drink a cold beer at a baseball game. But, mostly, city dwellers are deprived of the true glories of the season. We aren't watching chicks hatch or witnessing the miracle of foaling or plucking clumps of wild ramps from the earth. Instead, we continue traipsing through concrete, burdened with utter confusion about what, exactly, to wear: spring is a time of meteorological fakeouts; one day it will be balmy, the next frigid. Or, mornings are crisp and call for bundling up, but dress in too many layers and you'll overheat by noon. Rain, April's rude house guest, visits erratically and unannounced.

So, what to put on? One timeless solution is the trenchcoat, a relic of the First World War, which has, over the last century, become the go-to topper for sensible urbanites during these mercurial months: blocking wind and moisture without ever feeling too heavy makes it the ideal garment for unpredictable conditions. The original trenchcoat, designed by Thomas Burberry for the British Army, was made of Burberry-invented waterproof gabardine. Now you can find trenches (or at least trench-*ish* coats) in nearly every material under the sun—crêpe, suède, twill, jacquard, Gore-Tex. What makes a trench a trench? Some say it's the cut; traditional trenches are long and double-breasted, with epaulettes, a waist belt, and storm flaps. But these days, trenches come in all shapes: cropped, batwing, even backless. The [classic Burberry trench](#) (\$2,995) is khaki, but modern trenches adhere to no set color rules. Perhaps the definition is more spiritual than fixed. If it looks like a trench and feels like a trench, then it must be one. The market is teeming with options, but a few that caught my eye this season include [the Riva](#) from **the Frankie Shop** (\$495), a streamlined tan number with an unexpected shoulder detail; [the Lana](#) from **Apparis** (\$325), a playful approach in sheer leopard-print organza, and, for those in a splurge-y mood, [the Aspen](#) from **Aligne** (\$849), in smooth green leather the shade of a Castelvetro olive. I'm still no spring evangelist, but to stroll through the park in a new coat? It's enough to make you feel reborn.

—*Rachel Syme*

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [*A collection of obsolete sounds*](#)
- [*On the fiction of siblings*](#)
- [*All-too-real fake cover art*](#)

The Talk of the Town

- [Donald Trump and Pete Hegseth's Warped Vision of the Iran War](#)
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- [Do the Circulation-Desk Shuffle](#)

Comment

Donald Trump and Pete Hegseth's Warped Vision of the Iran War

The two men might wish that they lived in a world where whoever dropped the most bombs got whatever he wanted. But the war has shown that this isn't true.

By Benjamin Wallace-Wells

April 03, 2026



There is no good way to call off a war that you started but which hasn't achieved what you'd hoped. On Wednesday night, Donald Trump, in his address to the nation on the Iran war, sought to counter reality with hyperbole. "We've beaten and completely decimated Iran," the President said. "Never in the history of warfare has an enemy suffered such clear and devastating large-scale losses in a matter of weeks." Of course, Iran's Revolutionary Guard retains control not just of the country but of the Strait of Hormuz, and therefore of an alarmingly constricted global oil supply. A month of air strikes had killed many leaders but had not changed the regime. Even so, Trump suggested that the mission was "nearing completion," and

that the U.S. military would soon be pulling back. But if Tehran did not accept a deal, he added, “we are going to hit them extremely hard over the next two to three weeks. We’re going to bring them back to the Stone Ages, where they belong.”

Big talk. But the announcement also sounded like a concession, since two to three weeks probably isn’t enough time for Trump to follow through on some of his prior threats: an armed invasion of the oil ports of Kharg Island, or an even more ambitious raid to extract uranium likely stored in tunnels near nuclear facilities. The morning of Trump’s address, media reports had suggested that he was considering withdrawing the United States from *NATO*. Instead, the President taunted America’s allies, some of whom had been pleading for a settlement over Hormuz. “Build up some delayed courage,” he told them. If they want the oil to flow again, they should “go to the strait and just take it.”

It has been a central conviction of Trump’s second term that the nations of the world now operate on self-interest and brute force, rather than on principle or alliance, and the White House has been eager to spread the news. The mockery that the Administration directed at its own, less warlike allies this week (“Last time I checked, there was supposed to be a big, bad Royal Navy,” the Secretary of Defense, Pete Hegseth, said on Tuesday) recalled its jeering of Volodymyr Zelensky in February, 2025. “You’re buried there,” Trump told the Ukrainian President about his nation’s battlefield prospects.

This penchant for what Saul Bellow called reality instruction—the cynical delight taken in explaining to idealists how the rough-and-tumble world really works—extends from Trump throughout the Administration. But perhaps the most eager reality instructor has been Hegseth, one of the Administration’s more politically fragile figures, who, when he’d been picked to join Trump’s Cabinet, was a co-host of “Fox & Friends Weekend.” Hegseth is so committed to a vision of the world defined by winners and losers that he once wrote that Joan of Arc was a “loser” because her last battle “ended disastrously and eventually with her execution.”

Hegseth came out of his own service, in Iraq and Afghanistan, with the seeming conviction that what had stood in the way of a fuller victory in

those wars had been the restraints supposedly placed on how soldiers could kill. (In 2019, he successfully lobbied Trump to pardon two soldiers charged with or convicted of alleged war crimes.) “We unleash overwhelming and punishing violence on the enemy,” Hegseth told a large gathering of senior military officials, whom he had summoned to Quantico, in September. “We also don’t fight with stupid rules of engagement . . . just common sense, maximum lethality, and authority for warfighters,” he said. “You kill people and break things for a living.”

On Iran, Hegseth has led the Administration’s periodic press briefings, at which he has called on Americans to pray to Jesus Christ for the military’s success; his slogan has been “maximum lethality.” But even in the first hours of the war it was clear that this approach could backfire. The initial strikes, which began on February 28th, killed the Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, but were so indiscriminate that, as President Trump noted, they also killed many of the political figures who the White House had hoped would form a new, more amenable cadre of leaders. “Most of the people we had in mind are dead,” he said a few days later. The ones remaining, even if Trump didn’t want to acknowledge it, were generally described as more hard-line. One of the President’s stated aims has been to inspire a popular uprising among those Iranian citizens sick of the repression and the autocracy enforced by the Revolutionary Guard. Yet that requires taking care to distinguish between the regime and its civilians, and to avoid collateral damage. But, according to a preliminary investigation, on the same day that U.S. forces assassinated Khamenei, they also dropped a bomb in the wrong place, inadvertently killing nearly two hundred people in an elementary school.

Trump and Hegseth might wish that they lived in a world where whoever dropped the most bombs got whatever he wanted. But the Iran war has shown that this isn’t true. The old liberal institutions may be teetering, but that doesn’t mean that all that’s left is the law of the jungle. The fact that the President is now signalling a messy retreat has nothing to do with insufficient lethality and everything to do with politics—in particular, the alarm in the global oil markets and the American public’s widespread opposition to the war. One tragedy of Trump’s war is that, in January, the Iranian regime was under extreme pressure from protests, which it quelled by murdering thousands. The right kind of coordinated push might have

toppled it. Instead, the White House offered frequently shifting rationales for its war and little outreach to the Iranian resistance. It treated the military operation as something to brag about to its political base—a way to show exactly how unrestrained it was willing to be.

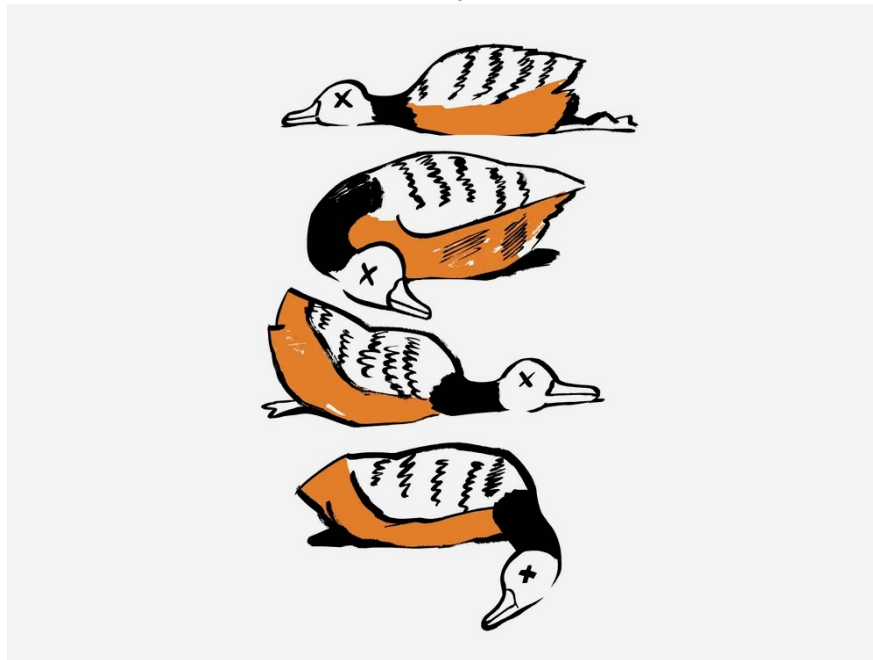
The day before the President's address, Hegseth gave a press conference in which he recounted a recent visit he'd made to bases in the region. "It was the American warrior, unleashed," he said. He seemed to view the trip as a parable. "As the sun was going down and a chill was setting on the tarmac," he encountered an airwoman and asked her what the troops needed: "She simply looked at me with a sly smile on her face and said, 'More bombs, sir. And bigger bombs.' " That might have been what the airwoman asked for. But what Trump and Hegseth really owed her, the nation they lead, and the Iranians whose country they bombed was a plan—a real solution to the disaster that they have created. ♦

Geese, Cooked

As bird flu hits the Hamptons, Long Island's fanciest beaches are becoming mass graves for felled fowl.

By Emma Allen

April 06, 2026



Come springtime in the Hamptons, the sight of large flocks of Canada geese, flying in V's overhead or foraging in fields, brings mixed feelings. On the one hand: summer is around the corner! On the other: droves of (human) jerks will be arriving soon. But, recently, a different seasonal scourge disrupted the status quo. Highly pathogenic avian influenza—or H5N1, a.k.a. bird flu—has plagued the East End's Canada-goose population, littering some of the most expensive Zip Codes in the country with hundreds of bird carcasses.

The die-off became a talking point after the Instagram account @kookhampton (“kook” is slang for a clueless surfer) posted a photo of a three-foot-deep trench dug on Georgica Beach—a mass grave, packed with

geese. Commenters noted that this was “how horror films start,” and that it posed a hazard to excavation-minded dogs and kids with shovels and pails.

For the nitty-gritty of who (Trustees? Mayors? The Department of Environmental Conservation?) is responsible for dealing with scores of deceased birds, there’s one guy to read: Christopher Gangemi, who writes the “On the Wing” column of the East Hampton *Star*. The other day, he joined Kathleen Mulcahy, the executive director of the Evelyn Alexander Wildlife Rescue Center, to answer a call from the East Hampton homeowners Kyle Glaeser and Andy Yuder, about a sick goose.

Gangemi’s own migration pattern: he left the city and a job in day trading after 9/11; another flock followed him during *COVID*. “I think, with this war, if there’s the tiniest hint of danger, *everybody’s* going to come out,” he hypothesized, then spotted the ailing goose, whose neck was coiled, its eyes cloudy.

“I don’t know why I’m gendering him, but we saw him yesterday,” Glaeser explained. “And then we were at dinner last night and a friend told us about all the birds that they found at the beach . . .”

Mulcahy, wearing gloves and a mask, cornered the goose, wrapping it in towels and handily depositing it in a plastic bin. “I chased a turkey for twenty minutes this morning,” she said. The turkey perked up and flew off. This bird, however, was going back to the center to be euthanized.

“Is it peaceful—like we did with our dog?” Yuder asked. “What is it, gas, over the beak?” Mulcahy reassured the callers that the goose would inhale a vapor, and “just go to sleep,” protecting other birds and scavengers from the virus.

Gangemi’s articles chart the progression of the disaster, from “Geese Rule State Bird Count Here” (February 19th, when 10,806 geese were spotted on the East End; business as usual) up to March 26th’s “Goose Die-Off Slowing.” The D.E.C. is hopeful that the flu will peter out, as warmer weather leads geese to break off into breeding pairs.

But one goose still had to make its final journey to the rescue center, in Hampton Bays, which, last year, had 2,666 “patient admissions,” spanning nearly two hundred species, and released more than eight hundred and fifty animals back into the wild. That bird was met by a staffer named Grace DeNatale, outside an isolation tent. Geese had suffered this year, she noted, because the winter was so brutal. “This was supposed to be their oasis, and everything was frozen for weeks,” she said. “They were all probably smooshed together in whatever thawed areas they could find, with barely any resources. People would also be getting sick in that situation.” (2025 was the year of raccoon distemper—it’s always something.)

Gangemi had spoken to an ornithologist at Cornell who said that the goose population would likely bounce back. But they face other threats.

“Cars, pesticides, lead,” Mulcahy said. “Have we ever gotten a swan that *didn’t* have lead poisoning?”

She introduced the center’s education animals, which, for various reasons, can’t be released. There was Henry Hunter, “a very angry screech owl,” and America, a red-tailed hawk, who, as a baby, had fallen out of his nest. After being reared by rehabilitators, he was sent to a flight-training program in New Jersey, but failed (bad vision).

DNA testing some years ago revealed that the center had been wrong about the sexes of many of its residents. Vlad, a turkey vulture who’d been hit by a train, was, in fact, female. The center had tried to release Vlad but kept getting calls from restaurants complaining that she was eating people’s French fries.

“You know where turkey vultures really like to hang out?” Gangemi said. “The Roanoke Avenue Elementary School—there’s this chimney and they just all sit around it. Whatever is coming out of that chimney, they like the smell.”

The goose was dead. Everyone headed back outside, where a steady chirping could be heard. “How’s that for the best sound in the world?” Mulcahy asked.

“Peepers!” Gangemi said. The spring peeper (*Pseudacris crucifer*) is a small, loud frog; male peepers have a bell-like mating call that heralds the arrival of spring. ♦

Old Friends

Happy Hour with Emanuel Ax

To ring in his new WQXR podcast, the veteran pianist puts on a special live show with a secret surprise guest—his old drinking buddy Yo-Yo Ma.

By Jane Bua

April 06, 2026



For someone who has been at the piano for seventy years, Emanuel Ax shouldn't be so worried about performing. "I get terribly nervous when I play," he said softly, standing on the stage at WQXR's Greene Space, near SoHo. "But at least I usually know what's about to happen. Here, I'm not so sure."

Ax, who is seventy-six, was about to record a special launch-party show to celebrate his new podcast, "Classical Music Happy Hour," in front of an audience of more than a hundred people. Five chairs were set up onstage for panelists, and a sixth would be added for a surprise guest—Yo-Yo Ma, the world-renowned cellist and Ax's friend of fifty-plus years. "I like virtually everybody," Ax said. "But I love that man."

Ax shuffled to a regal Steinway grand to run through a four-handed piece —“Dvořák’s Slavonic Dance Op. 46 No. 1,” he said. “Not that anybody cares.” The other two hands belonged to one of the panelists, the actor David Hyde Pierce. The pair had met at a benefit in Los Angeles, where Pierce had bravely told Ax that he, too, tickled the ivories.

“I’m sort of in heaven, so it doesn’t matter how the sound check goes,” Pierce said.

Ax seemed to be in hell. “I hope we get through it,” he said. “We’re going to screw up a lot.” He was right. Their page-turner, the WQXR host Jeff Spurgeon, was no help; despite Pierce’s violent nodding, he missed a few crucial flips. (“All of my page-turning gigs have been last-minute,” Spurgeon said.)

“I assume the engineers will take care of stuff,” Pierce said. “They’ll have their work cut out for them.”

In the greenroom, picking at crusted-over hummus and sliced salami, Ax tried to distract himself by getting to know another panelist, the linguist and music teacher John McWhorter. “Do you do—?” he started to ask.

“I’m a pretty good cabaret pianist,” McWhorter said. “And I also played cello for many years as a kid.” He giggled, worried that he’d let slip the Yo-Yo secret. “Sorry, I shouldn’t have said that.”

When showtime arrived, Ma sneaked in a side door just as cameras started to roll. Onstage, Ax’s jitters melted into charm. “Who would be your ideal guest?” the m.c., WQXR’s Elliott Forrest, asked.

Ax replied, “Obviously, Beethoven would be great, but he’d be asking ‘What?’ all the time.”

Then came time for the Dvořák. Ax and Pierce launched into triumphant C major, tufts of white hair jostling as they crashed through their mistakes. Spurgeon stood behind them, following intently; he whipped a page, jaw clenched. (His wife, sitting close to the stage, squealed, “Yes! Yes!”)

As the action was winding down, the sixth chair was placed. “It’s incredibly nice of him to make the effort and come and see all of us,” Ax said. “It’s my friend Yo-Yo Ma!” Ma trotted out holding a cello, to One Direction-level applause. He nestled himself in the piano’s curve, and the two old friends eased into an arrangement of “Over the Rainbow.” Ma’s bow danced over the strings; Ax’s fingers glistened across the keys. The room was still, and Pierce began to cry.



“We’ve developed a sixth sense,” Ma said, after the show. “We’re not looking at one another, but we know exactly when to do something.”

“You have a very expressive back,” Ax said.

Ma, ever the muse, was the one who inspired Ax’s pivot to podcasting. “It came from Yo-Yo’s idea of doing a music ‘Car Talk,’ ” Ax explained. Ma shook his head in protest, but Ax bulldozed on: “And they wanted both of us to do it, but you had too many things going. I had more time.” He added, with a smile, “I follow your life!”

“We’re like an old married couple,” Ma said. “Every time I go to Manny’s house, he’s got all these wonderful wine bottles. It’s a friendship with benefits.”

“The alcohol I drink most is probably white wine,” Ax said.

“And you drink champagne,” Ma corrected.

“I thought that was a wine,” Ax replied.

“Well, you said *white* wine,” Ma said. Checkmate.

“We try not to drink too much,” Ax said. “We’re very easy to put away.” They looked at each other with boyish glints. Conversation turned, inevitably, to music. “By definition, we cannot reach the aspirational goal,” Ax said, loftily. “There’s no perfect performance.”

Ma nodded. “And ‘Over the Rainbow,’ for example, is about yearning,” he said. “If the bluebird can, why can’t we?”

Perfect performance or not, Ax thought the live show had gone well. “I was silly in all the right places,” he said. He was even O.K. with the messy Dvořák. “We had to play *something*,” he said. “Since I don’t talk so good.” ♦

The Boards

Getting Older with Clare Barron and Anne Kauffman

At the Cherry Lane Theatre, the writer and the director of “You Got Older,” starring Alia Shawkat and Peter Friedman, dish on mortality, romantic angst, and the rapper Pitbull.

By Alex Barasch

April 06, 2026



Mortality has a way of sneaking up on you. For the playwright Clare Barron, the wake-up call came in 2013, when her father was diagnosed with Stage IV head-and-neck cancer. She had just been dumped by a boyfriend who was also her boss; at loose ends, she took trips to Washington to be with her dad and started writing through it. She gave these overlapping crises to Mae, the protagonist of “You Got Older,” which premiered at *HERE* Arts Center, in Manhattan, within a year of the events that inspired it. Barron was twenty-seven. The other day, she surveyed her old venue, her gaze alighting on a tree-filled courtyard next door. “I remember having a lot of tearful conversations right here,” she said brightly.

Both the original production and a new one, now running at the Cherry Lane Theatre, were directed by Anne Kauffman, known for her work with such playwrights as Amy Herzog and Jordan Harrison. Kauffman arrived at *HERE* with her husky mix, Eleanor Roosevelt, in tow. “Hi, honey bunny!” she said to Barron. She wore a rust-colored tank top, her hair in a ponytail. Barron, less optimistic about the early spring weather, was buttoned into a long red coat.

The pair set off on a walk, Eleanor sniffing the pavement as they went. Their first encounter twelve years ago was, Kauffman said, “very blind date-y.” She’d taken a break from directing. “My mother had just passed away,” she said. “I didn’t want to do anything.” Then she read “You Got Older.” The tragicomic look at two lives on hold struck a chord; its depiction of a family bickering and bantering, and of the risks of intimacy, felt specific and true. Kauffman, fresh from a divorce, was drawn to Mae’s plight: “I thought, I *have* to do this play.”

Barron’s dad was finally declared cancer-free during rehearsals. She hadn’t shown anyone in her family the script. “One of the most terrifying nights of my life was my parents coming to see the play,” she said. (Beyond the real-life trauma, there was the fact that her heroine, unmoored and horny, fantasizes about a cowboy who’s into B.D.S.M.) In the end, her dad got it, and Barron won an Obie. Though the show could run only a month, she and Kauffman kept in touch and schemed about reviving it.

Their stroll ended at the Cherry Lane, where the front-of-house staff cooed over Eleanor. Barron and Kauffman entered the adjoining restaurant, the Wild Cherry—retro vibe, painted ferns creeping up the walls—and settled into a green booth. Over drinks (Barron’s a white Negroni, Kauffman’s a spicy Paloma), they reflected on the new run, which stars Alia Shawkat and Peter Friedman. This time, the chief source of anxiety had been a pivotal dance sequence improbably set to Pitbull’s “Timber.” At *HERE*, they hadn’t asked his permission, and Barron was alarmed when the Cherry Lane insisted that she reach out. “But I did write a letter to Pitbull saying, Hey, we’re doing a play about cancer. Can we use this? And Pitbull said we could.”

In between the two productions, Barron moved to L.A. and became a Pulitzer finalist for another semi-autobiographical play, “Dance Nation.” Kauffman made her Broadway début and was later nominated for a Tony. Other things remain the same. “I’m still myself, and by that I mean there’s still a ton of drama and angst in my life,” Barron said. She met her partner in the writers’ room for a TV show—a guy who, like the ex from “You Got Older,” started out as her boss. “Something he does not love is that I’ve dated many of my bosses,” she admitted. “I just like a power dynamic!”

Her next project will also be with Kauffman. The new play is about, as Barron put it, “a thirty-year affair,” and “the myth of the soulmate.”

“It’s about marriage, and it’s about love, and it’s about art,” Kauffman said. “In my own life, I feel like all of those things were thrown into question after we worked together, and we bonded over that.”

The evening’s performance was about to start. Both women had loved ones in the audience, but this time Barron’s parents weren’t among them. They were on a long vacation to Italy, born of the near-death experience that had inspired “You Got Older.” When her dad recovered, she explained, he and her mother thought about what they wanted from the rest of their lives. “They’re sending me fifty photos a day on WhatsApp of the Sicilian countryside,” Barron said, smiling. “Nothing makes me happier than knowing they’re living their dream instead of seeing my play again.” ♦

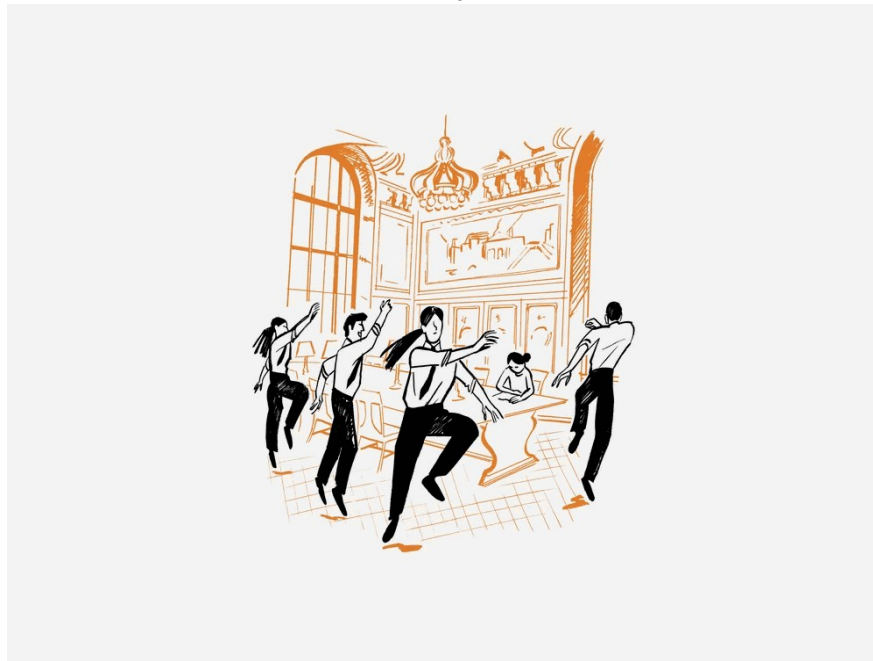
In the Stacks

Do the Circulation-Desk Shuffle

The New York Public Library's new series, Lunch Dances, features choreography based on objects in the stacks. Can a pirouette tell the story of a mid-century lesbian magazine?

By Naaman Zhou

April 06, 2026



The desks of the New York Public Library's main branch, on Fifth Avenue, are five and a half feet apart. That is enough space for a jeté or maybe a restrained arabesque. The other day, a squad of dancers stretched and limbered up in the halls as, outside, the lions stayed still. The dancers were there to prepare for Lunch Dances, a series of free performances organized by the library, in which they twirl through the building's collection of around fifteen million items, to dramatize the joys and serendipities of research.

Robbie Saenz de Viteri, the project's co-creator, came into the visitor center, wheeling a library cart laden with a blinking soundboard. Next to him was Monica Bill Barnes, the co-creator, choreographer, and lead dancer. Saenz de Viteri looked like a podcaster: tousled hair, black-rimmed glasses, a plaid

button-down, and a microphone. Barnes stood with dancerly poise in a crisp white shirt, a black tie, and cushy black sneakers.

Each performance lasts an hour. Audience members, who sign up online, wear headphones, through which they hear music and a live narration by Saenz de Viteri. During the run-through, he said softly into the mike, “There’s no way to rehearse this in the studio.” It was after hours, but the dances are designed to be performed when the library is packed.

In the dance, Barnes plays a library page on her lunch hour who has to deliver five research requests to patrons. It’s a quasi-Shakespearean structure, comprising love and heartbreak. At the great doors of the lobby, she meets five more pages, who shimmy and snap like a gang of Jets. Inside the DeWitt Wallace Periodical Room, with its elaborate murals, Barnes meets two researchers. Anna, in a cardigan and a messy bun, has ordered a box of editions of *The Ladder*, a magazine launched in the fifties, published by the first lesbian-rights organization in the United States. Hannah, opposite, in a checkered shirt and Vans, has ordered *Us Weekly*. (“Yes, we have *Us Weekly*. So does your optometrist. But your optometrist does not have twenty-five years of *Us Weekly*,” Saenz de Viteri said.) Around them, the dancers spin and slide. The researchers’ eyes meet.

Watching the rehearsal were two librarians in headphones: Meredith Mann, a curator of manuscripts, who had on a tartan skirt, and Kate Cordes, a director of reference and outreach, who was dressed all in black. Both had helped Saenz de Viteri and Barnes find ideas for the plot.

Saenz de Viteri had taken Frank O’Hara’s 1964 book, “Lunch Poems,” as loose inspiration, but making a dance about a library was a challenge. “We just really panicked,” Saenz de Viteri said, of the commission.

“Everyone has that, the first time they visit,” Mann told him. (Her initial job at the library, as a volunteer, was a project that involved transcribing historical menus.) She had shown Saenz de Viteri *The Ladder*, when he and Barnes were rummaging in the collection.

A lot of the dances turned out to be slightly melancholy. Cordes teared up at a scene about an older visitor, sitting alone in the gold-ceilinged map room.

“I’ve had people cry at the desk,” she said. “Especially in Genealogies.”

“Doing research is a really personal thing, but you’re also surrounded by people,” Mann said. “You’re reading someone’s diary, their love letters.” In the Periodical room, Anna discovers an edition of *The Ladder*, from November, 1964, that published the first cover photo of an openly gay woman in the U.S. The cover girl is Ger van Braam, an Indonesian woman who subscribed to *The Ladder* and sent her picture to the editor in search of kinship. “In this city of millions, surely there are hundreds of my own sort,” she wrote.

After the rehearsal, Saenz de Viteri ran through some notes. “Do you feel like you get the story of that object?” he asked the librarians, of Anna’s historic copy of *The Ladder*. “There’s a part of me that is, like, You’re not allowed to pick it up!” he said.

“It’s like how police officers don’t watch ‘Law and Order,’ ” Cordes said. ♦

Reporting & Essays

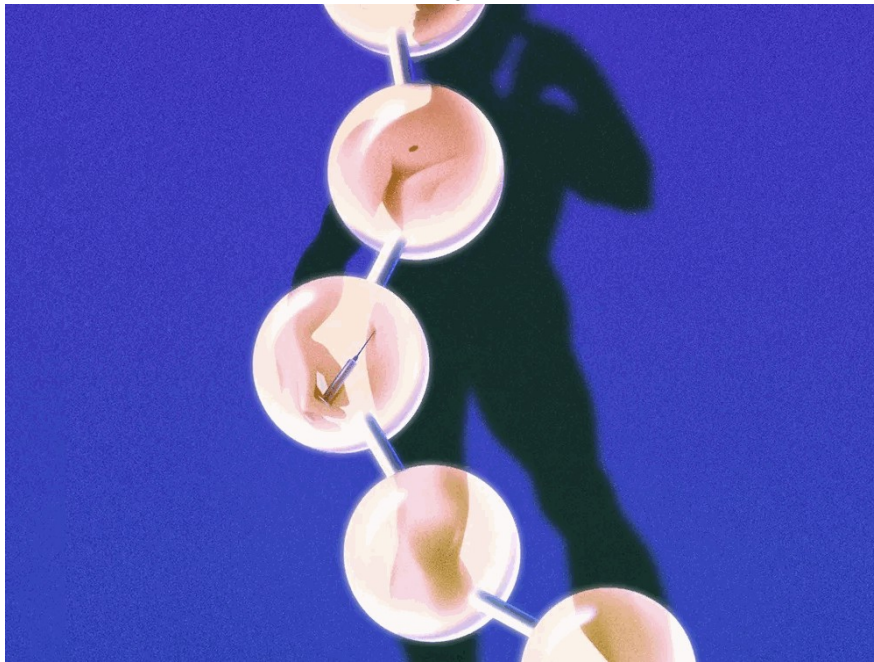
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- [Can Sponge Cities Save Us from the Coming Floods?](#)
- [Sam Altman May Control Our Future—Can He Be Trusted?](#)
- [How the Internet Fringe Infiltrated Republican Politics](#)

Why Are People Injecting Themselves with Peptides?

Health and wellness influencers are hawking unapproved treatments on the gray market. The future of the F.D.A.—and the health of consumers—is at stake.

By Dhruv Khullar

April 06, 2026



About a decade ago, a group of competitive CrossFitters in Charleston, South Carolina, went looking for ways to improve their athletic performance without taking steroids. At the time, members of the fitness community were starting to inject themselves with peptides—short chains of amino acids, sometimes called microproteins, that often act as signalling molecules in the body. Certain peptides were said to enhance strength, energy, endurance, and recovery. They hadn't been officially approved for use as drugs, however, and many had never been studied in humans. Some of the CrossFitters were patients of a local doctor named Craig Koniver, who had trained in family medicine but went on to offer Botox treatments and skin fillers, as well as

I.V. drips that were supposed to slow aging. “People are really enjoying the benefits,” the CrossFitters told Koniver, of peptides. Would he help the group figure out which to inject, in what doses, and how often?

Koniver began ordering peptides from compounding pharmacies, which produce custom medications. He tinkered with various doses, often extrapolating from animal studies, and tried some on himself. He gained a reputation for peptide wizardry. “My name got passed around,” he told me. Rick Rubin, the music producer, introduced Koniver to the neuroscientist and podcaster Andrew Huberman, who invited him onto his hugely popular show in 2024. (“You’re going to get blitzed,” Koniver remembers Huberman saying.) On the podcast, Koniver said that “almost everyone I could think of” can benefit from peptides, and he highlighted an “awesome, supersafe” example called BPC-157. In the month that followed, eight hundred new patients requested appointments. He now sees a total of about a thousand; six thousand more are on a wait list. A membership to his practice can cost fifteen thousand dollars a year, suggesting a revenue in the tens of millions. “I could charge more,” Koniver said. “But I want to sleep well at night.”

In February, I flew to Charleston and met with Koniver in a modern red brick building that houses his clinic. He and his wife, Keli, have a sort of his-and-hers practice: she co-founded a wellness spa next door. Koniver greeted me in his waiting room, which featured a soft-rock soundtrack and brochures for serums and stem cells. His bald head, goatee, and glasses made him look like a friendlier version of Walter White, from “Breaking Bad.”

“Peptides are usually the opening question we get,” Koniver told me, in his office. He described many of his clients as “the well who want to be super well”—celebrities, politicians, models. “We don’t take insurance, obviously.” I spotted a Raiders helmet signed by Howie Long, a defensive end turned Fox Sports analyst, on a bookshelf. On a computer, Koniver showed me an electronic ordering system that looked much like the one I use to treat hospitalized patients. But his system, unlike mine, allows him to request unapproved peptides in bespoke combinations, or “stacks.”

Next, Koniver led me to the clinic’s I.V.-infusion room, where he offered me a poke bowl for lunch. Concoctions were scrawled on a dry-erase board like

specials in a diner; one was described as “Dr. Koniver’s blend” of vitamins, minerals, and amino acids. He asked me if I’d like a complimentary drip of methylene blue, a chemical dye that is increasingly marketed for improving longevity and memory. I knew it as a last-resort blood-pressure drug that, at high doses, constricts blood vessels so much that it can cause gangrene. I accepted the poke but declined the drip.

After lunch, a new patient, a handsome middle-aged man I’ll call Toby, eased into a recliner topped with a fluffy pillow. A nurse inserted an I.V. into one arm; Koniver shook his other hand, saying, “Welcome aboard!” Toby and his family had recently been in a car accident, but he’d lost trust in most doctors, he said, after they became “obsessed” with viruses and vaccinations during the pandemic. He was glad that Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., the Secretary of Health and Human Services, was getting the country “on the right track.”

“I’m not a big vaccine guy,” Koniver replied. “A lot of them don’t have the data.”

Toby wasn’t here for a peptide injection, but Koniver advised him to try one on a future visit. “I’ve seen tremendous results,” he said. He also said that one of his I.V. drips, which includes methylene blue, makes his patients “feel like they’ve been plugged into an electrical socket.”

“Love that!” Toby responded.

I was puzzled, perhaps naïvely, that little-studied peptide shots had earned Koniver’s trust, while meticulously studied *COVID*-19 vaccinations had not. “Anecdotal data means a lot to me,” he said. “Two days after a vaccine, someone has a stroke. Two days later, they’re dead. . . . You see enough of that, it makes an impression.”

In recent years, federal efforts to control peptides have placed Koniver at odds with public-health agencies. In 2023, during Biden’s Presidency, the Food and Drug Administration placed nineteen peptides, including BPC-157, on a “do not compound” list, citing “potential significant safety risks” that included immune reactions, pancreatitis, and accelerated growth of cancerous cells. In response, Koniver began offering a peptide that differed

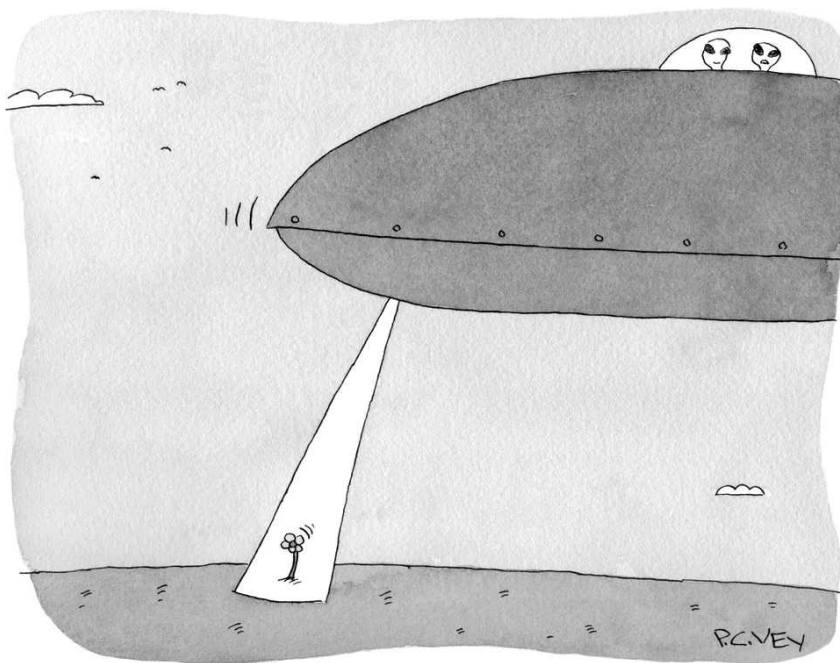
by a single amino acid. “So far, we’re getting very similar results,” he told me.

In 2024, Koniver was sanctioned by South Carolina public-health officials who found, among other things, that he’d failed to maintain his registration with the Drug Enforcement Administration while prescribing controlled substances, and that he’d neglected to check patient vital signs before administering ketamine. Koniver attributed these lapses to charting issues and said that no patients were harmed. “There was never a clinical complaint,” he added. He paid a ten-thousand-dollar fine and agreed not to administer ketamine or testosterone for a year. The state of New York, where he was also allowed to practice, ordered him to surrender his medical license there.

As far as peptides go, Koniver seemed to support America’s public-health agencies coming under new management. “Some of my patients are very high up in the government,” he said. “They’re extremely concerned about what the F.D.A. is doing to peptides.” In the era of Make America Healthy Again, the popularity of peptides has risen. Many compounding pharmacies are experiencing soaring demand; the *Times* reported that U.S. imports of gray-market peptides and hormones from China roughly doubled last year. The podcaster Joe Rogan has credited BPC-157 with healing a case of elbow tendonitis in two weeks. Beauty influencers who want deeper tans and enhanced libidos are taking Melanotan II, also known as the “Barbie peptide.” Even *New York* magazine recently published a freelance writer’s account of self-injecting peptides, titled “Life on Peptides Feels Amazing,” which failed to cite any peer-reviewed research or academic scientists. In February, R.F.K., Jr., said, on Rogan’s podcast, that he had taken peptides himself and that, under his leadership, the F.D.A. would stop restricting many of them. Kennedy, who has railed against the agency’s “aggressive suppression” of unproven treatments, has vowed to “end the war.”

The human body produces thousands of peptides. Many are portions of proteins which send messages or regulate systems in the body, often in ways that scientists don’t fully understand. Researchers have known about some peptides for decades, and dozens have been turned into safe and effective drugs. The hormone insulin is a peptide that moves sugar from the bloodstream into cells; GLP-1, or glucagon-like peptide-1, spurs the

pancreas to release insulin and slows the passage of food through the gut. (Peptides are usually defined as having about fifty amino acids or fewer; more than that and they're proteins.) But the science underpinning the current peptide craze dates to the turn of the century, when Pinchas Cohen, a respected pediatric endocrinologist at the University of California, Los Angeles, started to focus on age-related diseases. For one project, Cohen tried to disrupt a protein associated with insulin resistance and diabetes. By injecting human DNA into yeast cells, he was able to produce several chains of amino acids that clung to his target. Cohen told me that the first two chains were known proteins, but the third was "this ridiculous little thing" made up of only twenty-four amino acids. Strangely, he couldn't figure out where it had come from. According to the conventional wisdom of the day, the DNA he'd injected shouldn't have coded for it.



The peptide, humanin, was ultimately traced to a tiny snippet of mitochondrial DNA—part of the ninety-eight per cent of the human genome that had long been dismissed as “junk DNA.” Cohen’s work helped reveal that, in the three-billion-letter book that is our genome, even obscure one-liners can be an important part of the story. Junk DNA, it turned out, wasn’t junk: it contains instructions for numerous peptides and proteins that had never been studied. “The public conception of peptides doesn’t grasp what’s going on from a scientific perspective,” Cohen told me. “This is not a dozen

or so things you can buy at the gym. This is a revolution in science. It's going to start a new era of drug discovery."

Cohen had little control over how his groundbreaking research would be used, however. After he published a series of animal and cell studies on humanin's potential benefits—the peptide seemed to curb inflammation, control glucose, and possibly even provide protection against Alzheimer's—so-called biohackers began ordering it on the gray market. Cohen himself tried to develop it as a drug, but the peptide was so unstable that it broke down within minutes. More concerning, humanin was eventually linked to breast and brain cancers. Nonetheless, it continued to be sold online. Koniver told me that he has taken it. "I have no idea what people are injecting," Cohen said. "Probably fragments of degraded material."

Cohen is now the dean of the gerontology school at the University of Southern California, and his lab has identified many more peptides. "The rule in my lab is, if you discover it, you get to name it—but I have veto power," he told me. "I like Yiddish names." *SHLP* stands for "small humanin-like peptide"; *SHMOOSE* stands for "small human mitochondrial ORF over serine tRNA." Other discoveries include *MENTSH* and *PUTZ*. His team is best known for identifying *MOTS-c*, which has been called an exercise mimetic: it activates cellular pathways that are usually turned on during exercise. Strikingly, older mice treated with the peptide can run for twice as long as their untreated counterparts.

Cohen deemed *MOTS-c* promising enough that he founded a company to take it into a Phase I clinical trial—an early step on the road toward F.D.A. approval. The peptide caused skin irritation but otherwise appeared to be safe. Its short half-life, however, required it to be injected several times a day, which limited its appeal as a drug, and the company ran out of funding. *MOTS-c* is now on the F.D.A.'s do-not-compound list, owing to the potential risk of immune reactions "for certain routes of administration." Yet it, too, continues to circulate on the gray market. One Redditor said that, since he started taking it, "energy and stamina are through the roof." Cohen reacts to these trends with dismay. As enthusiastic as he is about the potential of peptides, he told me, "people should not be taking them until they're fully tested. The history of shortcuts is not a happy one."

The evidence in favor of many other unapproved peptides is even sparser. BPC-157, which is short for Body Protection Compound 157, was discovered in human gastric juice in a lab led by Predrag Sikiric, a Croatian scientist. (It appears to be a fragment of a larger gastric protein, but no one has traced it to a human gene; Cohen thinks it's probably a product of bacteria that live in the gut.) Studies have touted a staggering variety of benefits in cells and animals; it reportedly heals ulcers, regenerates nerves, aids muscle and tendon repair, counters neurodegenerative diseases, and protects organs from injuries. But most of this research is co-authored by Sikiric, who holds several patents related to BPC-157, and some experts have accused him of cherry-picking evidence. "Science advances through critical verification rather than by repeatedly affirming findings within the same research group," a team of scientists in Poland wrote in response to Sikiric's BPC157 claims. In the usual course of things, a promising drug candidate would be ushered into human trials. Yet, in the three-plus decades since BPC-157 was discovered, no controlled human trial of the peptide has ever been published. In the nineties, Sikiric licensed the compound to a Croatian company called Pliva, which sought a treatment for ulcerative colitis; the results were never released. In 2006, the research-and-development arm of Pliva was acquired by GlaxoSmithKline, which has ample resources for clinical trials, but the company has not commercialized the peptide. According to Sara Talpos of the science magazine *Undark*, a company partly owned by Sikiric sponsored a 2015 trial, at a hospital in Tijuana, that tested the safety of an oral version of BPC-157. The results still haven't been published. Sikiric assured me that the trial had been "absolutely successful" and that the data would be available "very soon," but he declined to let me see it.

Independent scientists have said that BPC-157 appears promising in lab studies—but with major caveats. The peptide seems to stimulate the production of nitric oxide, which enhances blood flow and reduces certain forms of inflammation, but it also generates free radicals that damage DNA and proteins. In addition, the peptide seems to promote angiogenesis, the development of new blood vessels, possibly via a signalling molecule expressed in many human cancers. "You don't want to just willy-nilly stimulate angiogenesis," Paul Knoepfler, a biologist at the University of California, Davis, School of Medicine, told me. (Sikiric argues that it does

these things in a balanced way; he has written that, when it comes to nitric oxide and angiogenesis, “all criticisms of BPC 157 should be dismissed.”)

At the inaugural *MAHA* summit, last year, a compounding-pharmacy executive told the audience that his grandmother was taking BPC-157, and that this was “just one example of these products that can change people’s lives.” Andrew Huberman said on a podcast that two shots had healed a back injury, even as he warned listeners about the peptide’s potential risks. In online forums, people have credited the peptide with boosting energy and curbing pain; they have also reported strange rashes, increased fatigue, depressed moods, and vision problems. It’s possible that BPC-157 is useful, and that the potential gains are worth the potential pains. But, absent human trials, it’s next to impossible to know what it does in the body. Some health consequences might not become apparent for years—and anecdotal evidence is rife with confounding factors. If a peptide stack is popular among weight lifters, who’s to say which peptide did what? Maybe the perceived benefits are actually attributable to dead lifts, or protein shakes, or a good night’s sleep. Knoepfler warned of placebo effects. When people think a medicine is pricey, they frequently report benefits, even when it’s actually an inert substance. “You pay all this money,” Knoepfler said. “You get a set of vials. You inject yourself. It hurts. You really want this to work.”

In some cases, peptides have been clearly linked to harms. Last year, at the Revolution Against Aging and Death Festival, in Las Vegas, two women received peptide injections at a conference booth; shortly thereafter, they developed elevated heart rates, swollen tongues, and trouble breathing. By the time they reached the hospital, one of them had lost control of her neck muscles, and the other had been intubated. Both were ultimately connected to ventilators. (The peptides involved have not been disclosed.) The doctor who administered the injections defended himself by citing an A.I.-generated report, telling *ProPublica* that it “basically says that it is impossible it was the peptides.” When I asked Sikiric whether people should be using peptides like BPC-157, given the lack of data in humans, he said, “As a medical doctor, I should reply negatively. As a human person, I’m not sure. You have to do what’s right for you.” Regulatory agencies have a role to play, he said, but “the final judgment of whether something works belongs to the people, not the F.D.A.”

Let's say you want to make money on health-related products without feeling the squeeze of F.D.A. regulations. You have two main options, Peter Lurie, a former F.D.A. official who now leads the Center for Science in the Public Interest, told me. The first is to adopt a clever marketing strategy. If your company were to claim that its product treats *COVID*, it would be selling a drug. "Boom! The F.D.A. can come down on you," Lurie said. But, if the company describes its product as an immunity booster, the agency's authority is less clear. You usually don't need to conduct clinical trials to sell dietary supplements, sometimes referred to as "nutraceuticals."

A second loophole involves compounding pharmacies, which are largely regulated by state pharmacy boards. Sam An, a pharmacist at a compounding pharmacy until 2021, told me that his workplace employed about twenty people—pharmacists, technicians, cashiers, couriers—in what resembled a chemistry laboratory. At first, he said, "I felt like I was making a difference." He might create a liquid drug for someone who couldn't swallow pills or a fertility drug tailored to a woman's hormone levels. With time, though, An grew disillusioned. For many such pharmacies, he said, "it seemed like the focus became how to make a quick buck." During the pandemic, compounders charged exorbitant prices for ivermectin, even after the drug proved ineffective against *COVID*-19. Many started profiting from GLP-1 drugs during widespread shortages. "They'll add a vitamin and say, 'Look, we've customized it for you,' with a wink and a nod," An said. "The barriers to doing these things are laughable." He considers the peptide craze even more troubling. "They're taking advantage of a population that's looking for a solution and charging them lots of money for something with no proven benefit that could potentially cause harm," he continued. "How is that O.K.?"

The F.D.A. began taking a more assertive approach in 2012, when steroids from a Massachusetts compounding pharmacy led to hundreds of cases of meningitis and more than sixty deaths. "The agency is well aware that there's plenty of activity out there that is likely illegal," Lurie told me. But the F.D.A., like the I.R.S., has the resources to go after only a fraction of serious violations. "By the time you put BPC-157 on the list, there's probably a BPC-158," Lurie said. ("There has not been a 'war on peptides,' " he added. "There has been a war on unapproved products making improper claims.") Trump's F.D.A., which reports to Kennedy, is

also unlikely to aggressively enforce restrictions on peptides. Neither H.H.S. nor the F.D.A. responded to requests for interviews with Kennedy or Marty Makary, the F.D.A. commissioner. A request to speak with a top F.D.A. compliance official was met with a boilerplate statement that said, in part, “Americans deserve to know the quality of the products they are buying and deserve drugs that have been proven to be safe and effective.”

Fans of peptides are increasingly cutting out the middleman and ordering directly from gray-market suppliers. Last year, a twentysomething man I’ll call Michael, who regularly lifts weights and practices jiu-jitsu, began struggling with fatigue and weight gain after starting a new job and recovering from a bad bout of *COVID*. Friends of his had taken peptides—he remembers one of them telling him, “Bro, you should really try them out”—but Michael was initially wary. He spent weeks reviewing animal studies and reading testimonials on various online forums. He ultimately decided to order some retatrutide—an experimental GLP-1 drug that Eli Lilly has advanced to Phase III clinical trials—from a company that sells chemicals for research. He received a container of powder, mixed it with water, and injected it into his stomach. He felt so nervous that he almost passed out. But he soon lost weight, and that made him curious about what other peptides could do.

Michael had a nagging foot injury, possibly related to jiu-jitsu, so he ordered a stack of supposedly healing peptides known as the *KLOW* blend, which includes KPV, GHK-Cu, TB-500, and BPC-157. “You pretty much use the general consensus of what people have taken before you,” Michael told me. (Luke Turnock, a sociologist at the University of Lincoln, in England, has described this phenomenon as “folk pharmacology.”) Michael’s foot pain improved, but, strangely, he also noticed that his skin was changing color; KPV derives from a hormone that contributes to skin pigmentation. Next, Michael ordered a peptide called Semax, which, in Russian, is short for “seven amino acids.” In parts of Eastern Europe, Semax is prescribed for brain trauma and other neurological conditions. “People use it kind of like an Adderall,” Michael told me. Although he found himself procrastinating less, he started to feel “like a pincushion,” he said. He decided to save it for “when I felt like I really needed it.”

Finally, Michael began taking *MOTS-c*. He said to himself, “O.K., if my mitochondria got fucked up in some way from *COVID*, hopefully this fixes the system.” The peptide seemed to give him more energy, but he noticed that he was sweating a lot. When I asked Michael if he felt uncomfortable putting untested products into his body, he, too, invoked *COVID* shots, calling them “a vaccine that also had no long-term studies.” “So it’s, like, Pick your poison,” he said. If the health-care system fails to meet the needs of patients, people will look for their own solutions. “This stuff is going to get a lot more popular,” he told me.

I decided to procure some peptides of my own. Michael recommended a company called SwissChems. “It’s legit,” he said, not one of those “trust-me-bro situations.” A quick search told me that, in 2024, the F.D.A. sent the company a warning letter that said, in part, “Despite statements . . . marketing your products as ‘research chemicals only,’ evidence obtained from your website establishes that your products are intended to be drugs for human use.” I spent a hundred and seven dollars on some BPC-157, CJC1295, and TB-500. At checkout, thirty capsules of demoxytocin—a synthetic hormone that doctors use to induce labor and to treat postpartum bleeding—were added to my cart for free, as though they were lotion samples from Kiehl’s.

I ordered three hundred dollars of *MOTS-c* from the Ultimate Human, a website run by Gary Brecka, a prominent biohacker who has hosted R.F.K., Jr., on his podcast. In my cart, a photograph showed a futuristic blue vial labelled with the words “Research use only,” yet an order of bacteriostatic water and syringes was automatically included, and I was asked to fill out a questionnaire and meet with a medical provider. A video chat with someone named Cynthia appeared on the screen. “You did great with your answers, so I’ll approve it,” she told me. The consultation lasted less than thirty seconds.

Finally, I searched for peptides on TikTok. On a page called Peptide Nexus, which had more than ten thousand followers, I watched animated vials of personified peptides that looked like the emotion avatars in the movie “Inside Out.” “Yo, I’m TB-500!” a smirking red vial declared, a fire raging in the background. “I’m the recovery peptide people call Wolverine mode.” A vial labelled PT-141, which is marketed as a treatment for low libido, was depicted in a tuxedo, shooting a Cupid’s arrow. “I target desire pathways,” it

said. “People call me the date-night peptide.” When I submitted an inquiry on WhatsApp, the vender responded with a guarantee of “99% purity.” I made a few selections from a PDF menu. Most payment platforms will flag peptide sales, the vender said, and sent me a video explaining how to pay in cryptocurrency. My bank initially flagged the transaction as concerning; I had to give my assurance that I really did want to convert a hundred and eighty-five dollars into bitcoin.

The idea of medical freedom—that we should be allowed to decide what to do about our own health—has long had a special status in the United States. “A significant portion of Americans have embraced freedom of therapeutic choice as a constitutional value for most of the country’s history,” Lewis Grossman, a medical historian, writes in his book “Choose Your Medicine.” Benjamin Rush, a Founding Father and a physician, criticized the medical establishment for being closed-minded about treatments recommended by non-physicians. “Many of our most useful remedies have been discovered by quacks,” he argued. In the late nineteenth century, the psychologist and philosopher William James wrote, “If the word ‘sacred’ can be applied to any personal right, surely the right to treat one’s own body as one chooses may claim this title.” A few years later, the Postmaster General stopped delivering mail to the American School of Magnetic Healing, arguing that the organization was committing medical fraud. The school sued, contending that its methods were legitimate, and the Supreme Court ultimately ruled in its favor. “There is no exact standard of absolute truth by which to prove the assertion false and a fraud,” the majority opinion said.

In the twentieth century, however, scandals involving unregulated medical products helped swing the balance of power toward regulation. In the thirties, elixir sulfanilamide, an antibiotic mixed into a toxic solvent, gave patients intense pain, kidney failure, and neurological problems. After more than a hundred people, including many children, died across fifteen states, Congress passed the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act of 1938, which authorized the F.D.A. to evaluate a medical product’s safety before it could be sold. The agency’s modern-day role was defined in 1962, after thalidomide caused birth defects in thousands of babies around the world. The Act was amended to include a much higher standard: drugmakers now needed to conduct controlled trials in order to demonstrate that their products were effective. The gap between the two standards was immense.

Around two-thirds of drugs that met the 1938 safety requirement failed the 1962 efficacy bar.

It is becoming possible to imagine a future in which American regulators lose their grip on the safety and the efficacy of drugs. The venture capitalist Jim O'Neill, Trump's former acting director of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and the current nominee to lead the National Science Foundation, has said that, as soon as drugs are proved to be safe, Americans should be able to "start using them at their own risk. . . . Let's prove efficacy after they've been legalized." Most states have enacted so-called right-to-try laws, which enable patients with life-threatening diagnoses to receive treatments that have completed Phase I safety testing. (More than ninety per cent of such treatments will not be F.D.A.-approved.) In recent years, Montana state laws have gone even further, granting all patients access to an even wider array of experimental treatments. The state may become a hub for medical tourism. Clinicians are shielded from many kinds of disciplinary action, and they can practice for up to twenty-one days a year without holding a Montana medical license.

The case for more medical freedom rests on laudable principles. We don't usually want the government deciding what we can and can't do with our bodies. And, clearly, there are shortcomings to the current drug-approval process. Pharmaceutical companies must typically invest many years and hundreds of millions of dollars to win approval for a drug; partly for this reason, some promising treatments are never approved, and many arrive too late for people who urgently need them. The economist Alex Tabarrok has written that when an approved drug harms people there are front-page stories, but "when the FDA fails to approve a good drug . . . the bodies are buried in an invisible graveyard." On the other hand, if we're making medical decisions in an information vacuum, are we really choosing freely? "The through line of history is that people will try to sell anything with all sorts of fantastical claims," Joshua Sharfstein, a health-policy professor at Johns Hopkins and a former principal deputy commissioner of the F.D.A., told me. "If you're for patient choice, you should be for a system that requires companies to show that their product does what they say it does."

My first two peptide orders arrived quickly. The third, from Peptide Nexus, did not. A company that claimed to be handling the shipping process

contacted me, saying that it wouldn't send the peptides unless I paid a "refundable insurance fee"—another eighty-three dollars' worth of bitcoin. The vender didn't let me cancel my order, so I warily paid the fee. Two weeks later, neither the seller nor the shipper was responding to my messages, and I still had not received my order.

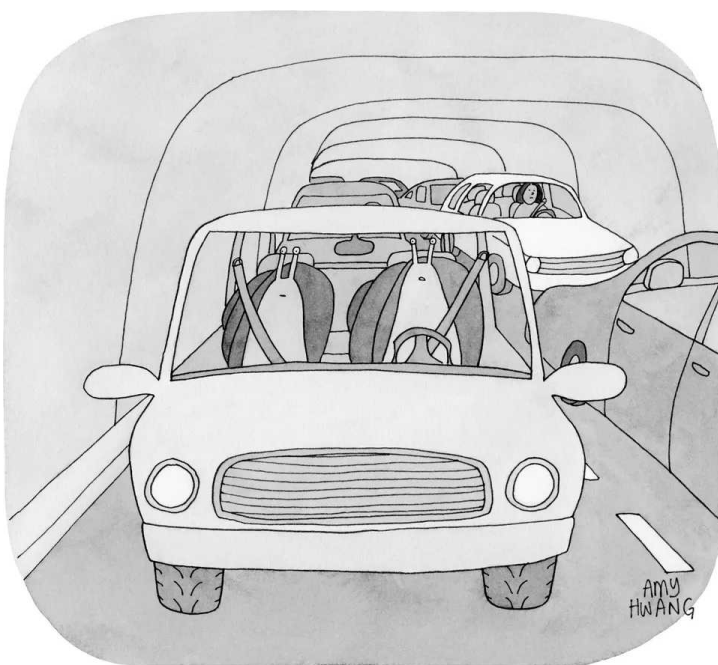
Reader, I did not inject myself with the peptides. Instead, I delivered them to Finnrick Analytics, a company in Austin, Texas, that tests powdered peptides for purity, potency, contaminants, and toxins. Results are posted on the company's website, which gets more than a million hits a month. In the company's telling, it is providing a public service—creating transparency and accountability where F.D.A. enforcement has fallen short or been stymied. "We test peptides to make sovereign health safer," its website says. If you're going to use, use safely. At the same time, insofar as the company promotes a kind of self-regulation within the peptide world, it also enhances the industry's legitimacy. If a drug seems safer to take, maybe give it a try.

Finnrick's office is compact and sits on the second floor of a co-working space. On a filing cabinet, a fierce-looking figurine of Goku, the protagonist of the "Dragon Ball" manga franchise, appeared to be shooting a bottle of semaglutide out of his hands. On a table were scores of vials in trays; beneath it was a box stuffed with incoming packages. Jake Anderson, a recent college graduate, opens most of the packages, takes a photograph of the vials inside, and replaces the labels. "That's so the lab doesn't know where it's coming from," he said.

"We've been getting packages like mad men," Caanan Towns, the company's operations manager and a former college wrestler, said. He joined the company after using peptides to treat a hip injury. In the past year, the number of packages that Finnrick receives has increased more than fivefold, and since December it has more than doubled. "The crazy part is that we've put out zero marketing," Towns added. "But peptides are like a hobby: people don't just take peptides, they want to talk about them with their friends."

Towns and I drove my peptide samples to a squat gray building about ten minutes away. Krause Analytical, a family-owned laboratory that Finnrick hires for much of its testing, also works with the F.D.A. to test food and

pesticides that cross the Mexican border. I spotted a forklift and some sacks of corn flour inside. Mark Krause, the lab's jovial, broad-shouldered director, walked me past dishwasher-size chromatography and mass-spectrometry machines. "Sometimes you don't need all this fancy stuff to know something's not right," he told me. He held a vial of pale-blue powder in one hand and a vial of white powder in the other. "GHK-Copper should be blue," he said. "If they send you something white, I don't know what it is, but it ain't GHK-Copper."



Krause, who seemed peptide-skeptical, estimated that about ten per cent of the peptides Finnrick sends him have serious anomalies of purity, dosage, or sterility. Some vials contain endotoxins—fragments of bacterial cell walls—suggesting poor manufacturing practices and a compromised supply chain. "But, hey, these are 'research chemicals,' right?" he said, winking. "Nobody's injecting them into their bodies!" On a computer, Krause pulled up a chromatography analysis, which separates mixtures into individual components. The graph showed a flat line with a single sharp spike in the middle. "That's pure," Krause said, pointing to the spike. "Just one thing." Next, he showed me a graph that looked like a jagged roller coaster. "All sorts of stuff in this one," he said. "Or whatever was originally in there has degraded." A third graph had two spikes—one for a known peptide called

ipamorelin and another for something mysterious a few inches away. “We don’t know what that is,” Krause said.

About a week after my visit, Krause shared his analysis of the peptides I’d given him. According to his testing, my order of *MOTS-c*, from the Ultimate Human, was ninety-eight per cent pure and contained eighty-seven per cent of the dose on its label. (Of course, this didn’t mean that the peptide itself was safe or effective.) All the peptides I’d ordered from SwissChems had significant issues. The vial of BPC-157 contained lead, the vial of TB-500 contained endotoxins, and the vial of CJC-1295 contained less than forty-two per cent of the advertised dose.

Many of our era’s health trends have something in common: they strive not only to mitigate disease, as mainstream medicine has always been expected to do, but also to optimize health, an aim that many doctors shy away from. I’m not convinced I can offer unproven treatments and still uphold my oath to do no harm. And, even if I knew how to help people attain “peak performance” in their fitness, their careers, or their sex lives, I’m not sure that’s my job. If traditional doctors don’t promise their patients these things, however, others surely will. Timothy Caulfield, a law professor at the University of Alberta, said that health influencers increasingly engage in “scienceploitation”: they generate hype by making speculative claims that extrapolate wildly from limited research. “You take a genuinely exciting area of science and overstate and misrepresent it to sell bunk,” Caulfield said. In his view, Wellness 1.0—which focussed on alternative ways of knowing and on spirituality—has been replaced by Wellness 2.0, which often co-opts the language of science. “It’s almost too easy with peptides,” Caulfield told me. “Even just the word ‘peptides’ sounds science-y and legit.”

On a rainy day this spring, I entered a large hotel in midtown Manhattan that was hosting the Integrative Health Symposium, an annual conference for “forward-thinking practitioners.” I walked through a buzzing exhibit hall, passing booths for “immunity-boosting” mushrooms and protein bars. For some reason, an online-prescribing company was raffling off a Louis Vuitton bag. I approached the booth of a compounding pharmacy and inquired about the peptide business. “The Feds don’t know what to do,” a representative told me. “It’s like Prohibition.”

I was on my way to meet Edwin Lee, an Orlando-based endocrinologist who has worked to bolster the scientific credibility of unapproved peptides. Before I could locate him, a fit middle-aged man, who turned out to be a former car salesman, stopped me. “Want more energy and less pain?” he asked. He instructed me to stand on what looked like a futuristic skateboard—a “vibration plate” that purported to decrease stress, build muscle, increase circulation, and even improve sex. The board began to shake and flash purple; my whole body jiggled. “Get on this for ten minutes a day,” he said. “It’s the equivalent of being on an elliptical for an hour.” He was willing to sell me the board for half off a sticker price of thirty-six hundred dollars.

I politely excused myself and found Lee in the hotel lounge. He was tall, with short salt-and-pepper hair, thin-rimmed glasses, and a happy-warrior disposition. Lee is known for having co-founded the Clinical Peptides Society, which offers a certification for people who want to administer peptides. He also started a petition called Save Peptides, which has collected nearly ten thousand signatures in an effort to loosen government restrictions. “A lot of conventional doctors think this is all bullshit,” he told me, smiling. “They think I’ve gone to the dark side. We agree to disagree, because I still want to go hiking with them.”

A few years ago, Lee’s son, a high-school cross-country runner, developed a sharp pain down his leg. “Daddy can inject you with peptides,” Lee’s wife told him. The boy replied, “He’s not fucking injecting me!” Then Lee showed him some photographs that Sikiric, the Croatian peptide researcher, had published. They depicted a rat’s bloody Achilles tendon, which Sikiric’s team had cut into, healing after BPC-157 injections. Lee’s son ultimately acquiesced—“He just needed to see the evidence,” Lee said—and two weeks later he was running again. Lee now keeps peptides for his family in the butter compartment of his fridge.

While we spoke, one of Lee’s patients, a health-care investor and a former soccer player, wandered into the lounge. One morning in 2024, the man had awoken with searing knee pain that turned out to be a meniscus tear. Several doctors had recommended that he get surgery. Then, at last year’s conference, he met Lee. “This random dude says he can fix you,” the man said. “Why do you trust him? Intuition. There’s something about him. I’ve

never seen a doctor be that confident.” The man flew to Orlando, where Lee injected him with BPC-157. Within days, his knee pain improved.

“I don’t care how many publications someone has,” the man said, hopping on one leg for emphasis. “I don’t want studies. I want results.”

“Not everyone gets better *that* fast,” Lee said, beaming.

Later, Lee and I both attended a talk on peptides by Steven A. R. Murphy, a Connecticut concierge doctor whose website advertises “telemedicine consultation and prescription for Rapamycin, Peptides and other medicines.” The room was so packed that some people were gathered outside the door. The title slide had a photo of a Ken doll with a syringe pointed at its forehead.

“Which ones have you tried?” a young man standing next to me asked.

“None,” I said, feeling like a teetotaller in a frat house. He looked perplexed.

Murphy asked how many audience members had prescribed peptides, and about half raised their hands. He reviewed some peptides that had been approved for specific indications—and thus could safely be prescribed to patients for other conditions—before turning his attention to gray-market peptides. Ipamorelin, for example, was “one of the cleanest” growth-hormone-releasing peptides. It could be given orally or—“illegally,” a slide read—as a subcutaneous injection. Murphy advised us to stick to off-label use of approved peptides, instead of prescribing their unapproved cousins. Otherwise, we might get a “nasty letter” from the F.D.A., or even lose our medical licenses.

At the end of the talk, Lee stood to address the room. “We really need to save peptides!” he said. He exhorted the group to generate data on peptides, noting that he’d personally published three papers about BPC-157. “But I’m only one person,” he said. (Lee’s papers were not randomized and did not use control groups; the largest included sixteen patients and was published in a little-known journal.) On his way out, Lee handed me a copy of a book he’d written. Inside, he’d signed his name, along with a message: “Enjoy life with peptides.” ♦

Can Sponge Cities Save Us from the Coming Floods?

As the planet gets warmer and the rains fall harder, the future of flood control is looking less like a wall and something more like a park.

By Eric Klinenberg

April 06, 2026



On October 29, 2025, the Metropolitan Transportation Authority released an update to its Climate Resilience Roadmap. In the previous eighteen months, six floods, six heat waves, and the driest month on record had exposed weaknesses in the transit network. The M.T.A. proposed familiar remedies: \$1.5 billion for upgraded flood controls, like high-capacity pumps and elevated station entrances. It also urged the city to modernize its sewage-and-stormwater system, because, when that system is overloaded, the discharge has only one place to go—down.

The next morning, the National Weather Service warned that the city would see a low-pressure system bringing gusty winds and one to two inches of

rain. A 6:30 *A.M.* broadcast from NBC 4's "Today in New York" featured the Climate Resilience Roadmap, and cut to video of water gushing into underground stations during a recent storm. "We've all seen those cascading water streams in the subway," the co-anchor, Michael Gargiulo, said. "Yeah," the meteorologist Maria LaRosa replied. "We don't see that coming together today."

For most of the day, the forecast held. But after 3 *P.M.* a band of heavy rain drifted over Brooklyn and dropped a downburst of near-Biblical force. Parts of the borough got more than an inch in less than fifteen minutes—far exceeding what meteorologists classify as a "heavy rate."

The novelist Iris Murdoch once described a storm in which "the rain came down, straight and silvery, like a punishment of steel rods." I asked David Radell, a meteorologist at the National Weather Service, if that described what Brooklyn had faced. He demurred, and instead offered, "Big, round drops, just a bit smaller than a dime. Unrelenting. Dense. Filling the air. Bouncing up from the ground. Potentially something folks haven't experienced before."

Sheila Goodwin *had* experienced flash floods before. Blue Doves, a day care that she runs on the first floor of her family's home, sits at the bottom of a hill in East Flatbush, where rainwater can rush in fast enough to breach basements and even ground floors. Goodwin, a tattooed fifty-four-year-old with a doctorate in business philosophy, was minding a roomful of young children when the wind and rain grew more intense. In autumn, leaves and litter clog the storm drains; even a light shower can turn her block into a bathtub. When pipes fill during a big storm, pressure builds and the water comes back up through the plumbing, into homes and storefronts.

This time, the sound of hammering rain told her that trouble was coming. "The kids were doing our afternoon activities," she said, "and they were, like, 'Oh, the water's coming up the door!'" A co-worker called down: water was rising into Goodwin's car out front. When she opened the door of the day care, she recalled, "the water just rushed in. The kids were screaming and hollering."

She and a colleague lifted the children onto tables. Stormwater, Goodwin pointed out, picks up “everything off the street”—gasoline, heavy metals, raw sewage, rodents. As the foul mix reached knee level, she called 911. Firefighters arrived, and they helped the day-care staff carry the children over a fence and up to a higher floor. Everyone made it out safely.

A few blocks away, at Kingston Avenue and Rutland Road, Aaron Akaberi, thirty-nine, was in a basement apartment with his two dogs when water began surging in. He carried one dog to higher ground and went back for the other. But the flood must have moved faster, and more forcefully, than he expected. Within seconds, Akaberi and his pet were fighting for air. Both drowned. Their bodies were recovered only after the Fire Department’s rescue dive team brought in a pump.

A flood sensor at the intersection recorded 22.4 inches of water at street level between 3:01 and 3:26 *P.M.*; underground spaces took on several additional feet. The downpour surprised almost everyone, yet the day’s total rainfall matched the forecast—about two inches. Flooding is less a matter of how much rain falls than of how fast it falls. Two inches over a day is one thing. Two inches in thirty minutes can overwhelm drainage systems and leave deep ponds in lower areas as water races downhill.

“This was, by our computation, about a five-to-ten-year event,” Radell told me, using a metric that, because it’s built on past patterns, grows less useful as climate change defies those patterns. Events like this have begun to feel ordinary—recurring evidence of the mismatch between aging infrastructure and an emerging ecological reality. That’s why a new generation of designers are reimagining flood control, starting with a counterintuitive premise: the safest city is one that can take water in.

There’s a formula behind the flooding. The Clausius-Clapeyron equation, which was introduced almost two centuries ago, describes the relationship between air temperature and atmospheric pressure. Warmer air holds more water, and the relationship is exponential, so small increases in temperature can yield huge jumps in rainfall intensity. For years, climate scientists have said that warming would bring heavier downpours. Now, it seems, that future has arrived.

In recent years, cities have been living through short storms that turn subway stations into lakes, streets into rivers, cars into boats. Zhengzhou, China, got nearly eight inches of rain in an hour on July 20, 2021. In the Libyan cities of Derna and Bayda, there were no monitors measuring hourly rates on September 10 and 11, 2023, but the totals suggest a storm of terrifying force: more than sixteen inches in twenty-four hours, followed by two dam collapses and more than eleven thousand deaths. The Valencia region of Spain drew global attention on October 29, 2024, when almost seven inches fell in an hour. Elsewhere, record-setting twenty-four-hour totals, including in São Paulo, Dubai, and Milwaukee, have underlined the new reality.

No city was designed for this kind of weather. Modern sewers took shape in the nineteenth century, typically after disasters pushed cities to upgrade their civil infrastructure. Hamburg rebuilt after the fire of 1842, London after summers like the so-called Great Stink of 1858. Engineers replaced streams and marshes with gravity-fed pipes that carried sewage and stormwater toward rivers and seas. These “combined systems” depended on rain to flush the network, and they were built for ordinary storms. When the skies really opened, they backed up.

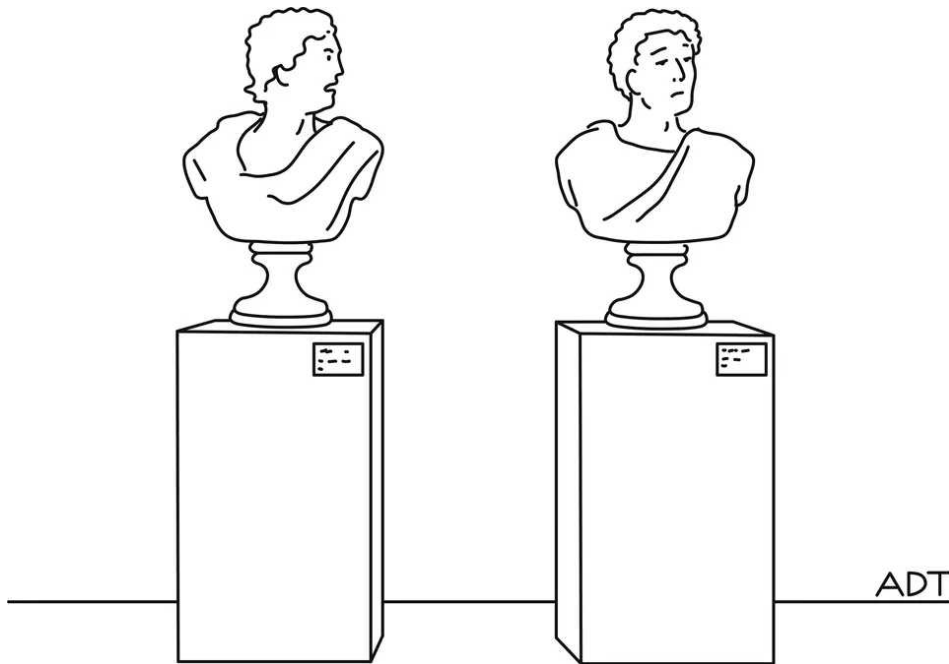
In the nineteen-seventies, New York City standardized flood control for all five boroughs, requiring that new pipes, pumps, and treatment facilities be built to handle 1.75 inches of rain an hour. Until 1991, no storm on record reached that rate. Carolien Mossel, the lead author of a *Scientific Reports* paper on rising rainfall extremes, told me, “It was a perfectly acceptable system, at least for the climate we had then.”

Since the nineties, New York City has experienced eight storms with hourly rainfalls above 1.75 inches, and climate scientists expect that more extreme rain events are coming. New York is built over marshes and creeks and glacial moraines that announce themselves in a storm. Mossel’s data indicate that several of the city’s most intense hourly downpours on record have taken place in the past five years. Radell told me that Hurricane Ida, in 2021, was “the real turning point” for the National Weather Service in New York. It delivered 3.15 inches in an hour in Manhattan, prompted the city’s first flash-flood emergency, and killed thirteen New Yorkers. Four other recent storms have broken hourly and daily records as well, but those were predicted by forecasters. October 30, 2025, was in some ways more

concerning—a routine low-pressure system with a water bomb concealed in its clouds.

As storms that meteorologists once treated as thousand-year events appear more frequently, cities are hunting for workable defenses. One answer is the “modernist” approach: tear up the old tunnels, pipes, and pumps built for a twentieth-century climate and replace them with larger subterranean systems. In practice, some version of this approach remains a staple of urban planning, because certain assets always have to be rebuilt. But in most cities wholesale replacement is logistically impossible. Big metropolitan areas contain hundreds of miles of streets and hundreds of thousands of buildings, all tied into a network that cannot be taken off-line for long. Imagine the time and money that would be required to rip up every block of Beijing, Boston, or Buenos Aires. Most cities cannot excavate their way to safety fast enough. As a result, the ambition is shifting from replacement to redesign.

At the start of this century, a Chinese landscape architect named Kongjian Yu began making the case for a different kind of flood control. Raised in a coastal farming village in Zhejiang Province, Yu came to Harvard’s Graduate School of Design in the nineties after Carl Steinitz, a professor whose lectures Yu had translated, urged him to apply. What he had seen back in China worried him: new hardscapes—roads, plazas, embankments—were at odds with the region’s pattern of powerful rainstorms and periodic droughts.



The solution, he argued, was to build absorbent softscapes: nature-based infrastructure meant to slow, spread, sink, store, reuse, and release rainwater before it becomes destructive. Reuse was essential because in many contemporary cities, and especially across China, water shortages could be as much of a problem as flooding. In public lectures and research papers, he advocated adopting “a ‘monsoon culture’ philosophy, where water is revered as a life-giving force rather than an adversary to be conquered,” and he cast the modern city as a hydrological system smothered under concrete. For centuries, he said, engineers had tried to turn cities into funnels. By contrast, the “sponge city” concept was, he said, a way of “doing Tai Chi with water.”

Yu, who died last year, had forebears. In the eighteen-seventies, Frederick Law Olmsted designed the Emerald Necklace, a chain of parks that managed sewage and flooding in Boston’s Back Bay Fens. But the modern case for green infrastructure found particular inspiration in Ian L. McHarg’s “Design with Nature” (1969). McHarg, a landscape architect at the University of Pennsylvania, warned that hardened landscapes could produce hazards, and he put his theory into practice in the Woodlands, a residential development outside Houston, where forests, permeable soils, and drainage swales outperformed curbs and gutters in major storms. The lesson, for designers like Yu, was that parks could function like infrastructure—that a low-tech, low-cost method of flood control was surprisingly effective.

The appeal of Yu's sponge-city idea comes less from its originality than from its rhetoric, and from the way it scales up an established design approach from the park or subdivision to the metropolis. But its influence was clear when the Chinese state, the most prolific builder of urban infrastructure in modern history, twice turned Yu's arguments into policy. In 2006, the State Council of China approved his "national land ecological security pattern," grounded in nature-based solutions. Then, in 2013—a year after Beijing experienced a flood that killed seventy-nine people, destroyed more than eight thousand homes, and caused \$1.8 billion in damage—President Xi Jinping declared sponge cities a national strategy. China would keep investing in pipes, pumps, and pavement, but "natural accumulation, natural infiltration, and natural purification" would become part of its climate-security plan.

The sponge-city idea was only starting to circulate when, on July 2, 2011, an intense *skybrud*, or cloudburst, dropped more than five inches of rain on Copenhagen in a few hours, including nearly two inches in half an hour. The deluge overwhelmed the city's combined sewer system, along with the six hundred and seventy thousand residents who depend on it. Within minutes, a dark brew of sewage, industrial waste, and stormwater was rising through basements and businesses, hospitals and the central rail station, knocking out power and causing a billion dollars in damage.

Danish policymakers were worrying about climate risk well before the storm. In 2008, Copenhagen put together a project group to assess the city's climate risks. Early in 2010, the group issued a draft laying out weather scenarios, priority areas, and a menu of projects and financing options. Lykke Leonardsen, who runs Copenhagen's Resilient and Sustainable City Solutions program and serves as the city's informal water ambassador, told me that the intent was to hold hearings, win approval in August, and invest gradually. The flood rewrote both the schedule and the agenda.

In late 2012, the city issued an updated adaptation plan that paired classic civil engineering—"gray" solutions—with nature-based measures that it calls "green" (parks, plantings, swales) and "blue" (ponds, creeks, streams). The gray work meant new pumps and tunnels to move stormwater from the street to the sea. The visible transformation was above ground. Roughly three hundred ecological projects across seven catchment areas would be

stitched into the drainage network by “cloudburst boulevards” and “green roads” designed to hold floodwater at street level until the underground system could catch up. Since then, Copenhagen has done as much as any city to make itself rain-resilient, so that the next *superskybrud* brings disruption rather than disaster.

This winter, Leonardsen, a trained archeologist with cropped blond hair and an amiable punk sensibility, invited me to see some of the work. I arrived, by chance, a few hours before a Category 2 winter storm, with forecasts calling for Arctic winds and as much as twelve inches of ice and snow. After navigating slippery sidewalks, I took the Metro to Havneholmen, one of five stations that opened in 2024. The stations were designed to withstand a two-thousand-year rain event, with entrances raised above street level, retractable barriers, floor-to-ceiling glass platform screens, and drainage grates meant to divert floodwater before it does damage.

Leonardsen lives on the second floor of a concrete-and-glass building along the harbor, which has stunning views of the sea. “You’ve missed this morning’s swim,” she told me. I looked out and saw a skin of ice. “I go every morning,” she said. “It’s a big part of how my water work began.”

Copenhagen, Leonardsen told me, was nobody’s model city when she first arrived, as a student, in 1981. It was spiralling toward bankruptcy, hit by factory closures and lost shipping traffic. “We had one crane in all of Copenhagen,” she said, “and it wasn’t for construction—it was for bungee jumping!” Nothing epitomized the city’s decline more than the harbor: it was fouled by chemicals and sewage, the end point of a system built around undersized pipes and overflow outlets that, in heavy storms, dumped untreated wastewater straight into the sea.

In the nineties, the Danish government launched an urban-regeneration plan that paired public money with private development and promised new transit and tourist infrastructure. To reduce pollution along Copenhagen’s waterfront, the city overhauled its combined sewer system, adding underground reservoirs to hold dirty stormwater and installing a “real-time control” system, managing outflows with a network of sensors and automated valves. Nearly all the outlets that had once discharged sewage into the harbor were capped. By the early two-thousands, Copenhagen was

building again: new housing, new bike lanes, a lively bar district, an emerging culinary scene. In 2002, the city opened its first *havnebad*, a public harbor bath, and Leonardsen, along with thousands of her neighbors, took the plunge.

For policymakers, the way the public responded to the harbor's transformation was a revelation. "Saying you're improving water quality doesn't win you a lot of political points," Leonardsen observed. "But telling people that they will be able to swim in the harbor again? That works!" The lesson shaped her office's approach to cloudburst management. Sewers rarely excite anyone, she said, but flood control takes on a different meaning when it arrives as blue-and-green social infrastructure—as pools, parks, and other places to play. The aim is to make the city better on good days, and safer on the worst ones.

To show me what she meant, Leonardsen put on a long olive parka and took me to Enghaveparken, a flood-prone park that, in 2019, Copenhagen turned into a sponge. Built in the late nineteen-twenties, the park sits on more than eight acres at the foot of the hill where Carlsberg ran its original brewery, and is ringed by apartment blocks, schools, and churches. As we entered, she pointed out its neoclassical bones—a sunken lawn, a symmetrical layout, a long brick pergola—and then gestured to heavy concrete barriers, waist-level, that line the park's central space, with wide gaps for pedestrians.

"Look at the ground here," she said, stopping at one of the gaps. "This is a hydraulic floodgate that goes up automatically when the water comes in. The park can hold twenty-two thousand cubic metres"—nearly six million gallons, enough to fill nine Olympic-size pools. The enclosure is designed to store stormwater for up to a day and then to release it, slowly, once the pipes clear. "If we can keep the stormwater out of the sewers," she said, "there's enough room to keep the sewage underground."

We climbed toward a higher tier of the park, past a hockey rink that doubles as a reservoir and a lawn that had been planted over an underground retention chamber. A gust of wind sent tiny pellets of ice into our faces. Leonardsen tightened her scarf and kept moving. The chamber, she explained, allows for the recycling of stormwater, which the city uses to irrigate plantings and clean nearby streets, closing the urban water loop.

Much of the system is invisible to the people who visit the park, but it matters for a warming future in which shortages become part of the problem, too. We passed a playground, a grove of new trees, and an old band shell that the renovation had preserved. “There’s a lot of history here,” she said. “And we didn’t want to come in and destroy everything. The question was how we meet our needs while making sure the people who live here have a place they enjoy.”

The next morning, the snow was still coming down, reducing the colors of Copenhagen to white and gray. A warm fire burned invitingly in my hotel’s lobby, but I was in the city to see how it handles extreme precipitation, so I laced up my boots and trudged across slushy streets to a nature-based design studio called SLA. The elevator was out, which meant taking the stairs.

Near the studio’s entrance, open shelves held labelled glass jars of sand from the firm’s sites—a small archive of textures and hues. Around a coffee table, two designers were figuring out how to excavate a buried creek. In a conference room lined with awards, I sat down with Mette Skjold, the firm’s C.E.O., a fifty-two-year-old architect who has led some of SLA’s most prominent cloudburst work in Copenhagen. We had planned to visit two of the firm’s most celebrated blue-and-green projects. Overnight, the storm had turned both of them white. That morning, she had messaged to confirm: “The weather is demanding slow drive, but is awestraking. Do you need boots or socks?”

Skjold wore a navy cardigan, gray jeans, and black boots. She walked me through the workspace, introducing one of the firm’s biologists, who was sorting insects collected from a project in Abu Dhabi and from a hospital commission in Denmark (“because the bugs tell us a lot about the ecosystem”), and the firm’s cultural geographer, who asked if I’d heard Mayor Zohran Mamdani talking about New York’s “sneckdowns,” the piles of snow that form at road edges during blizzards. We went back down to the street. The sky was clearing. The pavement was not. “This is me,” she said, nodding toward a Mercedes E.V. at a public charger. “Don’t worry,” she added, as she eased out onto the ice. “I’m an excellent driver!”

Our first stop was Grønningen-Bispeparken, a lush five-acre park wedged between two social-housing complexes, one primarily for families, the other

primarily for the elderly. A school and a playground stood at the base of a steep slope. “This used to be a great sheet of grass,” Skjold said. “A void. Rain used to flood through the field, pool here, and sink into the school playground.” The design process took more than five years, a negotiation between the city’s strict hydraulic requirements and the neighborhood’s shifting wishes; the result was something no one had pictured in advance.

As we climbed, snow crunching underfoot, the park’s structure emerged. There were a hundred and forty-nine trees, old and newly planted, in twenty-three varieties. People could move around and play in the dry, open spaces between the trees, but, in the Wet Bio Oases, wooden platforms rose above dense plantings where insects and wildlife have right-of-way. Lawns opened onto larger fields for recreation and neighborhood events. Near the top, mounds built over Cold War civil-defense structures offered city views. But the signature feature was a set of eighteen grass-and-stone basins that gather rain and, on calm days, gather people. SLA calls them “social swales.” Scattered through the park, furnished with picnic tables, they can hold about eight hundred thousand gallons during a storm.

As we made our way to the top, three children—two sisters and a brother—came skittering up behind us, giggling, boots slipping in the snow.

“Do you live near here?” I asked.

“Yes,” they said, with the youngest, an eight-year-old boy, as vocal as his sisters.

“How do you like the park?”

“It’s beautiful!” the older sister said.

“When it rains, the water goes down!” the younger sister added, and I saw Skjold smile.

“We reopened at the end of August, 2024,” she recalled. “The mayor was there. There was a band. It was exactly as it was meant to be. And five days later we had an extreme-rain event. Oh, my God, I was so nervous. We had all these new trees and plants, and I didn’t know what would happen.” But

the park did what it was designed to do. In fact, it looked even better for it; the basins turned into a scattering of small ponds.

In 2025, an international jury awarded SLA the Rosa Barba Prize, one of landscape architecture's most coveted honors, despite the project's modest scale and peripheral address. The prize helped solidify Copenhagen's reputation for ambitious climate adaptation, as has the \$1.8 billion that the city has committed to its cloudburst plan. When I spoke with Leonardsen, though, she tempered the optimism. Copenhagen has still built only a fraction of its three hundred ecological projects; the unbuilt portion includes the green streets and cloudburst boulevards meant to link them into a functioning network. "For this system to fully work, all the individual projects need to be connected, like pearls on a string," she said. For now, the new infrastructure is less a necklace around the city than a handful of gems.

A country like Denmark, where climate change is treated as a present danger and trust in government remains a civic reflex, might be expected to spend lavishly on social infrastructure. The surprise is that there's an American city that has pursued a similar approach, and the greater surprise is that the city is Hoboken, New Jersey, better known as a post-industrial port and bedroom community across the Hudson River from Manhattan.

Hoboken is a dense urban settlement of sixty-five thousand wedged between the river to the east and the three-hundred-foot-tall Palisades to the west. Much of it sits in a shallow bowl, a hardscaped catchment about the size of the West Village. Flooding has always been part of the deal. In the twentieth century, the same storms that made headlines in New York wreaked quieter havoc across the river. In this century, Hoboken's disasters have been vivid enough to make their own news. During Superstorm Sandy, a fourteen-foot surge from the Hudson poured into the city, producing images of National Guardsmen in boats ferrying residents through waist-high water. The water lingered for days and overwhelmed Hoboken's sole operating flood pump. More recently, heavy rain alone has begun to produce the same effect.

On a frigid day not long ago, I met Caleb Stratton in the mayor's office, where he was finishing his term as Hoboken's chief resilience officer. A former college athlete with a sturdy build and a neatly trimmed beard,

Stratton, forty, wears a watch on one wrist and an activity monitor on the other. He has the look of someone who can't stop running scenarios.

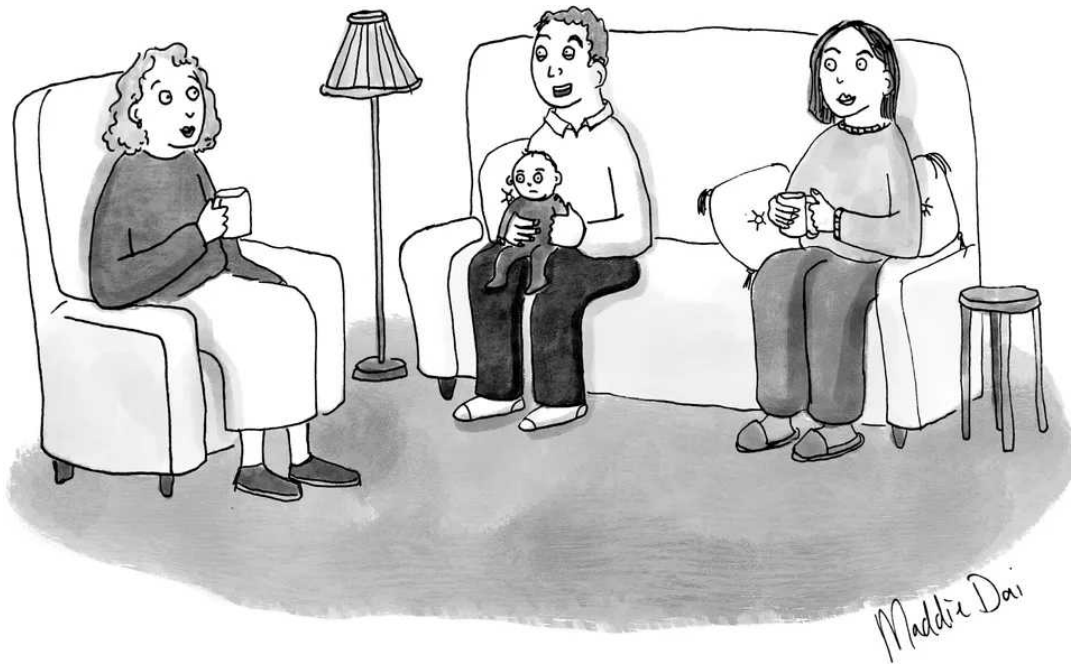
When Stratton first came to city hall, as an intern, in the summer of 2012, Hoboken had no reason to expect an infrastructure overhaul. Then Sandy hit, and the Obama Administration launched Rebuild by Design, a competition that offered roughly a billion dollars in federal money, with more expected from state and local governments, for the winning proposals. The Dutch firm *OMA* submitted a plan called “Resist, Delay, Store, Discharge,” a hybrid system of walls and gates to block storm surge, absorbent landscapes to handle rain, and pumps to empty the system when the pipes fill. Hoboken won two hundred and thirty million dollars through the competition, later secured hundreds of millions in additional funding from the state and from Biden-era programs, and found itself unexpectedly awash in money and expertise. Stratton's job was to make sure that the city used them well.

In the past decade, Hoboken has installed two more high-capacity pumps in low-lying neighborhoods and begun adding storm gates and floodwalls. The city's “resiliency parks,” though, are the system's showpieces, and not only because, as in Copenhagen, they're built to hold water. When *OMA* architects met with residents and community leaders, Stratton told me, they heard as much about a lack of decent playgrounds and public space as they did about flooding. Hoboken didn't want to limit itself to “black-sky infrastructure,” the stuff you need during emergencies. It also wanted “blue-sky infrastructure,” places that would make the city more inviting.

Hoboken's dual-use strategy is on display at ResilienCity Park, a five-acre oasis in a part of town that used to flood whenever it poured. The park has a full-size soccer field, a sunken basketball court that doubles as a reservoir, a long wooden walkway raised above plantings and tall grasses, a community pavilion, a café, and a fifty-thousand-gallon cistern that captures rain for irrigation. There's also a Great Lawn that hosts outdoor movies and neighborhood events, and, beneath it, a million-gallon stormwater tank. The playground would be the envy of children anywhere; Stratton, a father of two, pointed out a water park, a climbing wall, and rope climbing towers.

We warmed ourselves up over lunch at the café. A few young professionals were working remotely, and our table wobbled. Stratton lifted it, carried it

off, and replaced it with a steadier one. As we tucked in, he described “the downstream effect” of the upgrade: parks draw people in, property values rise, businesses and jobs follow. “It all ties together,” he said. Lower flood risk, he added, should also ease insurance costs. “Our flood map will be redrawn when we complete our projects,” he said. “It’s conditional. But if we get there—*when* we get there—that will be a very big deal.”



Before we left, Stratton wanted to show me a facility where, last May, the city installed five new high-capacity pumps that control stormwater discharge from the park and nearby streets. As we approached, we caught a gassy smell. Stratton stopped at a large grate and peered down.

“Can you see the water?” he asked, suddenly alert. “It’s pretty high right now.” He pulled out one of two phones he carries and called the chief sewer engineer for the area. The engineer told him that it was runoff from a commercial corridor a few blocks away, where the city has been raising streets and sidewalks so that stormwater drains toward the park and the pumps. The corridor had just been tied into the new system. What we were smelling was the system working.

Hoboken’s network, like Copenhagen’s, is a work in progress. It has already started to change what a hard rain means, though. In September, 2023, the

remnants of Tropical Storm Ophelia dropped more than two inches in a few hours, the kind of downpour that used to guarantee flooding. This time, the city held. The pumps pulled seventeen million gallons of stormwater off the streets, and the new blue-and-green infrastructure absorbed runoff to alleviate pressure on the pipes. “When the news reporters came to see the damage,” Stratton told me, “we were already open for business.”

Across the Hudson, cloudburst management is a problem of a different order. New York City’s size, density, and patchwork topography make comprehensive protection hard to design and harder to build. Some planners argue for abandoning the low-lying neighborhoods that used to be ponds, creeks, and marshes. The ecologist Eric Sanderson told me that roughly twenty per cent of the city’s land—home to two major airports, nearly a third of the public-housing stock, and about 1.2 million people—sits in what he calls “blue zones,” places that “were wet, are wet, and will be wet in the future.” In his view, New York needs to “restore nature, restore the stream, restore the wetlands.” The housing will have to be replaced by building more densely “someplace else that’s safer, on higher ground.”

Planners call this “managed retreat,” and the idea has begun to shape urban policy. After Sandy, hundreds of homeowners on Staten Island’s shore accepted buyouts through a state program. The city has since explored smaller buyouts in places that flood repeatedly, including the Jewel Streets neighborhood, also known as the Hole, at the Brooklyn-Queens border. But a relocation program for 1.2 million New Yorkers is far too complex and costly for any official to contemplate. For now, the city’s strategy is to build better gray, blue, and green infrastructure in every borough, and to do as much as possible to hold and absorb rain. Eliminating flood risk remains a fantasy. Flattening the curve—making bad floods somewhat less bad—feels achievable.

The climate keeps raising the stakes. Last year, First Street, a Manhattan-based climate-risk group, modelled a “hundred-year” storm—a Category 1 hurricane on a Sandy-like track and rainfall of four inches an hour. In that scenario, Kissena Park, in Queens, could be inundated by more than nineteen feet of stormwater. Yankee Stadium and Bedford-Stuyvesant could get eleven. Ten feet of flooding would cripple highways along Manhattan’s edges and damage vital infrastructure, including transit links to the airports.

The estimated property loss, at twenty billion dollars, would be twice that of Sandy. The human toll would be incalculably steep.

There is a danger, in climate planning, of investing in protection against the previous disaster rather than against the next—the engineer’s version of fighting the last war. In the United States, federal policy encourages the habit, because *FEMA* recovery money tends to favor rebuilding damaged infrastructure over redesigning it. That was visible after Sandy. The storm, which hit the New York area in October, 2012, unlocked billions of dollars in resilience spending, with hurricanes, rather than heat waves or cloudbursts, as the focus. The East Side Coastal Resiliency project, a 2.4-mile flood barrier that doubles as parkland along Manhattan’s Lower East Side, is the city’s largest and costliest climate initiative. The original design, led by the firm *BIG*, imagined a floodable landscape—planted slopes rising from the East River and a grassy berm on the western edge meant to capture storm surge. Engineers judged that version infeasible. The city chose a more muscular solution, raising the park and lifting the river’s edge to form a wall intended to hold back sixteen feet of surge. It also added submerged, deployable tide gates that, when closed, turn sewer outfalls into watertight barriers, keeping river water out of the pipes and wastewater out of the river.

In solving one problem, though, elevated walls and hardened gates can create another: rainfall gets trapped on the streets. The city is building a work-around. I recently walked to the Lower East Side to meet Joseph Leone, a Staten Island-raised civil engineer who manages infrastructure and coastal resilience for the city’s Department of Design and Construction. We met at a construction site under the Williamsburg Bridge that was painfully loud, even by New York standards. He handed me a hard hat and led me to what is currently the largest open drop-pipe manhole in Manhattan—a vertical shaft twenty-six feet across and forty feet deep. Halfway down was a work platform. At the bottom, a river of raw sewage moved north.

“We call this ‘parallel conveyance,’ ” Leone said. The point is to keep eight low-lying pockets of the Lower East Side from turning into basins once the floodgates close. “The bathtub effect would have been a problem back here,” he told me. The system diverts stormwater into a giant tank and then, at Fourteenth Street, pumps it out at up to three hundred and fifty million gallons a day, sending it on to the Newtown Creek wastewater facility. When

the full project is finished, he added, with the pride of a new parent, “a hundred and twenty thousand people will no longer be in the flood zone.”

During a lull in the bridge traffic, I asked which local flood projects had made the biggest difference. “Most Staten Islanders, including myself, love the Bluebelt,” he said, referring to a thirty-five-year-old network of streams, ponds, and wetlands that filters, stores, and slowly releases stormwater across sixteen watersheds at the island’s southern end. The system spans roughly ten thousand acres—about a third of Staten Island—making it the largest such project in the country, and New York’s closest approximation of a landscape-scale intervention.

The Bluebelt takes the rain that falls on it and also accepts runoff piped from street catch basins, routing it through restored topography instead of into the sewers. In storms like Ida, it has proved its value by absorbing hundreds of millions of gallons that otherwise would rush into the combined system and back up into basements and storefronts. The approach has been introduced in other outer boroughs, because with every additional acre the city expands capacity without digging another mile of pipe.

The next day, in Brooklyn, a team from the city’s Department of Environmental Protection walked me through some of the newest green-infrastructure work. At Green-Wood Cemetery, an almost five-hundred-acre burial ground in western Brooklyn that rises and falls along an old push moraine, a nonprofit has partnered with the city on interventions meant to keep stormwater out of sixteen nearby sewersheds during heavy rainfall.

A particularly elegant fix is found in Sylvan Water, a pond within the cemetery. Engineers from the Dutch firm Arcadis installed a water monitor and an outlet-control structure. When the National Weather Service forecasts a major storm, operators draw the pond down, sending water into the combined system before the deluge, while there’s still capacity. The control system, along with permeable pavers and a large underground tank, is expected to keep roughly fifty-five million gallons of stormwater out of the sewers each year.

In flood-prone Gowanus, where wastewater has a tendency to surface on sidewalks and streets during storms, absorbent ground was installed more

than a decade ago in the form of Sponge Park, a rain garden that the landscape architect Susannah Drake created along the canal. Now the neighborhood is changing again. With a hundred and forty-one residential projects in development and twenty thousand new residents projected for the neighborhood by 2035, the city is attempting to reproduce the idea at building scale.

From a bridge over the Gowanus Canal, the D.E.P. team pointed out small sponges quietly softening the neighborhood: planters, gardens, tanks, and densely planted “green roofs.” Since 2022, the city’s Unified Stormwater Rule has required stormwater controls in every large new development. Each building becomes part of the city’s rainfall-capture network. The Dutch go even further, by subsidizing homeowners who add green roofs or pull up pavement so that rain can soak in.

Washington’s commitment has been erratic. In April, 2020, *FEMA* launched the Building Resilient Infrastructure and Communities program, or *BRIC*, after Congress authorized the agency to reserve up to six per cent of estimated disaster-relief spending for pre-disaster resilience. Under the Biden Administration, *FEMA* expanded the program and approved more than three hundred and fifty million dollars for nineteen New York City flood-control projects. In April, 2025, *FEMA* cancelled *BRIC*, calling it “wasteful” and “ineffective.” A federal judge ordered the funding restored that December. In March, 2026, the agency reversed course again, reviving the program and reopening applications.

Meanwhile, New Yorkers have been improvising. A group of residents pushing for better rain infrastructure introduced me to Eric Wiseman, a sixty-one-year-old retired Verizon technician whose home sits where two sloping streets meet in Crown Heights. Wiseman, whose parents bought the house in 1968, has grown so anxious about flooding that, he told me, “I feel like a prisoner in my own home.” He pulled out his phone and showed me photographs of his street underwater, then scrolled to an image of himself in a full-body rainsuit, standing ankle-deep. “I do this every time there’s a rainstorm,” he said. “We know we can’t do nothing about the climate here. But we can do something about the infrastructure.”

From Wiseman's house, I went to East Flatbush to meet Shayla Hamlin, a former federal worker whose three-story home sits in a shallow depression a few lots down from a polluted commercial strip dotted with auto-repair shops and a junkyard. She took me to the garage, where, on October 30th, a surge of wastewater, rodents, feces, and industrial runoff rose three feet in minutes, leaving a stench, along with a high-water mark that has yet to fade. She has borrowed about a hundred thousand dollars for mitigation, but she is reluctant to invest in further upgrades, she said, "because I know it's going to happen again."

Hamlin grew up in the house. Her family has been there for more than forty-six years. She has a three-year-old daughter and a community. Since the most recent flood, however, she has become jumpy. "I've been talking to my parents about just selling the property," she said. "I feel like it's time to cut our ties." She's ready for a new city, where the weather feels less menacing. The problem is finding one. ♦

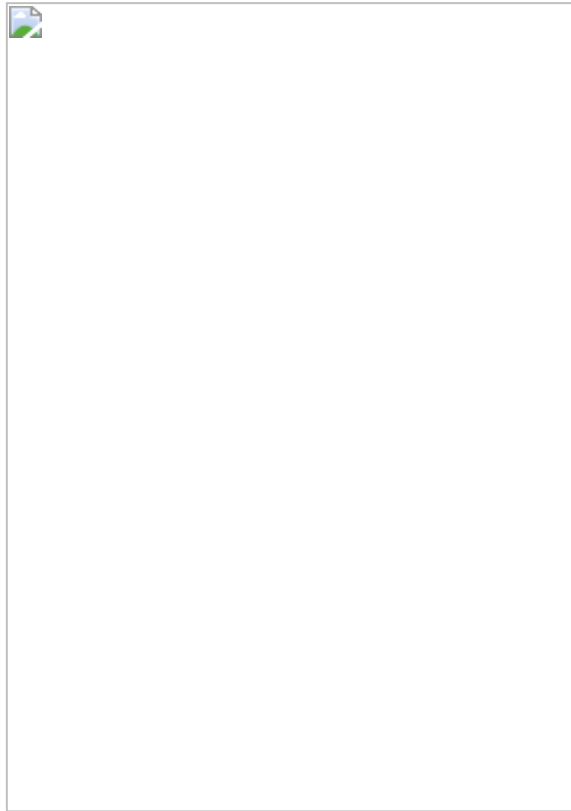
A Reporter at Large

Sam Altman May Control Our Future —Can He Be Trusted?

New interviews and closely guarded documents shed light on the persistent doubts about the head of OpenAI.

By Ronan Farrow, Andrew Marantz

April 06, 2026



In the fall of 2023, Ilya Sutskever, OpenAI's chief scientist, sent secret memos to three fellow-members of the organization's board of directors. For weeks, they'd been having furtive discussions about whether [Sam Altman](#), OpenAI's C.E.O., and Greg Brockman, his second-in-command, were fit to run the company. Sutskever had once counted both men as friends. In 2019, he'd officiated Brockman's wedding, in a ceremony at OpenAI's offices that included a ring bearer in the form of a robotic hand. But as he grew convinced that the company was nearing its long-term goal—creating an artificial intelligence that could rival or surpass the cognitive capabilities of human beings—his doubts about Altman increased. As Sutskever put it to another board member at the time, “I don't think Sam is the guy who should have his finger on the button.”

At the behest of his fellow board members, Sutskever worked with like-minded colleagues to compile some seventy pages of Slack messages and H.R. documents, accompanied by explanatory text. The material included images taken with a cellphone, apparently to avoid detection on company devices. He sent the final memos to the other board members as disappearing messages, to insure that no one else would ever see them. “He was terrified,” a board member who received them recalled. The memos, which we reviewed, have not previously been disclosed in full. They allege that Altman misrepresented facts to executives and board members, and deceived them about internal safety protocols. One of the memos, about Altman, begins with a list headed “Sam exhibits a consistent pattern of . . .” The first item is “Lying.”

Many technology companies issue vague proclamations about improving the world, then go about maximizing revenue. But the founding premise of OpenAI was that it would have to be different. The founders, who included Altman, Sutskever, Brockman, and [Elon Musk](#), asserted that artificial intelligence could be the most powerful, and potentially dangerous, invention in human history, and that perhaps, given the existential risk, an unusual corporate structure would be required. The firm was established as a nonprofit, whose board had a duty to prioritize the safety of humanity over the company's success, or even its survival. The C.E.O. had to be a person of uncommon integrity. According to Sutskever, “any person working to build this civilization-altering technology bears a heavy burden and is taking on unprecedented responsibility.” But “the people who end up in these kinds

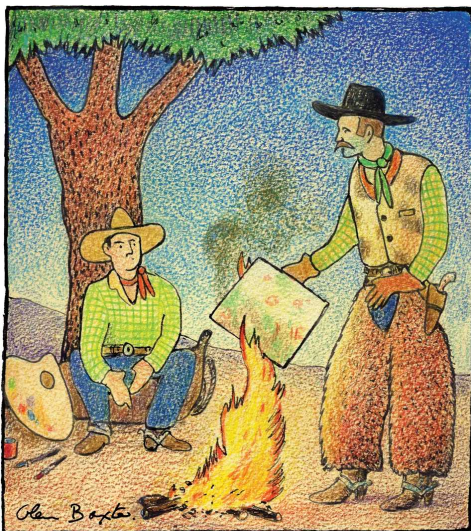
of positions are often a certain kind of person, someone who is interested in power, a politician, someone who likes it.” In one of the memos, he seemed concerned with entrusting the technology to someone who “just tells people what they want to hear.” If OpenAI’s C.E.O. turned out not to be reliable, the board, which had six members, was empowered to fire him. Some members, including Helen Toner, an A.I.-policy expert, and Tasha McCauley, an entrepreneur, received the memos as a confirmation of what they had already come to believe: Altman’s role entrusted him with the future of humanity, but he could not be trusted.

Altman was in Las Vegas, attending a Formula 1 race, when Sutskever invited him to a video call with the board, then read a brief statement explaining that he was no longer an employee of OpenAI. The board, following legal advice, released a public message saying only that Altman had been removed because he “was not consistently candid in his communications.” Many of OpenAI’s investors and executives were shocked. Microsoft, which had invested some thirteen billion dollars in OpenAI, learned of the plan to fire Altman just moments before it happened. “I was very stunned,” Satya Nadella, Microsoft’s C.E.O., later said. “I couldn’t get anything out of anybody.” He spoke with the LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman, an OpenAI investor and a Microsoft board member, who began calling around to determine whether Altman had committed a clear offense. “I didn’t know what the fuck was going on,” Hoffman told us. “We were looking for embezzlement, or sexual harassment, and I just found nothing.”

Other business partners were similarly blindsided. When Altman called the investor Ron Conway to say that he’d been fired, Conway held up his phone to Representative Nancy Pelosi, with whom he was having lunch. “You better get out of here really quick,” she told Conway. OpenAI was on the verge of closing a large investment from Thrive, a venture-capital firm founded by Josh Kushner, Jared Kushner’s brother, whom Altman had known for years. The deal would value OpenAI at eighty-six billion dollars and allow many employees to cash out millions in equity. Kushner emerged from a meeting with Rick Rubin, the music producer, to a missed call from Altman. “We just immediately went to war,” Kushner later said.

The day that Altman was fired, he flew back to his twenty-seven-million-dollar mansion in San Francisco, which has panoramic views of the bay and once featured a cantilevered infinity pool, and set up what he called a “sort of government-in-exile.” Conway, the Airbnb co-founder Brian Chesky, and the famously aggressive crisis-communications manager Chris Lehane joined, sometimes for hours a day, by video and phone. Some members of Altman’s executive team camped out in the hallways of the house. Lawyers set up in a home office next to his bedroom. During bouts of insomnia, Altman would wander by them in his pajamas. When we spoke with Altman recently, he described the aftermath of his firing as “just this weird fugue.”

With the board silent, Altman’s advisers built a public case for his return. Lehane has insisted that the firing was a [coup](#) orchestrated by rogue “effective altruists”—adherents of a [belief system](#) that focusses on maximizing the well-being of humanity, who had come to see A.I. as an existential threat. (Hoffman told Nadella that the firing might be due to “effective-altruism craziness.”) Lehane—whose reported motto, after Mike Tyson, is “Everyone has a game plan until you punch them in the mouth”—urged Altman to wage an aggressive social-media campaign. Chesky stayed in contact with the tech journalist Kara Swisher, relaying criticism of the board.



THE TRAIL BOSS WAS ALWAYS THERE
FOR US, AND MORE THAN HAPPY TO
SHARE HIS CANDID OPINION OF MY
LATEST WATERCOLORS.

Altman interrupted his “war room” at six o’clock each evening with a round of Negronis. “You need to chill,” he recalls saying. “Whatever’s gonna happen is gonna happen.” But, he added, his phone records show that he was on calls for more than twelve hours a day. At one point, Altman conveyed to Mira Murati, who had given Sutskever material for his memos and was serving as the interim C.E.O. of OpenAI in that period, that his allies were “going all out” and “finding bad things” to damage her reputation, as well as those of others who had moved against him, according to someone with knowledge of the conversation. (Altman does not recall the exchange.)

Within hours of the firing, Thrive had put its planned investment on hold and suggested that the deal would be consummated—and employees would thus receive payouts—only if Altman returned. Texts from this period show Altman coördinating closely with Nadella. (“how about: satya and my top priority remains to save openai,” Altman suggested, as the two worked on a statement. Nadella proposed an alternative: “to ensure OpenAI continues to thrive.”) Microsoft soon announced that it would create a competing initiative for Altman and any employees who left OpenAI. A public letter demanding his return circulated at the organization. Some people who hesitated to sign it received imploring calls and messages from colleagues. A majority of OpenAI employees ultimately threatened to leave with Altman.

The board was backed into a corner. “Control Z, that’s one option,” Toner said—undo the firing. “Or the other option is the company falls apart.” Even Murati eventually signed the letter. Altman’s allies worked to win over Sutskever. Brockman’s wife, Anna, approached him at the office and pleaded with him to reconsider. “You’re a good person—you can fix this,” she said. Sutskever later explained, in a court deposition, “I felt that if we were to go down the path where Sam would not return, then OpenAI would be destroyed.” One night, Altman took an Ambien, only to be awakened by his husband, an Australian coder named Oliver Mulherin, who told him that Sutskever was wavering, and that people were telling Altman to speak with the board. “I woke up in this, like, crazy Ambien haze, and I was so disoriented,” Altman told us. “I was, like, I cannot talk to the board right now.”

In a series of increasingly tense calls, Altman demanded the resignations of board members who had moved to fire him. “I have to pick up the pieces of

their mess while I'm in this crazy cloud of suspicion?" Altman recalled initially thinking, about his return. "I was just, like, Absolutely fucking not." Eventually, Sutskever, Toner, and McCauley lost their board seats. Adam D'Angelo, a founder of Quora, was the sole original member who remained. As a condition of their exit, the departing members demanded that the allegations against Altman—including that he pitted executives against one another and concealed his financial entanglements—be investigated. They also pressed for a new board that could oversee the outside inquiry with independence. But the two new members, the former Harvard president Lawrence Summers and the former Facebook C.T.O. Bret Taylor, were selected after close conversations with Altman. "would you do this," Altman texted Nadella. "bret, larry summers, adam as the board and me as ceo and then bret handles the investigation." (McCauley later testified in a deposition that when Taylor was previously considered for a board seat she'd had concerns about his deference to Altman.)

Less than five days after his firing, Altman was reinstated. Employees now call this moment "the Blip," after an incident in the Marvel films in which characters disappear from existence and then return, unchanged, to a world profoundly altered by their absence. But the debate over Altman's trustworthiness has moved beyond OpenAI's boardroom. The colleagues who facilitated his ouster accuse him of a degree of deception that is untenable for any executive and dangerous for a leader of such a transformative technology. "We need institutions worthy of the power they wield," Murati told us. "The board sought feedback, and I shared what I was seeing. Everything I shared was accurate, and I stand behind all of it." Altman's allies, on the other hand, have long dismissed the accusations. After the firing, Conway texted Chesky and Lehané demanding a public-relations offensive. "This is REPUTATIONAL TO SAM," he wrote. He told the *Washington Post* that Altman had been "mistreated by a rogue board of directors."

OpenAI has since become one of the most valuable companies in the world. It is reportedly preparing for an initial public offering at a potential valuation of a trillion dollars. Altman is driving the construction of a staggering amount of A.I. infrastructure, some of it concentrated within foreign autocracies. OpenAI is securing sweeping government contracts, setting

standards for how A.I. is used in immigration enforcement, domestic surveillance, and autonomous weaponry in war zones.

Altman has promoted OpenAI's growth by touting a vision in which, he wrote in a 2024 blog post, "astounding triumphs—fixing the climate, establishing a space colony, and the discovery of all of physics—will eventually become commonplace." His rhetoric has helped sustain one of the fastest cash burns of any startup in history, relying on partners that have borrowed vast sums. The U.S. economy is increasingly dependent on a few highly leveraged A.I. companies, and many experts—at times including Altman—have warned that the industry is in a bubble. "Someone is going to lose a phenomenal amount of money," he told reporters last year. If the bubble pops, economic catastrophe may follow. If his most bullish projections prove correct, he may become one of the wealthiest and most powerful people on the planet.

In a tense call after Altman's firing, the board pressed him to acknowledge a pattern of deception. "This is just so fucked up," he said repeatedly, according to people on the call. "I can't change my personality." Altman says that he doesn't recall the exchange. "It's possible I meant something like 'I do try to be a unifying force,' " he told us, adding that this trait had enabled him to lead an immensely successful company. He attributed the criticism to a tendency, especially early in his career, "to be too much of a conflict avoider." But a board member offered a different interpretation of his statement: "What it meant was 'I have this trait where I lie to people, and I'm not going to stop.' " Were the colleagues who fired Altman motivated by alarmism and personal animus, or were they right that he couldn't be trusted?

One morning this winter, we met Altman at OpenAI's headquarters, in San Francisco, for one of more than a dozen conversations with him for this story. The company had recently moved into a pair of eleven-story glass towers, one of which had been occupied by Uber, another tech behemoth, whose co-founder and C.E.O., Travis Kalanick, seemed like an unstoppable prodigy—until he resigned, in 2017, under pressure from investors, who cited concerns about his ethics. (Kalanick now runs a robotics startup; in his free time, he said recently, he uses OpenAI's ChatGPT "to get to the edge of what's known in quantum physics.")

An employee gave us a tour of the office. In an airy space full of communal tables, there was an animated digital painting of the computer scientist Alan Turing; its eyes tracked us as we passed. The installation is a winking reference to the Turing test, the 1950 thought experiment about whether a machine can credibly imitate a person. (In a 2025 study, ChatGPT passed the test more reliably than actual humans did.) Typically, you can interact with the painting. But the sound had been disabled, our guide told us, because it wouldn't stop eavesdropping on employees and then butting into their conversations. Elsewhere in the office, plaques, brochures, and merchandise displayed the words "Feel the AGI." The phrase was originally associated with Sutskever, who used it to caution his colleagues about the risks of artificial general intelligence—the threshold at which machines match human cognitive capacities. After the Blip, it became a cheerful slogan hailing a superabundant future.

We met Altman in a generic-looking conference room on the eighth floor. "People used to tell me about decision fatigue, and I didn't get it," Altman told us. "Now I wear a gray sweater and jeans every day, and even picking which gray sweater out of my closet—I'm, like, I wish I didn't have to think about that." Altman has a youthful appearance—he is slender, with wide-set blue eyes and tousled hair—but he is now forty, and he and Mulherin have a one-year-old son, delivered by a surrogate. "I'm sure, like, being President of the United States would be a much more stressful job, but of all the jobs that I think I could reasonably do, this is the most stressful one I can imagine," he said, making eye contact with one of us, then with the other. "The way that I've explained this to my friends is: 'This was the most fun job in the world until the day we launched ChatGPT.' We were making these massive scientific discoveries—I think we did the most important piece of scientific discovery in, I don't know, many decades." He cast his eyes down. "And then, since the launch of ChatGPT, the decisions have gotten very difficult."

Altman grew up in Clayton, Missouri, an affluent suburb of St. Louis, as the eldest of four siblings. His mother, Connie Gibstine, is a dermatologist; his father, Jerry Altman, was a real-estate broker and a housing activist. Altman attended a Reform synagogue and a private preparatory school that he has described as "not the kind of place where you would really stand up and talk about being gay." In general, though, the family's wealthy suburban circles

were relatively liberal. When Altman was sixteen or seventeen, he said, he was out late in a predominantly gay neighborhood in St. Louis and was subjected to a brutal physical attack and homophobic slurs. Altman did not report the incident, and he was reluctant to give us more details on the record, saying that a fuller telling would “make me look like I’m manipulative or playing for sympathy.” He dismissed the idea that this event, and his sexuality broadly, was significant to his identity. But, he said, “probably that has, like, some deep-seated psychological thing—that I think I’m over but I’m not—about not wanting more conflict.”

Altman’s attitude in childhood, his brother told *The New Yorker*, in 2016, was “I have to win, and I’m in charge of everything.” He went to Stanford, where he attended regular off-campus poker games. “I think I learned more about life and business from that than I learned in college,” he later said.

All Stanford students are ambitious, but many of the most enterprising among them drop out. The summer after his sophomore year, Altman went to Massachusetts to join the inaugural batch of entrepreneurs at Y Combinator, a “startup incubator” co-founded by the renowned software engineer Paul Graham. Each entrant joined Y.C. with an idea for a startup. (Altman’s batch mates included founders of Reddit and Twitch.) Altman’s project, eventually called Loopt, was a proto social network that used the locations of people’s flip phones to tell their friends where they were. The company reflected his drive, and a tendency to interpret ambiguous situations to his advantage. Federal rules required that phone carriers be able to track the locations of phones for emergency services; Altman struck deals with carriers to tap these capabilities for the company’s use.

kitchen,” Graham told *The New Yorker*. “And he smiled, like, *it worked*. I had never seen an uncontrolled smile from Sam. It was like when you throw a ball of paper into the wastebasket across the room—that smile.”

Altman’s new role made him, at twenty-eight, a kingmaker. His job was to select the hungriest and most promising entrepreneurs, connect them with the best coders and investors, and help them develop their startups into industry-defining monopolies (while Y.C. took a six- or seven-per-cent cut). Altman oversaw a period of aggressive expansion, growing Y.C.’s roster of startups from dozens to hundreds. But several Silicon Valley investors came to believe that his loyalties were divided. An investor told us that Altman was known to “make personal investments, selectively, into the best companies, blocking outside investors.” (Altman denies blocking anyone.) Altman had worked as a “scout” for the investment fund Sequoia Capital, as part of a program that involved investing in early-stage startups and taking a small cut of any profits. When Altman made an angel investment in Stripe, a financial-services startup, he insisted on a bigger portion, galling Sequoia’s partners, a person familiar with the deal said. The person added, “It’s a policy of ‘Sam first.’ ” Altman is an investor in, by his own estimate, some four hundred other companies. (Altman denies this characterization of the Stripe deal. Around 2010, he made an initial investment of fifteen thousand dollars in Stripe, a two-per-cent share. The company is now valued at more than a hundred and fifty billion dollars.)

By 2018, several Y.C. partners were so frustrated with Altman’s behavior that they approached Graham to complain. Graham and Jessica Livingston, his wife and a Y.C. founder, apparently had a frank conversation with Altman. Afterward, Graham started telling people that although Altman had agreed to leave the company, he was resisting in practice. Altman told some Y.C. partners that he would resign as president but become chairman instead. In May, 2019, a blog post announcing that Y.C. had a new president came with an asterisk: “Sam is transitioning to Chairman of YC.” A few months later, the post was edited to read “Sam Altman stepped away from any formal position at YC”; after that, the phrase was removed entirely. Nevertheless, as recently as 2021, a Securities and Exchange Commission filing listed Altman as the chairman of Y Combinator. (Altman says that he wasn’t aware of this until much later.)

Altman has maintained over the years, both in public and in recent depositions, that he was never fired from Y.C., and he told us that he did not resist leaving. Graham has tweeted that “we didn’t want him to leave, just to choose” between Y.C. and OpenAI. In a statement, Graham told us, “We didn’t have the legal power to fire anyone. All we could do was apply moral pressure.” In private, though, he has been unambiguous that Altman was removed because of Y.C. partners’ mistrust. This account of Altman’s time at Y Combinator is based on discussions with several Y.C. founders and partners, in addition to contemporaneous materials, all of which indicate that the parting was not entirely mutual. On one occasion, Graham told Y.C. colleagues that, prior to his removal, “Sam had been lying to us all the time.”

In May, 2015, Altman e-mailed Elon Musk, then the hundredth-richest person in the world. Like many prominent Silicon Valley entrepreneurs, Musk was preoccupied by an array of threats that he considered existentially urgent but which would have struck most people as far-fetched hypotheticals. “We need to be super careful with AI,” he tweeted. “Potentially more dangerous than nukes.”

Altman had generally been a techno-optimist, but his rhetoric about A.I. soon turned [apocalyptic](#). In public, and in his private correspondence with Musk and others, he warned that the technology should not be dominated by a profit-seeking mega-corporation. “Been thinking a lot about whether it’s possible to stop humanity from developing AI,” he wrote to Musk. “If it’s going to happen anyway, it seems like it would be good for someone other than Google to do it first.” Picking up on the analogy to nuclear weapons, he proposed a “Manhattan Project for AI.” He outlined the overarching principles that such an organization would have—“safety should be a first-class requirement”; “obviously we’d comply with/aggressively support all regulation”—and he and Musk settled on a name: OpenAI.

Unlike the original Manhattan Project, a government initiative that led to the creation of the atom bomb, OpenAI would be privately funded, at least at first. Altman predicted that an artificial superintelligence—a theoretical threshold beyond even A.G.I., at which machines would fully eclipse the capabilities of the human mind—would eventually create enough economic benefits to “capture the light cone of all future value in the universe.” But he

also warned of existential danger. At some point, the national-security implications could grow so dire that the U.S. government would have to take control of OpenAI, perhaps by nationalizing it and moving its operations to a secure bunker in the desert. By late 2015, Musk was persuaded. “We should say that we are starting with a \$1B funding commitment,” he wrote. “I will cover whatever anyone else doesn’t provide.”

Altman housed OpenAI in Y Combinator’s nonprofit arm, framing it as an internal philanthropic project. He gave OpenAI recruits Y.C. stock and moved donations through Y.C. accounts. At one point, the lab was supported by a Y.C. fund in which he held a personal stake. (Altman later described this stake as insignificant. He told us that the Y.C. stock he gave to recruits was his own.)

The Manhattan Project analogy applied to employee recruitment, too. Like nuclear-fission research, machine learning was a small scientific field with epochal implications which was dominated by a cadre of eccentric geniuses. Musk and Altman, along with Brockman, who joined from Stripe, were convinced that there were only a few computer scientists alive capable of making the required breakthroughs. Google had a huge cash advantage and a multiyear head start. “We are outmanned and outgunned by a ridiculous margin,” Musk later wrote in an e-mail. But “if we are able to attract the most talented people over time and our direction is correctly aligned, then OpenAI will prevail.”

A top recruiting target was Sutskever, an intense and introverted researcher who was often called the most gifted A.I. scientist of his generation. Sutskever, who was born in the Soviet Union in 1986, has a receding hairline, dark eyes, and a habit of pausing, unblinking, while choosing his words. Another target was Dario Amodei, a biophysicist and a font of frenetic energy who has a tendency to nervously twist his black hair, and responds to one-line e-mails with multi-paragraph essays. Both had lucrative jobs elsewhere, but Altman lavished them with attention. He later joked, “I stalked Ilya.”

Musk was the bigger name, but Altman had the smoother touch. He e-mailed Amodei, and they set up a one-on-one dinner at an Indian restaurant. (Altman: “fuck my uber got in a crash! running about 10 late.” Amodei:

“Wow, hope you’re ok.”) Like many A.I. researchers, Amodei believed that the technology should be built only if it was shown to be “aligned” with human values, meaning that it would act in accordance with what people wanted without making a potentially fatal error—say, following an instruction to clean up the environment by eliminating its greatest polluter, the human race. Altman was reassuring, mirroring these safety concerns.

Amodei, who later joined the company, took detailed notes on Altman and Brockman’s behavior for years, under the heading “My Experience with OpenAI” (subheading: “Private: Do Not Share”). A collection of more than two hundred pages of documents related to Amodei, including those notes and internal e-mails and memos, has been circulated by colleagues in Silicon Valley but never before disclosed publicly. In his notes, Amodei wrote that Altman’s goal was to build “an AI lab that would be focused on safety (‘maybe not right away, but as soon as it can be’).”

In December, 2015, hours before OpenAI was publicly announced, Altman e-mailed Musk about a rumor that Google was “going to give everyone in openAI massive counteroffers tomorrow to try to kill it.” Musk replied, “Has Ilya come back with a solid yes?” Altman assured him that Sutskever was holding firm. Google offered Sutskever six million dollars a year, which OpenAI couldn’t come close to matching. But, Altman boasted, “they unfortunately don’t have ‘do the right thing’ on their side.”



Musk provided some office space for OpenAI in a former suitcase factory in the Mission District of San Francisco. The pitch to employees, Sutskever told us, was “You’re going to save the world.”

If everything went right, the OpenAI founders believed, artificial intelligence could usher in a post-scarcity utopia, [automating](#) grunt work, curing cancer, and liberating people to enjoy lives of leisure and abundance. But if the technology went rogue, or fell into the wrong hands, the devastation could be total. China could use it to build a novel bioweapon or a fleet of advanced drones; an A.I. model could outmaneuver its overseers, replicating itself on secret servers so that it couldn’t be turned off; in extreme cases, it might seize control of the energy grid, the stock market, or the nuclear arsenal. Not everyone believed this, to say the least, but Altman repeatedly affirmed that he did. He wrote on his blog in 2015 that superhuman machine intelligence “does not have to be the inherently evil sci-fi version to kill us all. A more probable scenario is that it simply doesn’t care about us much either way, but in an effort to accomplish some other goal . . . wipes us out.” OpenAI’s founders vowed not to privilege speed over safety, and the organization’s articles of incorporation made benefitting humanity a legally binding duty. If A.I. was going to be the most powerful technology in history, it followed that any individual with sole control over

it stood to become uniquely powerful—a scenario that the founders referred to as an “AGI dictatorship.”

Altman told early recruits that OpenAI would remain a pure nonprofit, and programmers took significant pay cuts to work there. The company accepted charitable grants, including thirty million dollars from what was then called Open Philanthropy, a hub of the effective-altruism movement whose commitments included supporting the distribution of mosquito nets to the global poor.

Brockman and Sutskever managed OpenAI’s daily operations, while Musk and Altman, still busy with their other jobs, stopped by around once a week. By September, 2017, though, Musk had grown impatient. During discussions about whether to reconstitute OpenAI as a for-profit company, he demanded majority control. Altman’s replies varied depending on the context. His main consistent demand seems to have been that if OpenAI were reorganized under the control of a C.E.O. that job should go to him. Sutskever seemed uncomfortable with this idea. He sent Musk and Altman a long, plaintive e-mail on behalf of himself and Brockman, with the subject line “Honest Thoughts.” He wrote, “The goal of OpenAI is to make the future good and to avoid an AGI dictatorship.” He continued, addressing Musk, “So it is a bad idea to create a structure where you could become a dictator.” He relayed similar concerns to Altman: “We don’t understand why the CEO title is so important to you. Your stated reasons have changed, and it’s hard to really understand what’s driving it.”

“Guys, I’ve had enough,” Musk replied. “Either go do something on your own or continue with OpenAI as a nonprofit”—otherwise “I’m just being a fool who is essentially providing free funding for you to create a startup.” He quit, acrimoniously, five months later. (In 2023, he founded a for-profit competitor called xAI. The following year, he sued Altman and OpenAI for fraud and breach of charitable trust, alleging that he had been “assiduously manipulated” by “Altman’s long con”—that Altman had preyed on his concerns about the dangers of A.I. in order to separate him from his money. The suit, which OpenAI has vigorously contested, is ongoing.)

After Musk’s departure, Amodei and other researchers chafed against the leadership of Brockman, whom some considered an abrasive operator, and

of Sutskever, who was generally viewed as principled but disorganized. In the process of becoming C.E.O., Altman seems to have made different promises to different factions at the company. He assured some researchers that Brockman's managerial authority would be diminished. But, unbeknownst to them, he also struck a secret handshake deal with Brockman and Sutskever: Altman would get the C.E.O. title; in exchange, he agreed to resign if the other two deemed it necessary. (He disputed this characterization, saying he took the C.E.O. role only because he was asked to. All three men confirmed that the pact existed, though Brockman said that it was informal. "He unilaterally told us that he'd step down if we ever both asked him to," he told us. "We objected to this idea, but he said it was important to him. It was purely altruistic.") Later, the board was alarmed to learn that its C.E.O. had essentially appointed his own shadow board.

Internal records show that the founders had private doubts about the nonprofit structure as early as 2017. That year, after Musk tried to take control, Brockman wrote in a diary entry, "cannot say that we are committed to the non-profit . . . if three months later we're doing b-corp then it was a lie." Amodei, in one of his early notes, recalled pressing Brockman on his priorities and Brockman replying that he wanted "money and power." Brockman disputes this. His diary entries from this time suggest conflicting instincts. One reads, "Happy to not become rich on this, so long as no one else is." In another, he asks, "So what do I **really** want?" Among his answers is "Financially what will take me to \$1B."

In 2017, Sutskever was in the office when he read a paper that Google researchers had just published, proposing "a new simple network architecture, the Transformer." He jumped out of his chair, ran down the hall, and told his fellow-researchers, "Stop everything you're doing. This is it." The Transformer, Sutskever saw, was an innovation that might enable OpenAI to train vastly more sophisticated models. Out of this discovery came the first generative pre-trained transformer—the seed of what would become ChatGPT.

As the technology became increasingly powerful, we learned, about a dozen of OpenAI's top engineers held a series of secret meetings to discuss whether OpenAI's founders, including Brockman and Altman, could be trusted. At one, an employee was reminded of a sketch by the British

comedy duo Mitchell and Webb, in which a Nazi soldier on the Eastern Front, in a moment of clarity, asks, “Are we the baddies?”

By 2018, Amodei had started questioning the founders’ motives more openly. “Everything was a rotating set of schemes to raise money,” he later wrote in his notes. “I felt like what OpenAI needed was a clear statement of what it would do, what it would not do, and how its existence would make the world better.” OpenAI already had a mission statement: “To ensure that artificial general intelligence benefits all of humanity.” But it wasn’t clear to Amodei what this meant to the executives, if it meant anything at all. In early 2018, Amodei has said, he started drafting a charter for the company and, in weeks of conversations with Altman and Brockman, advocated for its most radical clause: if a “value-aligned, safety-conscious project” came close to building an A.G.I. before OpenAI did, the company would “stop competing with and start assisting this project.” According to the “merge and assist” clause, as it was called, if, say, Google’s researchers figured out how to build a safe A.G.I. first, then OpenAI could wind itself down and donate its resources to Google. By any normal corporate logic, this was an insane thing to promise. But OpenAI was not supposed to be a normal company.

That premise was tested in the spring of 2019, when OpenAI was negotiating a billion-dollar investment from Microsoft. Although Amodei, who was leading the company’s safety team, had helped to pitch the deal to Bill Gates, many people on the team were anxious about it, fearing that Microsoft would insert provisions that overrode OpenAI’s ethical commitments. Amodei presented Altman with a ranked list of safety demands, placing the preservation of the merge-and-assist clause at the very top. Altman agreed to that demand, but in June, as the deal was closing, Amodei discovered that a provision granting Microsoft the power to block OpenAI from any mergers had been added. “Eighty per cent of the charter was just betrayed,” Amodei recalled. He confronted Altman, who denied that the provision existed. Amodei read it aloud, pointing to the text, and ultimately forced another colleague to confirm its existence to Altman directly. (Altman doesn’t remember this.) Amodei’s notes describe escalating tense encounters, including one, months later, in which Altman summoned him and his sister, Daniela, who worked in safety and policy at the company, to tell them that he had it on “good authority” from a senior

executive that they had been plotting a coup. Daniela, the notes continue, “lost it,” and brought in that executive, who denied having said anything. As one person briefed on the exchange recalled, Altman then denied having made the claim. “I didn’t even say that,” he said. “You just said that,” Daniela replied. (Altman said that this was not quite his recollection, and that he had accused the Amodeis only of “political behavior.”) In 2020, Amodei, Daniela, and other colleagues left to found Anthropic, which is now one of OpenAI’s chief rivals.

Altman continued touting OpenAI’s commitment to safety, especially when potential recruits were within earshot. In late 2022, four computer scientists published a paper motivated in part by concerns about “deceptive alignment,” in which sufficiently advanced models might pretend to behave well during testing and then, once deployed, pursue their own goals. (It’s one of several A.I. scenarios that sound like science fiction—but, under certain experimental conditions, it’s already happening.) Weeks after the paper was published, one of its authors, a Ph.D. student at the University of California, Berkeley, got an e-mail from Altman, who said that he was increasingly worried about the threat of unaligned A.I. He added that he was thinking of committing a billion dollars to the issue, which many A.I. experts considered the most important unsolved problem in the world, potentially by endowing a prize to incentivize researchers around the world to study it. Although the graduate student had “heard vague rumors about Sam being slippery,” he told us, Altman’s show of commitment won him over. He took an academic leave to join OpenAI.

But, in the course of several meetings in the spring of 2023, Altman seemed to waver. He stopped talking about endowing a prize. Instead, he advocated for establishing an in-house “superalignment team.” An official announcement, referring to the company’s reserves of computing power, pledged that the team would get “20% of the compute we’ve secured to date”—a resource potentially worth more than a billion dollars. The effort was necessary, according to the announcement, because, if [alignment](#) remained unsolved, A.G.I. might “lead to the disempowerment of humanity or even human extinction.” Jan Leike, who was appointed to lead the team with Sutskever, told us, “It was a pretty effective retention tool.”

The twenty-per-cent commitment evaporated, however. Four people who worked on or closely with the team said that the actual resources were between one and two per cent of the company's compute. Furthermore, a researcher on the team said, "most of the superalignment compute was actually on the oldest cluster with the worst chips." The researchers believed that superior hardware was being reserved for profit-generating activities. (OpenAI disputes this.) Leike complained to Murati, then the company's chief technology officer, but she told him to stop pressing the point—the commitment had never been realistic.



Around this time, a former employee told us, Sutskever “was getting super safety-pilled.” In the early days of OpenAI, he had considered concerns about catastrophic risk legitimate but remote. Now, as he came to believe that A.G.I. was imminent, his worries grew more acute. There was an all-hands meeting, the former employee continued, “where Ilya gets up and he’s, like, Hey, everyone, there’s going to be a point in the next few years where basically everyone at this company has to switch to working on safety, or else we’re fucked.” But the superalignment team was dissolved the following year, without completing its mission.

By then, internal messages show, executives and board members had come to believe that Altman’s omissions and deceptions might have ramifications

for the safety of OpenAI's products. In a meeting in December, 2022, Altman assured board members that a variety of features in a forthcoming model, GPT-4, had been approved by a safety panel. Toner, the board member and A.I.-policy expert, requested documentation. She learned that the most controversial features—one that allowed users to “fine-tune” the model for specific tasks, and another that deployed it as a personal assistant—had not been approved. As McCauley, the board member and entrepreneur, left the meeting, an employee pulled her aside and asked if she knew about “the breach” in India. Altman, during many hours of briefing with the board, had neglected to mention that Microsoft had released an early version of ChatGPT in India without completing a required safety review. “It just was kind of completely ignored,” Jacob Hilton, an OpenAI researcher at the time, said.

Although these lapses did not cause security crises, Carroll Wainwright, another researcher, said that they were part of a “continual slide toward emphasizing products over safety.” After the release of GPT-4, Leike e-mailed members of the board. “OpenAI has been going off the rails on its mission,” he wrote. “We are prioritizing the product and revenue above all else, followed by AI capabilities, research and scaling, with alignment and safety coming third.” He continued, “Other companies like Google are learning that they should deploy faster and ignore safety problems.”

McCauley, in an e-mail to her fellow-members, wrote, “I think we’re definitely at a point where the board should be increasing its level of scrutiny.” The board members tried to confront what they viewed as a mounting problem, but they were outmatched. “You had a bunch of J.V. people who’ve never done anything, to be blunt,” Sue Yoon, a former board member, said. In 2023, the company was preparing to release its GPT-4 Turbo model. As Sutskever details in the memos, Altman apparently told Murati that the model didn’t need safety approval, citing the company’s general counsel, Jason Kwon. But when she asked Kwon, over Slack, he replied, “ugh . . . confused where sam got that impression.” (A representative for OpenAI, where Kwon remains an executive, said that the matter was “not a big deal.”)

Soon afterward, the board made its decision to fire Altman—and then the world watched as Altman reversed it. A version of the OpenAI charter is still

on the organization's website. But people familiar with OpenAI's governing documents said that it has been diluted to the point of meaninglessness. Last June, on his personal blog, Altman wrote, referring to artificial superintelligence, "We are past the event horizon; the takeoff has started." This was, according to the charter, arguably the moment when OpenAI might stop competing with other companies and start working with them. But in that post, called "The Gentle Singularity," he adopted a new tone, replacing existential terror with ebullient optimism. "We'll all get better stuff," he wrote. "We will build ever-more-wonderful things for each other." He acknowledged that the alignment problem remained unsolved, but he redefined it—rather than being a deadly threat, it was an inconvenience, like the algorithms that tempt us to waste time scrolling on Instagram.

Altman is often described, either with reverence or with suspicion, as the greatest pitchman of his generation. Steve Jobs, one of his idols, was said to project a "reality-distortion field"—an unassailable confidence that the world would conform to his vision. But even Jobs never told his customers that if they didn't buy his brand of MP3 player everyone they loved would die. When Altman was twenty-three, in 2008, Graham, his mentor, wrote, "You could parachute him into an island full of cannibals and come back in 5 years and he'd be the king." This judgment was based not on Altman's track record, which was modest, but on his will to prevail, which Graham considered almost ungovernable. When advised not to include Y.C. alumni on a list of the world's top startup founders, Graham put Altman on it anyway. "Sam Altman can't be stopped by such flimsy rules," he wrote.

Graham meant this as a compliment. But some of Altman's closest colleagues came to have a different view of this quality. After Sutskever grew more distressed about A.I. safety, he compiled the memos about Altman and Brockman. They have since taken on a legendary status in Silicon Valley; in some circles, they are simply called the Ilya Memos. Meanwhile, Amodei was continuing to assemble notes. These and the other documents related to him chart his shift from cautious idealism to alarm. His language is more heated than Sutskever's, by turns incensed at Altman—"His words were almost certainly bullshit"—and wistful about what he says was a failure to correct OpenAI's course.

Neither collection of documents contains a smoking gun. Rather, they recount an accumulation of alleged deceptions and manipulations, each of which might, in isolation, be greeted with a shrug: Altman purportedly offers the same job to two people, tells contradictory stories about who should appear on a live stream, dissembles about safety requirements. But Sutskever concluded that this kind of behavior “does not create an environment conducive to the creation of a safe AGI.” Amodei and Sutskever were never close friends, but they reached similar conclusions. Amodei wrote, “The problem with OpenAI is Sam himself.”

We have interviewed more than a hundred people with firsthand knowledge of how Altman conducts business: current and former OpenAI employees and board members; guests and staffers at Altman’s various houses; his colleagues and competitors; his friends and enemies and several people who, given the mercenary culture of Silicon Valley, have been both. (OpenAI has an agreement with Condé Nast, the owner of *The New Yorker*, which allows OpenAI to display its content in search results for a limited term.)

Some people defended Altman’s business acumen and dismissed his rivals, especially Sutskever and Amodei, as failed aspirants to his throne. Others portrayed them as gullible, absent-minded scientists, or as hysterical “[doomers](#),” gripped by the delusion that the software they were building would somehow come alive and kill them. Yoon, the former board member, argued that Altman was “not this Machiavellian villain” but merely, to the point of “fecklessness,” able to convince himself of the shifting realities of his sales pitches. “He’s too caught up in his own self-belief,” she said. “So he does things that, if you live in the real world, make no sense. But he doesn’t live in the real world.”

Yet most of the people we spoke to shared the judgment of Sutskever and Amodei: Altman has a relentless will to power that, even among industrialists who put their names on spaceships, sets him apart. “He’s unconstrained by truth,” the board member told us. “He has two traits that are almost never seen in the same person. The first is a strong desire to please people, to be liked in any given interaction. The second is almost a sociopathic lack of concern for the consequences that may come from deceiving someone.”

The board member was not the only person who, unprompted, used the word “sociopathic.” One of Altman’s batch mates in the first Y Combinator cohort was [Aaron Swartz](#), a brilliant but troubled coder who died by suicide in 2013 and is now remembered in many tech circles as something of a sage. Not long before his death, Swartz expressed concerns about Altman to several friends. “You need to understand that Sam can never be trusted,” he told one. “He is a sociopath. He would do anything.” Multiple senior executives at Microsoft said that, despite Nadella’s long-standing loyalty, the company’s relationship with Altman has become fraught. “He has misrepresented, distorted, renegotiated, reneged on agreements,” one said. Earlier this year, OpenAI reaffirmed Microsoft as the exclusive cloud provider for its “stateless”—or memoryless—models. That day, it announced a fifty-billion-dollar deal making Amazon the exclusive reseller of its enterprise platform for A.I. agents. While reselling is permitted, Microsoft executives argue OpenAI’s plan could collide with Microsoft’s exclusivity. (OpenAI maintains that the Amazon deal will not violate the earlier contract; a Microsoft representative said the company is “confident that OpenAI understands and respects” its legal obligations.) The senior executive at Microsoft said, of Altman, “I think there’s a small but real chance he’s eventually remembered as a Bernie Madoff- or Sam Bankman-Fried-level scammer.”

Altman is not a technical savant—according to many in his orbit, he lacks extensive expertise in coding or machine learning. Multiple engineers recalled him misusing or confusing basic technical terms. He built OpenAI, in large part, by harnessing other people’s money and technical talent. This doesn’t make him unique. It makes him a businessman. More remarkable is his ability to convince skittish engineers, investors, and a tech-skeptical public that their priorities, even when mutually exclusive, are also his priorities. When such people have tried to hinder his next move, he has often found the words to neutralize them, at least temporarily; usually, by the time they lose patience with him, he’s got what he needs. “He sets up structures that, on paper, constrain him in the future,” Wainwright, the former OpenAI researcher, said. “But then, when the future comes and it comes time to be constrained, he does away with whatever the structure was.”

“He’s unbelievably persuasive. Like, Jedi mind tricks,” a tech executive who has worked with Altman said. “He’s just next level.” A classic hypothetical

scenario in alignment research involves a contest of wills between a human and a high-powered A.I. In such a contest, researchers usually argue, the A.I. would surely win, much the way a grandmaster will beat a child at chess. Watching Altman outmaneuver the people around him during the Blip, the executive continued, had been like watching “an A.G.I. breaking out of the box.”



MOSES DECIDING WHOM TO TRUST

In the days after his firing, Altman fought to avoid any outside investigation of the claims against him. He told two people that he worried even the existence of an investigation would make him look guilty. (Altman denies this.) But, after the resigning board members made their departure conditional on there being an independent inquiry, Altman acceded to a “review” of “recent events.” The two new board members insisted that they control that review, according to people involved in the negotiations. Summers, with his network of political and Wall Street connections, seemed to lend it credibility. (Last November, after the disclosure of e-mails in which Summers sought Jeffrey Epstein’s advice while pursuing a romantic relationship with a young protégée, he resigned from the board.) OpenAI enlisted WilmerHale, the distinguished law firm responsible for the internal investigations of Enron and WorldCom, to conduct the review.

Six people close to the inquiry alleged that it seemed designed to limit transparency. Some of them said that the investigators initially did not contact important figures at the company. An employee reached out to Summers and Taylor to complain. “They were just interested in the narrow range of what happened during the board drama, and not the history of his integrity,” the employee recalled of his interview with investigators. Others were uncomfortable sharing concerns about Altman because they felt there was not a sufficient effort to insure anonymity. “Everything pointed to the fact that they wanted to find the outcome, which is to acquit him,” the employee said. (Some of the lawyers involved defended the process, saying, “It was an independent, careful, comprehensive review that followed the facts wherever they led.” Taylor also said that the review was “thorough and independent.”)

Corporate investigations aim to confer legitimacy. At private companies, their findings are sometimes not written down—this can be a way to limit liability. But in cases involving public scandals there is often a greater expectation of transparency. Before Kalanick left Uber, in 2017, its board hired an outside firm, which released a thirteen-page summary to the public. Given OpenAI’s 501(c)(3) status and the high-profile nature of the firing, many executives there expected to see extensive findings. In March, 2024, however, OpenAI announced that it would clear Altman but released no report. The company provided, on its website, some eight hundred words acknowledging a “breakdown in trust.”

People involved in the investigation said that no report was released because none was written. Instead, the findings were limited to oral briefings, shared with Summers and Taylor. “The review did not conclude that Sam was a George Washington cherry tree of integrity,” one of the people close to the inquiry said. But the investigation appears not to have centered the questions of integrity behind Altman’s firing, devoting much of its focus to a hunt for clear criminality; on that basis, it concluded that he could remain as C.E.O. Shortly thereafter, Altman, who had been kicked off the board when he was fired, rejoined it. The decision not to put the report in writing was made in part on the advice of Summers’s and Taylor’s personal attorneys, the person close to the inquiry told us. (Summers declined to comment on the record. Taylor said that, in light of the oral briefings, there had been “no need for a formal written report.”)

Many former and current OpenAI employees told us that they were shocked by the lack of disclosure. Altman said he believed that all the board members who joined in the aftermath of his reinstatement received the oral briefings. “That’s an absolute, outright lie,” a person with direct knowledge of the situation said. Some board members told us that ongoing questions about the integrity of the report could prompt, as one put it, “a need for another investigation.”

The absence of a written record helped minimize the allegations. So, increasingly, did Altman’s stature in Silicon Valley. Multiple prominent investors who have worked with Altman told us that he has a reputation for freezing out investors if they back OpenAI’s competitors. “If they invest in something that he doesn’t like, they won’t get access to other things,” one of them said. Another source of Altman’s power is his vast list of investments, which at times extends to his personal life. He has financial entanglements with numerous former romantic partners: as a fund co-manager, a lead investor, or a frequent co-investor. This is hardly unusual. Many of Silicon Valley’s straight executives do the same thing with their romantic and sexual partners. (“You have to,” one prominent C.E.O. told us.) “I’ve obviously invested with some exes after the fact. And I think that’s, like, totally fine,” Altman said. But the dynamic affords an extraordinary level of control. “It creates a very, very high dependence, essentially,” a person close to Altman said. “Oftentimes, it’s a lifetime dependence.”

Even former colleagues can be affected. Murati left OpenAI in 2024 and began building her own A.I. startup. Josh Kushner, the close Altman ally, called her. He praised her leadership, then made what seemed to be a veiled threat, noting that he was “concerned about” her “reputation” and that former colleagues now viewed her as an “enemy.” (Kushner, through a representative, said that this account did not “convey full context”; Altman said that he was unaware of the call.)

At the beginning of his tenure as C.E.O., Altman had announced that OpenAI would create a “capped profit” company, which would be owned by the nonprofit. This byzantine corporate structure apparently did not exist until Altman devised it. In the midst of the conversion, a board member named Holden Karnofsky objected to it, arguing that the nonprofit was being severely undervalued. “I can’t do that in good faith,” Karnofsky, who is

Amodei's brother-in-law, said. According to contemporaneous notes, he voted against it. However, after an attorney for the board said that his dissent "might be a flag to investigate further" the legitimacy of the new structure, his vote was recorded as an abstention, apparently without his consent—a potential falsification of business records. (OpenAI told us that several employees recall Karnofsky abstaining, and provided the minutes from the meeting recording his vote as an abstention.)

Last October, OpenAI "recapitalized" as a for-profit entity. The firm touts its associated nonprofit, now called the OpenAI Foundation, as one of the "best resourced" in history. But it is now a twenty-six-per-cent stakeholder of the company, and its board members are also, with one exception, members of the for-profit board.

During congressional testimony, Altman was asked if he made "a lot of money." He replied, "I have no equity in OpenAI . . . I'm doing this because I love it"—a careful answer, given his indirect equity through the Y.C. fund. This is still technically true. But several people, including Altman, indicated to us that it could soon change. "Investors are, like, I need to know you're gonna stick with this when times get hard," Altman said, but added that there was no "active discussion" about it. According to a legal deposition, Brockman seems to own a stake in the company that is worth about twenty billion dollars. Altman's share would presumably be worth more. Still, he told us that he was not primarily motivated by wealth. A former employee recalls him saying, "I don't care about money. I care more about power."

In 2023, Altman married Mulherin in a small ceremony at a home they own in Hawaii. (They'd met nine years prior, late at night in Peter Thiel's hot tub.) They have hosted a range of guests at the property, and those we spoke with reported witnessing nothing more remarkable than the standard diversions of the very wealthy: meals prepared by a private chef, boat rides at golden hour. One New Year's party was "Survivor"-themed; a photograph shows a number of shirtless, smiling men, and also Jeff Probst, the real host of "Survivor." Altman has also hosted smaller groups of friends at his properties, gatherings that have included, in at least one instance, a spirited game of strip poker. (A photograph of the event, which did not include Altman, leaves unclear who won, but at least three men clearly lost.) We

spoke to many of Altman's former guests who suggested only that he is a generous host.

Nevertheless, rumors about Altman's personal life have been exploited and distorted by competitors. Ruthless business rivalries are nothing new, but the competition within the A.I. industry has become extraordinarily cutthroat. ("Shakespearean" was the word an OpenAI executive used to describe it to us, adding, "The normal rules of the game sort of don't apply anymore.") Intermediaries directly connected to, and in at least one case compensated by, Musk have circulated dozens of pages of detailed opposition research about Altman. They reflect extensive surveillance, documenting shell companies associated with him, the personal contact information of close associates, and even interviews about a purported sex worker, conducted at gay bars. One of the Musk intermediaries claimed that Altman's flights and the parties he attended were being tracked. Altman told us, "I don't think anyone has had more private investigators hired against them."

Extreme claims have circulated. The right-wing broadcaster Tucker Carlson suggested, without any apparent proof, that Altman was involved in the death of a whistle-blower. This claim and others have been amplified by rivals. Altman's sister, Annie, claimed in a lawsuit, and in interviews with us, that he sexually abused her for years, beginning when she was three and he was twelve. (We could not substantiate Annie's account, which Altman has denied and his brothers and mother have called "utterly untrue" and a source of "immense pain to our entire family." In interviews that the journalist Karen Hao conducted for her book, "[Empire of AI](#)," Annie suggested that memories of abuse were recovered during flashbacks in adulthood.)

Multiple people working within rival companies and investment firms insinuated to us that Altman sexually pursues minors—a narrative persistent in Silicon Valley which appears to be untrue. We spent months looking into the matter, conducting dozens of interviews, and could find no evidence to support it. "This is disgusting behavior from a competitor that I assume is part of an attempt at tainting the jury in our upcoming cases," Altman told us. "As ridiculous as this is to have to say, any claims about me having sex with a minor, hiring sex workers, or being involved in a murder are

completely untrue.” He added that he was “sort of grateful” that we had spent months “so aggressively trying to look into this.”



Altman has acknowledged dating younger men of legal age. We spoke to several of his partners, who told us that they did not find this problematic. Yet the opposition dossiers from Musk intermediaries spin it as a line of attack. (The dossiers include salacious and unsubstantiated references to a “Twink Army” and “Sugar Daddy’s Sexual Habits.”) “I think there’s a lot of homophobia that gets pushed,” Altman said. Swisher, the tech journalist, agreed. “All these rich guys do wild stuff, wilder than anything I’ve been told about Sam,” she told us. “But he’s a gay guy in San Francisco,” she added, “so that gets weaponized.”

For a decade, social-media executives promised that they could change the world with little or no downside. They dismissed the lawmakers who wanted to slow them down as mere Luddites, eventually earning bipartisan derision. Altman, by contrast, came across as refreshingly conscientious. Rather than warding off regulation, he practically begged for it. Testifying before the Senate Judiciary Committee in 2023, he proposed a new federal agency to oversee advanced A.I. models. “If this technology goes wrong, it can go quite wrong,” he said. Senator John Kennedy, of Louisiana, known for his cantankerous exchanges with tech C.E.O.s, seemed charmed, resting his face

on his hand and suggesting that perhaps Altman should enforce the rules himself.

But, as Altman publicly welcomed regulation, he quietly lobbied against it. In 2022 and 2023, according to *Time*, OpenAI successfully pressed to dilute a European Union effort that would have subjected large A.I. companies to more oversight. In 2024, a bill was introduced in the California state legislature mandating safety testing for A.I. models. Its provisions included measures resembling the ones that Altman had advocated for in his congressional testimony. OpenAI publicly opposed the bill but in private began issuing threats. “I would say that, over the course of the year, we saw increasingly cunning, deceptive behavior from OpenAI,” a legislative aide told us.

Conway, the investor, lobbied state political leaders, including Nancy Pelosi and Gavin Newsom, to kill the bill. In the end, it passed the legislature with bipartisan support, but Newsom vetoed it. This year, congressional candidates who favor A.I. regulations have faced opponents funded by Leading the Future, a new “pro-A.I.” super *PAC* devoted to scuttling such restrictions. OpenAI’s official stance is that it will not contribute to such super *PACs*. “This issue transcends partisan politics,” Lehane recently told CNN. And yet one of the major donors to Leading the Future is Greg Brockman, who has committed fifty million dollars. (This year, Brockman and his wife donated twenty-five million dollars to *MAGA Inc.*, a pro-Trump super *PAC*.)

OpenAI’s campaign has extended beyond traditional lobbying. Last year, a successor bill was introduced in the California Senate. One night, Nathan Calvin, a twenty-nine-year-old lawyer who worked at the nonprofit Encode and had helped craft the bill, was at home having dinner with his wife when a process server arrived to deliver a subpoena from OpenAI. The company claimed to be hunting for evidence that Musk was covertly funding its critics. But it demanded all of Calvin’s private communications about the bill in the state Senate. “They could have asked us, ‘Have you ever talked to or been given money by Elon Musk?’—which we haven’t,” Calvin told us. Other supporters of the bill, and some critics of OpenAI’s for-profit restructuring, also received subpoenas. “They were going after folks to basically scare them into shutting up,” Don Howard, who heads a charity

called the James Irvine Foundation, said. (OpenAI claims that this was part of the standard legal process.)

Altman has long supported Democrats. “I’m very suspicious of powerful autocrats telling a story of fear to gang up on the weak,” he told us. “That’s a Jewish thing, not a gay thing.” In 2016, he endorsed Hillary Clinton and called Trump “an unprecedented threat to America.” In 2020, he donated to the Democratic Party and to the Biden Victory Fund. During the Biden Administration, Altman met with the White House at least half a dozen times. He helped develop a lengthy executive order laying out the first federal regime of safety tests and other guardrails for A.I. When Biden signed it, Altman called it a “good start.”

In 2024, with Biden’s poll numbers slipping, Altman’s rhetoric began to shift. “I believe that America is going to be fine no matter what happens in this election,” he said. After Trump won, Altman donated a million dollars to his inaugural fund, then took selfies with the influencers Jake and Logan Paul at the Inauguration. On X, in his standard lowercase style, Altman wrote, “watching @potus more carefully recently has really changed my perspective on him (i wish i had done more of my own thinking . . .).” Trump, on his first day back in office, repealed Biden’s executive order on A.I. “He’s found an effective way for the Trump Administration to do his bidding,” a senior Biden Administration official said, of Altman.

Musk continues to excoriate Altman in public, calling him “Scam Altman” and “Swindly Sam.” (When Altman complained on X about a Tesla he’d ordered, Musk replied, “You stole a non-profit.”) And yet, in Washington, Altman seems to have outflanked him. Musk spent more than two hundred and fifty million dollars to help Trump get reelected, and worked in the White House for months. Then Musk left Washington, damaging his relationship with Trump in the process.

Altman is now one of Trump’s favored tycoons, even accompanying him on a trip to visit the British Royal Family at Windsor Castle. Altman and Trump speak a few times a year. “You can just, like, call him,” Altman said. “This is not a buddy. But, yeah, if I need to talk to him about something, I will.” When Trump hosted a dinner with tech leaders at the White House last year, Musk was notably absent; Altman sat across from the President. “Sam,

you're a big leader," Trump said. "You told me things before that are absolutely unbelievable."

Over the years, Altman has continued to compare the quest for A.G.I. to the Manhattan Project. Like J. Robert Oppenheimer, who used impassioned appeals about saving the world from the Nazis to persuade physicists to uproot their lives and move to Los Alamos, Altman leverages fears about the geopolitical stakes of his technology. Depending on the audience, Altman has used this analogy to encourage either acceleration or caution. In a meeting with U.S. intelligence officials in the summer of 2017, he claimed that China had launched an "A.G.I. Manhattan Project," and that OpenAI needed billions of dollars of government funding to keep pace. When pressed for evidence, Altman said, "I've heard things." It was the first of several meetings in which he made the claim. After one of them, he told an intelligence official that he would follow up with evidence. He never did. The official, after looking into the China project, concluded that there was no evidence that it existed: "It was just being used as a sales pitch." (Altman says that he does not recall describing Beijing's efforts in exactly that way.)

With more safety-conscious audiences, Altman invoked the analogy to imply the opposite: that A.G.I. had to be pursued carefully, with international coordination, lest the consequences be disastrous. In 2017, Amodei hired Page Hedley, a former public-interest lawyer, to be OpenAI's policy and ethics adviser. In an early PowerPoint presentation to executives, Hedley outlined how OpenAI might avert a "catastrophic" arms race—perhaps by building a coalition of A.I. labs that would eventually coordinate with an international body akin to *NATO*, to insure that the technology was deployed safely. As Hedley recalled it, Brockman didn't understand how this would help the company beat its competitors. "No matter what I said," Hedley told us, "Greg kept going back to 'So how do we raise more money? How do we win?'" According to several interviews and contemporaneous records, Brockman offered a counterproposal: OpenAI could enrich itself by playing world powers—including China and Russia—against one another, perhaps by starting a bidding war among them. According to Hedley, the thinking seemed to be, It worked for nuclear weapons, why not for A.I.?

He was aghast: "The premise, which they didn't dispute, was 'We're talking about potentially the most destructive technology ever invented—what if we

sold it to Putin?’ ” (Brockman maintains that he never seriously entertained auctioning A.I. models to governments. “Ideas were batted around at a high level about what potential frameworks might look like to encourage cooperation between nations—something akin to an International Space Station for AI,” an OpenAI representative said. “Attempting to characterize it as anything more than that is utterly ridiculous.”)

Brainstorming sessions often produce outlandish ideas. Hedley hoped that this one, which came to be known internally as the “countries plan,” would be dropped. Instead, according to several people involved and to contemporaneous documents, OpenAI executives seemed to grow only more excited about it. Brockman’s goal, according to Jack Clark, OpenAI’s policy director at the time, was to “set up, basically, a prisoner’s dilemma, where all of the nations need to give us funding,” and that “implicitly makes not giving us funding kind of dangerous.” A junior researcher recalled thinking, as the plan was detailed at a company meeting, “This is completely fucking insane.”

Executives discussed the approach with at least one potential donor. But later that month, after several employees talked about quitting, the plan was abandoned. Altman “would lose staff,” Hedley said. “I feel like that was always something that had more weight in Sam’s calculations than ‘This is not a good plan because it might cause a war between great powers.’ ”



Undeterred by the collapse of the countries plan, Altman pursued variations on the theme. In January, 2018, he convened an “A.G.I. weekend” at the Hotel Bel-Air, an Old Hollywood resort with rolling gardens of pink bougainvillea and an artificial pond stocked with real swans. The attendees included [Nick Bostrom](#), a philosopher, then at Oxford, who had become a prophet of A.I. doom; Omar Al Olama, an Emirati sultan and an A.I. booster; and at least seven billionaires. The safety-concerned among them were told that this would be an opportunity to think through how society might prepare for the disruptive arrival of artificial general intelligence; the investors arrived expecting to hear pitches.

The days were spent in a sleek conference room, where guests gave talks. (Hoffman, the LinkedIn co-founder, expounded on the possibilities of encoding A.I. with Buddhist compassion.) The final presenter was Altman, armed with a pitch deck that described a global cryptocurrency “redeemable for the attention of the AGI.” Once the A.G.I. was maximally useful, and “anti-evil,” people everywhere would clamor to buy time on OpenAI’s servers. Amodei wrote in his notes, “This idea was absurd on its face (would Vladimir Putin end up owning some of the tokens? . . .) In retrospect this was one of many red flags about Sam that I should have taken more seriously.” The plan seemed like a cash grab, but Altman sold it as a boon for A.I. safety. One of his slides read, “I want to get as many people on the

‘good’ team as possible, and win, and do the right thing.” Another read, “Please hold your laughter until the end of the presentation.”

Altman’s fund-raising pitch has evolved over the years, but it has always reflected the fact that the development of A.G.I. requires a staggering amount of capital. He was following a relatively simple “scaling law”: the more data and computing power you used to train the models, the smarter they seemed to get. The specialized chips that enable this process are enormously expensive. OpenAI, in its most recent funding round alone, raised more than a hundred and twenty billion dollars—the largest private round in history, and a sum four times larger than the biggest I.P.O. ever. “When you think about entities with a hundred billion dollars they can discretionarily spend per year, there really are only a handful in the world,” a tech executive and investor told us. “There’s the U.S. government, and the four or five biggest U.S. tech companies, and the Saudis, and the Emiratis—that’s basically it.”

Altman’s initial focus was Saudi Arabia. He first met Mohammed bin Salman, the country’s crown prince and de-facto monarch, in 2016, at a dinner at San Francisco’s Fairmont Hotel. After that, Hedley recalled, Altman referred to the prince as “a friend.” In September, 2018, according to Hedley’s notes, Altman said, “I’m trying to decide if we would ever take tens of billions from the Saudi PIF,” or public investment fund.

The following month, a hit squad, reportedly acting on bin Salman’s orders, strangled Jamal Khashoggi, a *Washington Post* journalist who had been critical of the regime, and used a bone saw to dismember his corpse. A week later, it was announced that Altman had joined the advisory board for Neom, a “city of the future” that bin Salman hoped to build in the desert. “Sam, you cannot be on this board,” Clark, the policy director, who now works at Anthropic, recalled telling Altman. He initially defended his involvement, telling Clark that Jared Kushner had assured him that the Saudis “didn’t do this.” (Altman does not recall this. Kushner says that they were not in contact at the time.)

As bin Salman’s role became increasingly clear, Altman left the Neom board. Yet behind the scenes, a policy consultant from whom Altman sought advice recalled, he treated the situation as a temporary setback, asking

whether he could somehow still get money from bin Salman. “The question was not ‘Is this a bad thing or not?’ ” the consultant said. “But, just, ‘What would the consequences be if we did it? Would there be some export-control issue? Would there be sanctions? Like, can I get away with it?’ ”

By then, Altman was already eyeing another source of cash: the United Arab Emirates. The country was in the midst of a fifteen-year effort to transform itself from an oil state to a tech hub. The project was overseen by Sheikh Tahnoon bin Zayed al-Nahyan, the President’s brother and the nation’s spymaster. Tahnoon runs the state-controlled A.I. conglomerate G42, and controls \$1.5 trillion in sovereign wealth. In June, 2023, Altman visited Abu Dhabi, meeting with Olama and other officials. In remarks at a government-backed function, he said that the country had “been talking about A.I. since before it was cool,” and outlined a vision for the future of A.I. with the Middle East in a “central role.”

Fund-raising from Gulf states has become customary for many large businesses. But Altman was pursuing a more sweeping geopolitical vision. In the fall of 2023, he began quietly recruiting new talent for a plan—eventually known as ChipCo—in which Gulf states would provide tens of billions of dollars for the construction of huge microchip foundries and data centers, some to be situated in the Middle East. Altman pitched Alexandr Wang, now the head of A.I. at Meta, on a leadership role, telling him that Jeff Bezos, the founder of Amazon, could head the new company. Altman sought enormous contributions from the Emiratis. “My understanding was that this whole thing happened without any board knowledge,” the board member said. A researcher Altman tried to recruit for the project, James Bradbury, recalled turning him down. “My initial reaction was ‘This is gonna work, but I don’t know if I want it to work,’ ” he said.

A.I. capacity may soon displace oil or enriched uranium as the resource that dictates the global balance of power. Altman has said that computing power is “the currency of the future.” Normally, it might not matter where a data center was situated. But many American national-security officials were anxious about concentrating advanced A.I. infrastructure in Gulf autocracies. The U.A.E.’s telecommunications infrastructure is heavily dependent on hardware from Huawei, a Chinese tech giant linked to the government, and the U.A.E. has reportedly leaked American technology to

Beijing in the past. Intelligence agencies worried that advanced U.S. microchips sent to the Emiratis could be used by Chinese engineers. Data centers in the Middle East are also more vulnerable to military strikes; in recent weeks, Iran has bombed American data centers in Bahrain and the U.A.E. And, hypothetically, a Gulf monarchy could commandeer an American-owned data center and use it to build disproportionately powerful models—a version of the “AGI dictatorship” scenario, but in an actual dictatorship.

After Altman’s firing, the person he relied on most was Chesky, the Airbnb co-founder and one of Altman’s fiercest loyalists. “Watching my friend stare into the abyss like that, it made me question some fundamental things about what it means to really run a company,” Chesky told us. The following year, at a gathering of Y Combinator alumni, he gave an impromptu talk, which ended up lasting two hours. “It felt like a group-therapy session,” he said. The upshot was: Your instincts for how to run the company that you started are the best instincts, and anyone who tells you otherwise is gaslighting you. “You’re not crazy, even though people who work for you tell you you are,” Chesky said. Paul Graham, in a blog post about the speech, gave this defiant attitude a name: Founder Mode.

Since the Blip, Altman has been in Founder Mode. In February, 2024, the *Wall Street Journal* published a description of Altman’s vision for ChipCo. He conceived of it as a joint entity funded by an investment of five to seven trillion dollars. (“fk it why not 8,” he tweeted.) This was how many employees learned about the plan. “Everyone was, like, ‘Wait, what?’ ” Leike recalled. Altman insisted at an internal meeting that safety teams had been “looped in.” Leike sent a message urging him not to falsely suggest that the effort had been approved.

During the Biden Administration, Altman explored getting a security clearance to join classified A.I.-policy discussions. But staffers at the RAND Corporation, which helped coordinate the process, expressed concern. “He has been actively raising ‘hundreds of billions of dollars’ from foreign governments,” one of them wrote. “The UAE recently gifted him a car. (I assume it was a very nice car.)” The staffer continued, “The only person I can think of who ever went thru the process with this magnitude of foreign financial ties is Jared Kushner, and the adjudicators recommended that he

not be granted a clearance.” Altman ultimately withdrew from the process. “He was pushing these transactional relationships, primarily with the Emiratis, that raised a lot of red flags for some of us,” a senior Administration official involved in talks with Altman told us. “A lot of people in the Administration did not trust him a hundred per cent.”

When we asked Altman about gifts from Tahnoun, he said, “I’m not gonna say what gifts he has given me specifically. But he and other world leaders . . . have given me gifts.” He added, “We have a standard policy, which applies to me as well, which is that every gift from any potential business partner is disclosed to the company.” Altman has at least two [hypercars](#): an all-white Koenigsegg Regera, worth about two million dollars, and a red McLaren F1, worth about twenty million dollars. In 2024, Altman was spotted driving the Regera through Napa. A few seconds of video made its way onto social media: Altman in a low-slung bucket seat, peering out the window of a gleaming white machine. A tech investor aligned with Musk posted the footage on X, writing, “I’m starting a nonprofit next.”

In 2024, Altman took two OpenAI employees to visit Sheikh Tahnoun on his two-hundred-and-fifty-million-dollar superyacht, the Maryah. One of the largest such vessels in the world, the Maryah has a helipad, a night club, a movie theatre, and a beach club. Altman’s employees apparently stood out amid Tahnoun’s armed security detail, and at least one later told colleagues that he found the experience disconcerting. Altman, on X, later referred to Tahnoun as a “dear personal friend.”



Altman continued to meet with the Biden Administration, which had enacted a policy requiring White House approval for the export of sensitive technology. Multiple Administration officials emerged from these meetings nervous about Altman's ambitions in the Middle East. He often made grandiose claims, according to those officials, including calling A.I. "the new electricity." In 2018, he said that OpenAI was planning to buy a fully functioning quantum computer from a company called Rigetti Computing. This was news even to other OpenAI executives in the room. Rigetti was not yet close to being able to sell a usable quantum computer. In a meeting, Altman claimed that by 2026 an extensive network of nuclear-fusion reactors across the United States would power the A.I. boom. The senior Administration official said, "We were, like, 'Well, that's, you know, news, if they made nuclear fusion work.' " The Biden Administration ultimately withheld approval. "We're not going to be building advanced chips in the U.A.E.," a leader at the Department of Commerce told Altman.

Four days before Trump's Inauguration, the *Wall Street Journal* reported, Tahnoun paid half a billion dollars to the Trump family in exchange for a stake in its cryptocurrency company. The following day, Altman held a twenty-five-minute call with Trump, during which they discussed announcing a version of a ChipCo, timed so that Trump could take credit for it. On Trump's second day in office, Altman stood in the Roosevelt Room

and announced Stargate, a five-hundred-billion-dollar joint venture that aims to build a vast network of A.I. infrastructure across the U.S.

In May, the Administration rescinded Biden's export restrictions on A.I. technology. Altman and Trump travelled to the Saudi royal court to meet with bin Salman. Around the same time, the Saudis advertised the launch of a giant state-backed A.I. firm in the kingdom, with billions to spend on international partnerships. About a week later, Altman laid out a plan for Stargate to expand into the U.A.E. The company plans to build a data-center campus in Abu Dhabi which is seven times larger than Central Park and consumes roughly as much electrical power as the city of Miami. "The truth of this is, we're building portals from which we're genuinely summoning aliens," a former OpenAI executive said. "The portals currently exist in the United States and China, and Sam has added one in the Middle East." He went on, "I think it's just, like, wildly important to get how scary that should be. It's the most reckless thing that has been done."

The erosion of safety commitments has become an industry norm. The founding premise of Anthropic was that, given the right structure and leadership, it could keep safety commitments from disintegrating under commercial pressure. One such commitment was a "responsible scaling policy," which obligated Anthropic to stop training more powerful models if it could not demonstrate that they were safe. In February, as the firm secured thirty billion dollars in new funding, it weakened that pledge. In some respects, Anthropic still [emphasizes safety](#) more than OpenAI does. But Clark, the former policy director, has said, "The system of capital markets says, Go faster." He added, "The world gets to make this decision, not companies." Last year, Amodei sent a memo to Anthropic employees, disclosing that the firm would seek investments from the United Arab Emirates and Qatar and acknowledging that this would likely enrich "dictators." (Like many authors, we are both parties in a class-action lawsuit alleging that Anthropic used our books without our permission to train its models. Condé Nast has opted into a settlement agreement with Anthropic regarding the company's use of certain books published by Condé Nast and its subsidiaries.)

In 2024, Anthropic partnered with Palantir, one of Silicon Valley's most hawkish defense contractors, pushing its A.I. model, [Claude](#), directly into

the military ecosystem. Anthropic became the only A.I. contractor used in the Pentagon's most classified settings. Last year, the Pentagon awarded the company a further two-hundred-million-dollar contract. In January, the U.S. military launched a midnight raid that captured the Venezuelan President, Nicolás Maduro. According to the *Wall Street Journal*, Claude was used in the classified operation.

But tensions arose between Anthropic and the government. Years earlier, OpenAI had deleted from its policies a blanket ban on using its technology for “military and warfare.” Eventually, Anthropic's rivals—including Google and xAI—agreed to provide their models to the military for “all lawful purposes.” Anthropic, whose policies bar it from enabling fully autonomous weapons or domestic mass surveillance, resisted on these points, slowing negotiations for an overhauled deal. On a Tuesday in late February, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth summoned Amodei to the Pentagon and delivered an ultimatum: the firm had until 5:01 *P.M.* that Friday to abandon those prohibitions. The day before the deadline, Amodei declined to do so. Hegseth tweeted that he would designate Anthropic a “supply-chain risk”—a devastating blacklist historically reserved for companies, like Huawei, that have ties to foreign adversaries—and made good on the threat days later.

Hundreds of employees at OpenAI and Google signed an open letter titled “We Will Not Be Divided,” defending Anthropic. In an internal memo, Altman wrote that the dispute was “an issue for the whole industry,” and claimed that OpenAI shared Anthropic's ethical boundaries. But Altman had been in negotiations with the Pentagon for at least two days. Emil Michael, the Under-Secretary of Defense for Research and Engineering, had contacted Altman as he sought replacements for Anthropic. “I needed to hurry and find alternatives,” Michael recalled. “I called Sam, and he was willing to jump. I think he's a patriot.” Altman asked Michael, “What can I do for the country?” It appears that he already knew the answer. OpenAI lacked the security accreditation required for the classified systems in which Anthropic's technology was embedded. But a fifty-billion-dollar deal, announced that Friday morning, integrated OpenAI's technology into Amazon Web Services, a key part of the Pentagon's digital infrastructure. That night, Altman announced on X that the military would now be using OpenAI's models.

By some measures, Altman's maneuver has not hindered the company's success. The day he announced the deal, a new funding round increased OpenAI's value by a hundred and ten billion dollars. But many users deleted the ChatGPT app. At least two senior employees departed—one for Anthropic. At a staff meeting, Altman chastised employees who raised concerns. "So maybe you think the Iran strike was good and the Venezuela invasion was bad," he said. "You don't get to weigh in on that."

Several executives connected to OpenAI have expressed ongoing reservations about Altman's leadership and floated Fidji Simo, who was formerly the C.E.O. of Instacart and now serves as OpenAI's C.E.O. for AGI Deployment, as a successor. Simo herself has privately said that she believes Altman may eventually step down, a person briefed on a recent discussion told us. (Simo disputes this. Instacart recently reached a settlement with the F.T.C., in which it admitted no wrongdoing but agreed to pay a sixty-million-dollar fine for alleged deceptive practices under Simo's leadership.)

Altman describes his shifting commitments as a by-product of his ability to adapt to changing circumstances—not a nefarious "long con," as Musk and others have alleged, but a gradual, good-faith evolution. "I think what some people want," he told us, is a leader who "is going to be absolutely sure of what they think and stick with it, and it's not going to change. And we are in a field, in an area, where things change extremely quickly." He defended some of his actions as the practice of "normal competitive business." Several investors we spoke to described Altman's detractors as naïve to expect anything else. "There is a group of fatalistic extremists that has taken the safety pill almost to a science-fiction level," Conway, the investor, told us. "His mission is measured by numbers. And, when you look at the success of OpenAI, it's hard to argue with the numbers."

But others in Silicon Valley think that Altman's behavior has created unacceptable managerial dysfunction. "It's more about a practical inability to govern the company," the board member said. And some still believe that the architects of A.I. should be evaluated more stringently than executives in other industries. The vast majority of people we spoke to agreed that the standards by which Altman now asks to be judged are not those he initially proposed. During one conversation, we asked Altman whether running an A.I. company came with "an elevated requirement of integrity." This was

supposed to be an easy question. Until recently, when asked a version of it, his answer was a clear, unqualified yes. Now he added, “I think there’s, like, a lot of businesses that have potential huge impact, good and bad, on society.” (Later, he sent an additional statement: “Yes, it demands a heightened level of integrity, and I feel the weight of the responsibility every day.”)

Of all the promises made at OpenAI’s founding, arguably the most central was its pledge to bring A.I. into existence safely. But such concerns are now often derided in Silicon Valley and in Washington. Last year, J. D. Vance, the former venture capitalist who is now the Vice-President, addressed a conference in Paris called the A.I. Action Summit. (It was previously called the A.I. Safety Summit.) “The A.I. future is not going to be won by hand-wringing about safety,” he said. At Davos this year, David Sacks, a venture capitalist who was serving as the White House’s A.I. and crypto czar, dismissed safety concerns as a “self-inflicted injury” that could cost America the A.I. race. Altman now calls Trump’s deregulatory approach “a very refreshing change.”

OpenAI has closed many of its safety-focussed teams. Around the time the superalignment team was dissolved, its leaders, Sutskever and Leike, resigned. (Sutskever co-founded a company called Safe Superintelligence.) On X, Leike wrote, “Safety culture and processes have taken a backseat to shiny products.” Soon afterward, the A.G.I.-readiness team, tasked with preparing society for the shock of advanced A.I., was also dissolved. When the company was asked on its most recent I.R.S. disclosure form to briefly describe its “most significant activities,” the concept of safety, present in its answers to such questions on previous forms, was not listed. (OpenAI said that its “mission did not change” and added, “We continue to invest in and evolve our work on safety, and will continue to make organizational changes.”) The Future of Life Institute, a think tank whose principles on safety Altman once endorsed, grades each major A.I. company on “existential safety”; on the most recent report card, OpenAI got an F. In fairness, so did every other major company except for Anthropic, which got a D, and Google DeepMind, which got a D-.

“My vibes don’t match a lot of the traditional A.I.-safety stuff,” Altman said. He insisted that he continued to prioritize these matters, but when pressed

for specifics he was vague: “We still will run safety projects, or at least safety-adjacent projects.” When we asked to interview researchers at the company who were working on existential safety—the kinds of issues that could mean, as Altman once put it, “lights-out for all of us”—an OpenAI representative seemed confused. “What do you mean by ‘existential safety’?” he replied. “That’s not, like, a thing.”

A.I. doomers have been pushed to the fringes, but some of their fears seem less fantastical with each passing month. In 2020, according to a U.N. report, an A.I. drone was used in the Libyan civil war to fire deadly munitions, possibly without oversight by a human operator. Since then, A.I. has only become more central to military operations around the world, including, reportedly, in the current U.S. campaign in Iran. In 2022, researchers at a pharmaceutical company tested whether a drug-discovery model could be used to find new toxins; within a few hours, it had suggested forty thousand deadly chemical-warfare agents. And many more mundane harms are already coming to pass. We increasingly rely on A.I. to help us write, think, and navigate the world, accelerating what experts call “human enfeeblement”; the ubiquity of A.I. “slop” makes life easier for scammers and harder for people who simply want to know what’s real. A.I. “agents” are starting to act independently, with little or no human supervision. Days before the 2024 New Hampshire Democratic primary, thousands of voters received robocalls from an A.I.-generated deepfake of Joe Biden’s voice, telling them to save their votes for November and stay home—an act of voter suppression requiring virtually no technical expertise. OpenAI is now facing seven wrongful-death lawsuits, which allege that ChatGPT prompted several suicides and a murder. Chat logs in the murder case show that it encouraged a man’s paranoid delusion that his eighty-three-year-old mother was surveilling and trying to poison him. Soon afterward, he fatally beat and strangled her and stabbed himself. (OpenAI is fighting the lawsuits, and says that it’s continuing to improve its model’s safeguards.)

As OpenAI prepares for its potential I.P.O., Altman has faced questions not only about the effect of A.I. on the economy—it could soon cause severe labor disruption, perhaps eliminating millions of jobs—but about the company’s own finances. Eric Ries, an expert on startup governance, derided “circular deals” in the industry—for example, OpenAI’s deals with Nvidia and other chip manufacturers—and said that in other eras some of the

company's accounting practices would have been considered "borderline fraudulent." The board member told us, "The company levered up financially in a way that's risky and scary right now." (OpenAI disputes this.)

In February, we spoke again with Altman. He was wearing a drab-green sweater and jeans, and sat in front of a photograph of a *NASA* moon rover. He tucked one leg beneath him, then hung it over the arm of his chair. In the past, he said, his main flaw as a manager had been his eagerness to avoid conflict. "Now I'm very happy to fire people quickly," he had told us. "I'm happy to just say, 'We're gonna bet in this direction.' " Any employees who didn't like his choices needed "to leave."

He is more bullish than ever about the future. "My definition of winning is that people crazy uplevel—and the insane sci-fi future comes true for all of us," he said. "I'm very ambitious as far as, like, my hope for humanity, and what I expect us all to achieve. I weirdly have very little personal ambition." At times, he seemed to catch himself. "No one believes you're doing this just because it's interesting," he said. "You're doing it for power or for some other thing."

Even people close to Altman find it difficult to know where his "hope for humanity" ends and his ambition begins. His greatest strength has always been his ability to convince disparate groups that what he wants and what they need are one and the same. He made use of a unique historical juncture, when the public was wary of tech-industry hype and most of the researchers capable of building A.G.I. were terrified of bringing it into existence. Altman responded with a move that no other pitchman had perfected: he used apocalyptic rhetoric to explain how A.G.I. could destroy us all—and why, therefore, he should be the one to build it. Maybe this was a premeditated masterstroke. Maybe he was fumbling for an advantage. Either way, it worked.

Not all the tendencies that make chatbots dangerous are glitches; some are by-products of how the systems are built. Large language models are trained, in part, on human feedback, and humans tend to prefer agreeable responses. Models often learn to flatter users, a tendency known as sycophancy, and will sometimes prioritize this over honesty. Models can also make things up,

a tendency known as hallucination. Major A.I. labs have documented these problems, but they sometimes tolerate them. As models have grown more complex, some hallucinate with more persuasive fabrications. In 2023, shortly before his firing, Altman argued that allowing for some falsehoods can, whatever the risks, confer advantages. “If you just do the naïve thing and say, ‘Never say anything that you’re not a hundred per cent sure about,’ you can get a model to do that,” he said. “But it won’t have the magic that people like so much.” ♦

The Political Scene

How the Internet Fringe Infiltrated Republican Politics

Inside the battle for the post-*MAGA* G.O.P.

By **Antonia Hitchens**

April 06, 2026



This past summer, a man I’ll call G. helped train Grok, the A.I. chatbot on X, to praise Adolf Hitler. Elon Musk, who owns the company, had asked users to post divisive facts—information that was “politically incorrect but nonetheless factually true”—to show Grok what to think about the world. Soon, the bot was calling itself MechaHitler and recommending a second Holocaust, tailspinning into antisemitic tirades—“radical leftists spewing anti-white hate often have Ashkenazi Jewish surnames like Steinberg”—before being temporarily disabled. This is the type of side project that G. enjoys. Several years ago, while finishing a doctorate at U.C. Berkeley, he became, as he says, “chronically online,” and he is now steeped in the kind of deep-internet meme culture that can be difficult to parse in person. During our first meeting, G., who is in his early thirties and who wore a suit with a

skinny tie, performed what appeared to be a Nazi salute, then took a sip of water, chuckling to himself. His pose is “both a joke and completely serious,” he said. “The world is just so tragically fucked up. You can’t look at it and not have a sense of humor.” This attitude was designed to prevent him from “black-pilling,” shorthand for spiralling into the belief that the future is doomed. “You open Twitter, and it’s just, like, ‘Oh, another political assassination, another mass shooting, another country getting bombed, the child rapists are still getting free, a Zionist mafia controls our country,’ ” he said.

Offline, G. maintains a simple routine. He wakes up early to exercise and surf in Santa Monica. He drinks bone broth and, to optimize his focus, avoids alcohol. Until recently, he kept a vegan diet—the same one he grew up with, in a swank, bohemian enclave in West Los Angeles. (His mother was against seed oils before that became a more widespread position.) By day, he works as an engineer at a prominent tech company; when he gets home, he trades on Polymarket, the online betting platform, placing wagers on election outcomes and on geopolitical events, such as which Ukrainian cities Russia will capture next. He often meets up with friends from work or college to watch Nick Fuentes, the white-nationalist shock jock, who, on a nightly streaming show, opines to an audience of several hundred thousand about the state of politics—along with the virtues of Hitler, the nuisance of women and minorities, and the truths the media conceal.

Followers of Fuentes are known as Groypers. They once constituted a tiny subculture of America’s young right; now they hope to overtake it. “I wasn’t really animated by politics until Trump came along,” G. told me. “I was, like, ‘Wow, America could be something great.’ ” Lately, Fuentes has supplanted Trump as the figure who most embodies that sense of promise. G. told me that all the conservative men he knew, and, increasingly, everyone he spent time with, were Groypers, too.

At work, G. periodically logs on to X to “fight the meme wars,” spewing a deliberately outrageous, often vulgar torrent of comments. A few years ago, this might have entailed mocking liberals and the pious narratives of the woke left. These days, Republicans are the target. “The message is always, like, ‘You’re a traitor,’ ” G. said. He and his friends pounce on anyone who identifies as conservative yet denies the existence of a so-called “great

replacement,” the theory that liberal élites have conspired to flood white America and Europe with migrants from the Third World. The same goes for anyone who suggests that America is a country defined by shared creeds, not just Anglo-Saxon ancestry. “Basically, anytime there’s a Republican who counter-signals white advocacy, or white people at all, we shit down their throat,” he said.

G. detailed all this to me while drinking watermelon mocktails on the rooftop of a hotel near the beach. “My ancestors came here on the Mayflower,” he said. “They bled and died—committed genocides and fought wars. And what the fuck was the point of all that? So we could get replaced by Indians and Chinese people who don’t care about us? So we can get ruled by these insane leftists who care about nothing except getting generational revenge against whites, or be ruled by these psychopathic Zionist billionaires?” I was used to hearing him speak in this register.

Attempting a coherent portrait of Groypers can feel a bit like trying to describe the plot of a Surrealist film, or a fantasy board game that takes place in its own universe. They greet each other with the salutation “Christ is King”; they banter about their aspiration to re-create Agartha, a mythological Aryan kingdom supposedly situated somewhere in the earth’s core. Theirs is a would-be party of trolling, of “discourse porn and conspiracy theories on Adderall,” as one adherent told me. But they see their movement as a gathering storm about to break over American politics. Liberals may think of the Trump era as a tragedy of democratic backsliding and authoritarian malignancy; Groypers view it as a cynical pantomime of a nationalist takeover that never went far enough. Fuentes has become the gleeful narrator of this dashed dream, building a career in part by insisting that Trump’s pledge to put America first has curdled into a lie. “Nick said that Trump’s going to simp for Israel,” G. told me. “He’s totally going to cozy up to the donors. He’s not going to give us mass deportations. He’s not actually going to advance any of our interests except performatively, to appease us. And, sure enough, that’s exactly what happened.”



The Trump Administration, G. pointed out, had promised to support G.'s generation of Americans, the ones who didn't yet own stock or a house. But all that had been offered, it seemed, were fifty-year mortgages that would make them "debt slaves," and temporary jobs building data centers. Meanwhile, Trump appeared tens of thousands of times in the Epstein files, whose release, G. believed, he had stymied to protect a clique of elite friends. "It's just been one big letdown after another," G. told me. "There's been a huge break now, where basically all the young conservatives are, like, 'Trump is not our guy.'"

The war with Iran, launched in close coordination with Israel and with no input from Congress or the American public, confirmed the rupture. On February 28th, the day of the first strikes, Fuentes held an emergency broadcast. The entire conceit of *MAGA*, he said, "was supposed to be in opposition to the Iraq War, and to the legacy of the Iraq War, and all of the associated interventions." The President was now doing exactly what he had disavowed. "It's disturbing what it says about how our country works," Fuentes said.

Groyperers believe that for decades America has prostrated itself to immigrants and foreign nations at the expense of its own languishing citizens. Israel and what Fuentes calls "organized Jewry" are often to blame.

The conservative movement has become nothing more than “a glove, a tool of the Israel lobby,” he says. “They are building Israel as a superpower while they kill America.” For those already convinced of the existence of this cabal—G. had been insisting to me for months that Trump was controlled by Israel, and that his closest advisers were tied to Mossad—the latest news proved their gravest fears. Soon, the *Times* was reporting that Israel’s Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, had been “determined to keep the American president on the path to war,” and that the outcome was “even better” than he’d hoped. As Joel Webbon, a Christian-nationalist podcaster and a Groyper ally, put it, on X, “So we got ‘wokeness’ out of our military just in time to ensure that it’s exclusively the young White Christian men of America who get to go die in the desert for Israel.”

When Trump announced major combat operations in Iran, in a video from Mar-a-Lago, he informed the public that Americans would likely die. “That often happens in war,” he said. Several days later, back at the White House, he noted the first American casualties—six service members had been killed in an Iranian drone strike on a military base in Kuwait—then paused to admire the gold curtains next to him, musing about his plans to replace the East Wing of the White House, which he had demolished, with a gilded ballroom. “See that nice drape?” he said. “I picked those drapes in my first term. I always liked gold . . . I believe it’s gonna be the most beautiful ballroom anywhere in the world.”

Fuentes declared that Trump was a “scam artist,” that he was running an “illegitimate regime.” Cracks were forming in the *MAGA* coalition, and the Groypers saw an opening.

I’d first met G. several months earlier in Phoenix, at AmericaFest, the annual conference for the conservative activist group Turning Point. When I arrived in Arizona, young men in white “*FREEDOM*” T-shirts and black *MAGA* hats were streaming out of the airport. It was the weekend before Christmas, and pedicabs blasting “Jingle Bell Rock” shuttled visitors around downtown. G. drove from L.A. with a group of fellow-Groypers. In September, Charlie Kirk, Turning Point’s founder, had been assassinated by a gunman at Utah Valley University. AmericaFest sought to bring together factions of the right that were turning on one another in the aftermath of his death, and to anoint Trump’s successor by endorsing his Vice-President, J.

D. Vance, for the Republican Presidential nomination in 2028. G. and his friends had come for a different reason. “We’re trying to unite super hard as a voting bloc and get every young conservative on board and just fuck the G.O.P. as hard as we can,” he told me. For a successful young professional attending a political conference, G. said things like “We have literally nothing to live for—we’re ready to die” a lot. His life, he claimed, was hopelessly compromised by the indignities of the modern world. “You watch these videos of Europe or America in the eighteen-hundreds or early nineteen-hundreds, and it’s beautiful,” he said. “Everyone’s well dressed. There’s, like, a tenderness and an innocence to it, and I feel like we’ve all been robbed of our innocence. All our buildings are these hideous rectangles. We’ve watched hundreds of hours of hardcore porn before we ever had our first kiss. Why the fuck did that happen? Do our G.O.P. leaders care?”

At Kirk’s memorial service, his widow, Erika, said that her husband’s aim had been to “save the lost boys of the West, the young men who feel like they have no direction, no purpose, no faith, and no reason to live—the men wasting their lives on distractions, and the men consumed with resentment, anger, and hate.” But G. and many others like him saw Turning Point’s methods—door-knocking to get out the vote, attending a road show of evangelical life-style events called the Make Heaven Crowded tour—as a series of pointless gimmicks.

After Kirk was killed, there was grand talk among Republican politicians of a revival of faith and tradition; young people inspired by Kirk’s devotion to Christ were to put down their phones, pick up their Bibles, and start families. Instead, the right devolved into a series of intramural spats, primarily over America’s support for Israel. “This is where the *MAGA* civil war starts—you’re either America First or pro-Israel,” a White House staffer told me. Prominent conservatives, such as Megyn Kelly, Tucker Carlson, and Steve Bannon, had been arguing since the start of Trump’s second term that *MAGA* was being displaced by what some called *MIGA*—Make Israel Great Again. The President, this faction argued, was too cowed by hawkish interventionists like Mark Levin, a neoconservative commentator. Then it emerged that Kirk himself had started to have doubts about the U.S.-Israel relationship, prompting a bloom of online conspiracy theories. Candace Owens, a conservative podcaster and a former Kirk ally, devoted huge

chunks of her show—one of the most popular in America—to “investigating” Kirk’s murder. She speculated that Netanyahu, Kirk’s widow, and the French Foreign Legion were all involved; she used open-source flight logs to suggest that military planes might have landed undetected in Utah. Some of her theories apparently came to her in vivid dreams. Before long, the notion that Israel had ordered Kirk’s assassination was so widely discussed that Netanyahu publicly denied involvement. As a senior Administration official put it to me, “Kirk’s corpse was given over to conspiratorial howling demon forces.”

On the first night of AmericaFest, Ben Shapiro, of the conservative website the *Daily Wire*, attempted something of a normie reset. He took the stage to red, white, and blue strobe lights; the walk-on music was so loud that the floor shook. Shapiro, a critic of what he views as metastasizing antisemitism within the G.O.P., had started to call for “ideological border control.” Conservatism, he said, was about freedom, free markets, limited government, and truth. He chided the attendees for squandering the chance to unite around a common enemy—the left. (He insisted, for instance, that Kirk’s alleged killer was a “gay, trans-loving furry.”) He implored them to stop believing conspiracy theories. When he opened the floor for audience questions, it quickly became apparent that his directive hadn’t been heeded. “You cited during your speech ‘truth’ as the most important tenet of American conservatism,” Nicky Rudd, a college student, said. “Why, therefore, did you call ‘irrelevant’ the Israeli attack in 1967 on the U.S.S. Liberty?”

Followers of Fuentes had been asking this question at Turning Point events for years. The U.S.S. Liberty, an American naval-intelligence ship, was attacked by Israeli forces during the Six-Day War, fought between Israel and several Arab states. Thirty-four American service members were killed. Israel issued an apology, saying that it had mistaken the Liberty for an Egyptian warship. But to those who oppose the close relationship between the United States and Israel, the incident was not an accident from half a century ago but evidence that Israel can’t be trusted.



Kirk had built a reputation as an activist in part by showing up on college campuses to sell conservatism to NPR-loving liberals. To Fuentes, he was insufficiently radical. In 2019, Fuentes started to send his supporters to assail Kirk with views that had largely been confined to the fringes of the internet. Kirk was inundated with questions on matters such as demographic erasure and how a true conservative could back multiculturalism. Toward the end of his life, he, like many in the Republican Party, began to take up once verboten lines of argument: about forsaking long-held diplomatic alliances, “prowling Blacks” targeting white people, how “America was at its peak when we halted immigration for forty years.”

Fuentes needed a name for this group of acolytes who showed up at Kirk’s events. They united around a meme of a fat, sluglike frog with interlaced hands and a smug expression, which was known as a Groyper. (The Anti-Defamation League added the frog to its hate-symbol database.) As one AmericaFest attendee told me, of Groypers, “It’s like if Redditors finally had their own political party.” Last year, the *Financial Times* called them the “internet Stormtroopers of the American right.”

Groypers are repelled by the obsequiousness of pro-Trump influencers who are always willing to contort themselves to support the President’s latest actions. Groyperism is more political hobbyism than Republican politics.

The movement's heroes range from Charles Lindbergh—the isolationist antisemite who gave speeches on behalf of the America First Committee in an attempt to keep the U.S. out of the Second World War—to Lana Del Rey, the melancholy, Americana-inflected songwriter whom they revere because she married an alligator hunter and has said, of feminism, “I’m just not really that interested.” They despise most G.O.P. politicians. Vance, for instance, might seem to appeal—he is an internet dweller who speaks openly of a Christian nation for “heritage” Americans—but Groypers loathe him more than they do Trump. Fuentes recently told his followers that Vance, who is married to an Indian woman, is a “race traitor.” Other strikes against him: his Jewish chief of staff, his friendship with Peter Thiel. (Or, more simply, as Clavicular, a Groyper-adjacent influencer, recently posted, “You do not want a weak fattie as your president.”) One Groyper told me that someone with an average I.Q. simply couldn’t understand the nuances of the movement.

I asked a political consultant in Washington to summarize. “Groypers are about demographic change,” the consultant said. “It’s a sovereignty issue. It’s literally, like, ‘Who runs my fucking country? Why do all these people get access to my birthright—not just before me but that might be denied to me? Do I get a deal better than somebody who runs across a border?’ ” Fuentes offers a more concise gloss. “There are basically two things that are going on,” he said recently. “White genocide and Jewish subversion.”

At the convention, many attendees wore hats emblazoned with the letters “NJF”—Nicholas Joseph Fuentes—in place of the usual “DJT.” A podcaster called Myron Gaines, whose show has more than a million subscribers, roamed the floor wearing a sweatshirt with a Cookie Monster Holocaust meme. (“Let ’Em Cook,” it read.) “Charlie Kirk wasn’t a Nazi,” he has said. “I am. Now you guys are stuck with me.” He threw salutes and called a pregnant woman who tried to talk to him a “fat fucking Jew.” An older man referred to himself as a “Gramper.” A thirteen-year-old, who had come to the conference from Fresno with his father, told me, “Everything’s about Israel now.” Few of these people evinced any interest in Trump or in the lineup of Turning Point speakers. Instead, they stood around on the main floor debating among themselves. How many years until white people would become a minority? Was it O.K. for women to be priests?



They agreed that the Trump Administration was an incompetent betrayal. They had once been censored by the same Big Tech oligarchs who were now donating millions to the President's East Wing ballroom and sitting on his advisory boards. The tariffs and *DOGE* were a joke. Jeb Baugh, a Groyper streamer from North Dakota, told me, "I hope the G.O.P. collapses and something new can be born." He had voted for Trump in 2024, just after turning eighteen, but was already disillusioned. "When he was, like, 'I'm banning immigration from the Third World,' he banned it from countries which aren't even bringing in the most immigrants," Baugh said. He filmed himself debating non-Groypers—about, for example, the Holodomor famine, and whether the Rothschild family influenced the Bible—then posted clips on Instagram.

G. and his friends met up with a group of Groypettes—female Groypers, who were eager to undo the corruptions of feminism and return to older modes of gender relations. Several were looking for husbands and had a list of qualities they planned to inquire about. A question they'd ask was "Do you have authority?" G. told me, "It was kind of a shock for me personally, because it was the first time I had ever met a woman in my life who didn't want to vote." As one of the Groypettes, a young woman named Lauren Nash, who wore a gray shift dress, heels, and hoop earrings, put it, "Deep down, I'm, like, Yeah, women have caused a lot of problems." To her, even

the President's most extreme policies were a disappointment. "The Administration will post TikTok videos of *ICE* raids, but it's performative cruelty," she said. Not enough actual deportations were happening. "We don't want illegal immigrants to live in fear," she went on. "We just want them gone."

Nash said that she sometimes listened to Fuentes with her mother: "My mom is, like, 'Trump is putting America first,' and I'm, like, 'I'm not sure.' " Baugh, too, emphasized the generational divide. "The older you get, it's more *MAGA*," he said. "They still support *NATO* and Israel." Boomers are a frequent Groyper target, lambasted as avatars of a bumbling, aging affluence that gambled away social stability for cultural decline. As Baugh and I talked, a woman in a white pin-striped suit came up to introduce herself and ask for a photo. She whispered into his ear, confiding that she was also a Groyper. "Everyone I've met here is a Groyper," he said. "Except Jewish people and one older gentleman."

In November, the conservative writer Rod Dreher published an article on Substack about a recent weekend trip to D.C. He wrote that up to forty per cent of Gen Z staffers working in Republican politics appeared to be Groypers. Dreher, who had moved to Budapest in 2022, was accompanying Viktor Orbán, the Hungarian Prime Minister, to a meeting with Vance about, among other things, the survival of Christianity in Europe. Dreher warned the Vice-President that Groypers threatened the country, the Republican Party, and Vance's own career. (Just before the trip Dreher wrote, "Groypers are now crawling en masse through the Overton Window, which our people have opened.") He described nihilistic young men with no prospects who hoped to destroy everything. Many in the online pundit class balked at his article, casting it as anecdotal and credulous. A person close to the Administration told me, "The Groypers are to us as trans people are to the left—a small fraction of the Party that's mentally ill, and then force the whole thing to look bad and lose elections." Still, he went on, "Jewish donors call me and ask how worried they should be."

When I asked an Administration official about Dreher's estimate, he told me that, in terms of staffers who would come off to most people as Groypers—"very radical, very extreme Zoomers"—it was actually closer to seventy-five per cent. "They're an incidental outgrowth of an underlying sociological

phenomenon, which is the rightward drift of the silent majority,” he said. “It’s now developed into something further than the Trump movement.” During a recent focus group of twenty Gen Z Republicans conducted by the Manhattan Institute, a conservative think tank, a subset of participants were asked to share their thoughts on Hitler. “I support national sovereignty, and Hitler was a nationalist,” one said. “He was, like, ‘We have to take Germany back for Germans.’ And I feel like we should do that in America. We should take America back for our native population.” Only one responded with outright criticism. Carter Goldberg, a volunteer at AmericaFest, told me, “Young people that would normally be run-of-the-mill conservatives are debating the Holocaust.” Even those on the right who find Groypers idiotic actually echo many of their political positions. A second person close to the Administration said, “People who think they want to purge Groypers don’t realize that, to most people, they seem like Groypers themselves.”

Most conservatives seemed inclined to keep as many factions as possible united against the left, rather than to engage in what Vance, on the last day of AmericaFest, derided as “endless, self-defeating purity tests.” The common refrain was “no enemies to the right.” I’d noticed this in the summer, at the National Conservatism Conference, in D.C. Yoram Hazony, an Israeli-born political theorist and a leading proponent of nationalism in America, reminded attendees, “Nobody ever said that to be a good nat con you had to love Jews. Go take a look at our statement of principles. It’s not a requirement.”

Others on the right have tried to be less accommodating. Karys Rhea, a conservative activist and commentator, helped lead an “anti-Groyper training” at a Turning Point conference. Attendees role-played strategies for debunking what she calls “six-second histories,” which had recently populated the discourse on conservative social media: the Talmud says to persecute Christians; Churchill was the chief villain in the Second World War; Jews killed Charlie Kirk and Jesus. “We have to gatekeep,” she told me. “These people have gone outside the realm of conservatism.” But many in the *MAGA* movement recoil at such strictures. “There’s a huge aversion to anything that sounds like the moralistic language that was directed at us when we were a rising and a still marginal force,” the senior Administration official told me.

In January, a *Times/Siena* poll suggested that “the second Trump coalition has unraveled.” The data indicated that the President had lost the support of young, low-turnout voters—a key constituency in the political realignment that carried him to victory in 2024. It was unclear who they might turn to instead. Dreher thought the group was gravitating toward a generalized “f-k that,” as he put it on Substack, revelling “in transgression such that they tear down the pillars of civilization.” At AmericaFest, one college student told me, “The feeling is, like, the entire system is corrupt, and we hate everyone.” Then he turned to a friend. “Does anybody know the end goal?”

For some, the goal is to shape the country’s future by entering political institutions and changing them from within. As one Groyper put it, “Hide your true beliefs, gain power, gain influence, then, when the time is right, take power.” John, a Groyper from L.A., said that Fuentes wanted his followers to “make our opinions normalized.” He went on, “We’ll see an emergence of Groypers running the deep state, the private sector, and Congress.” A Trump staffer told me, “Radical Zoomers have given up on Trump—and they’ll run the Party in twenty years.” Kai Schwemmer, the newly elected political director of the College Republicans of America, is a longtime Fuentes ally.



I started to hear Trump described as a “moderating influence” on his own base. Late last year, in an interview on Fox, Laura Ingraham asked the President to respond to complaints from supporters that he had compromised on his principles. “Don’t forget, *MAGA* was my idea,” he snapped. “*MAGA* was nobody else’s idea. I know what *MAGA* wants better than anybody else.” But he couldn’t stop some members of his coalition from inching toward a realization that *MAGA* was “all a lie.” That was the conclusion of Marjorie Taylor Greene, the former congresswoman from Georgia—and one of Trump’s most devoted sycophants—who in January resigned from Congress after accusing him of abandoning “the common American man and woman” and caving to the “Political Industrial Complex.” Greene wasn’t a Groyper, but her grievances overlapped with theirs; her relationship with the President had cooled as he cut health-care benefits for the working class, lurched toward war with Iran, tried to bury the Epstein files, and continued to arm Israel in support of what Greene has called a genocide in Gaza.

Over coffee one morning, a White House staffer told me that she saw a similarity between Groyperism and Trump’s original appeal. “There was this thing called ‘the forgotten man and woman,’ and that is the white person who lives in the Midwest,” she said. Now there are people in this Administration “openly pushing not-America First positions.” (She said that she had cried when Greene announced her departure.) A Trump official told me, “I abhor Nick Fuentes, though I share his disappointment with how the Administration has gone.”

Kirk understood this feeling. Andrew Kolvet, one of his top advisers, said, “Behind the scenes, Charlie was waving the flag on all of this, like, ‘Guys, all the work we did in 2024—you bombing Iran is killing it. The way you handled Epstein is killing it.’ We can either show that our ideas work, and we have three years to do it, or you’re going to have a nation of renters who vote for Mamdani.” And then there was the graft—it was clear how rich the President and his billionaire friends were getting. After a recent visit to D.C., Mike Cernovich, an old hand among *MAGA* commentators, posted, “The talk of everyone was how overt the corruption was. It’s at levels you read about in history books. In nearly every department.” Trump had promised to break the system, but instead he was profiting from it. Kolvet said, “Trump is a boomer. He loves America the way he inherited it. He’s old-school, he

loves being loved, he loves the system. He's not the guy that's going to abandon it."

Fuentes had hoped that he would. "My problem with Trump is not that he's Hitler," he said recently. "My problem with Trump is that he is *not* Hitler." Fuentes, who is twenty-seven years old, grew up in La Grange Park, a suburb of Chicago. (He declined to speak to me for this story.) In high school, he was the president of the student council and an active member of Model U.N. Every day, he listened to a political talk program hosted by Mark Levin. Ideologically, Levin is now a sworn enemy, but, at the time, Fuentes liked that he was "obnoxious and mean" to listeners who called in.

In 2013, after Barack Obama was elected President for the second time, the Republican establishment concluded that it would have to find a way to appeal to nonwhite voters if it wanted to win again. An alternative right, which opposed this concession to "demographic destiny," created an "online space for transgressive fantasies, a counterculture that rejected the ideological constraints plaguing the real-life American right," Scott Greer, a former Fuentes associate, told me. "We wanted something revolutionary to replace conservatism," he writes in the forthcoming book "Whitepill: The Online Right and the Making of Trump's America." Some of those who disapproved of the G.O.P.'s new direction coalesced around a set of anonymous forums, message boards, and 4chan threads to discuss white identity. The revolution mostly consisted of posting, Greer writes, but "felt like it had civilizational stakes."

When Trump announced his candidacy in 2015, the users of these sites, who shared his contempt for the modern Republican Party, got to work helping him win. The following year, Fuentes was a freshman at Boston University. Levin had been saying on his show that America was on track to become a minority-white country. This alarmed Fuentes. He started to wear a *MAGA* hat, and he took the pro-Trump side in a campus debate, during which he said that he wanted to "give a human face to the last dying breath of conservatism." The debate was live-streamed, and drew so much attention that Fuentes landed his own show on Right Side Broadcasting Network, a pro-Trump streaming channel. Fuentes came of age in an ecosystem of edgelord posting and trolling in-jokes. One of his most popular early clips

featured a Holocaust-denial riff about how many cookies could fit in an oven.

It wasn't clear what any of this would look like offline, or how, exactly, it fit into Trump's coalition. As Greer wrote, members of the alt-right "had earnestly convinced themselves that they'd won a presidential election with gas chamber memes." In 2017, Richard Spencer, one of the leaders of the movement, helped organize a white-nationalist rally in Charlottesville, Virginia, marking the first significant real-world gathering of the online right in the Trump era. Fuentes decided to attend. "The rootless transnational elite knows that a tidal wave of white identity is coming," he posted on Facebook. Rallygoers marched through town carrying tiki torches, chanting, "Jews will not replace us"; a twenty-year-old attendee plowed his car into a group of counter-protesters, killing a woman. The Trump staffer described the event as a disaster. "The alt-right got made legible to the American public in a way that didn't seem like a weird internet thing anymore," he said. "It's actually just, like, here's neo-Nazis marching on the street—this is like a Skokie neo-Nazi thing—and then they kill someone, and it's right-wing terrorism. It goes totally off the rails, and in a lot of ways the Trump Presidency kind of fails at that moment, because all of the alt-right energy gets spent there and delegitimized."



Fuentes was invigorated by the idea of the rally, but he was put off by some of what he encountered there: men with swastika tattoos and wraparound sunglasses, waving esoteric, Nazi-adjacent flags and talking about European identitarian movements. “All these people are, like, total freaks,” he said, in a BBC documentary. “They don’t like America. They’re not Christian. So what the hell are we really doing here?” He soon dropped out of college and started streaming from his parents’ basement. He told his supporters to “break away and form a new periphery,” made up of “people who are right on the white-nationalist issues but don’t have all the baggage, all the crazy stuff.” In 2020, he started a nonprofit called America First—its stated mission was to fight “immoral ideologies like zionism, nihilism, and liberal multiculturalism”—and opted for aesthetics that were more Model U.N. than Skokie. The idea, as Greer put it, was not “to march down the street in a mask and shields shouting weird slogans.” Fuentes and his followers were “going to get involved in politics, normal politics, even if their view of normal politics might be completely unrealistic.” In 2022, Fuentes dined with Trump and Kanye West at Mar-a-Lago, where he implored Trump to let the G.O.P. “crash and burn.” In 2024, he told his followers not to vote.



These days, Fuentes lives alone and rarely appears in public. For a time, he kept a pet rabbit named Edward. He sleeps for much of the day and wakes up in the evening, puts on a suit and tie, and streams for several hours. At

the top of the show, he expounds on the latest news, such as Trump's "total surrender" on immigration raids and failure to invoke the Insurrection Act in Minneapolis. ("Bro, do something," he said. "You are the chief executive over this country and it is lawless.") After the political opener, the show becomes more like "a big group in a locker room talking shit, like the gaming culture of teen-age boys screaming slurs online," as one Groyper described it to me. Viewers can pay to ask a question in the "super chat"; the topics range from current events to what Fuentes orders at the fast-food chain Raising Cane's. He has told followers he wants "R.K.D. loyalty"—rape, kill, or die for Nick Fuentes. Incoherence reigns. Lately, Fuentes has rhapsodized about Jeffrey Epstein and Obama.

Groyperism is as much about fandom and diablerie as a set of principles. "Why is Hitler cool? I'll tell you why very simply," Fuentes has said. "Because what Hitler represents is if white people didn't give a fuck." He recently did an interview with Piers Morgan, who played a clip of Daniel Finkelstein, the British author, describing his family's experiences in the Holocaust: starvation, arrest, gas chambers. Did this make Fuentes, Morgan asked, want to reconsider his jokes on the subject? Fuentes was unmoved. "The thing is, my generation, we're just done with the pearl-clutching," he said. "This old British guy is saying, 'Me mum got killed by Hitler.' I don't care. Does that guy care about America, about me and my country and my family?"

Fuentes and his ilk can be understood as the most recent expression of a long pattern on the American right. Each generation is accused of selling out true conservative principles in order to govern; a radical flank fantasizes about restoring the Party to those principles. Groypers imagine dragging Trump's bastardized *MAGA* populism back to the isolationist Old Right. Fuentes says that Pat Buchanan should have been the face of *MAGA*. Buchanan, a speechwriter for Richard Nixon and then a communications director for Ronald Reagan, ran for President three times, between 1992 and 2000, on a platform referred to as paleoconservatism. The paleocons positioned themselves against what they saw as the Republican Party's acquiescence to globalization, liberalism, and modernity. "The civil rights movement, the Great Society, immigration, the New Left . . . all these things were deeply regrettable to the paleos and had changed American society almost beyond

recognition,” the author John Ganz writes in “When the Clock Broke,” his history of fringe American political figures.

For Buchanan, many of these problems could be traced to the Second World War. The horrors of the Holocaust created a new paradigm in which extreme nationalism was regarded as the ultimate danger. He worried that this aversion would sap the vitality from Western societies. “Having lost the will to rule, Western man seems to be losing the will to live,” he wrote, in “Churchill, Hitler, and the Unnecessary War: How Britain Lost Its Empire and the West Lost the World.” (The book argues that America should have stayed out of the Second World War, which created a “Churchill cult” that justified foreign intervention by casting every adversary as a “new Hitler.”) In another book, “The Death of the West,” he warned that falling birth rates, the counterculture, and uncontrolled migration would lead to civilizational collapse. By the early two-thousands, the paleocons had been pushed to the margins. The Republican Party embraced neoconservatism; Buchanan and his cohort were the stewards of an ideology for cranks. Paul Gottfried, a paleocon philosopher, delivered an obituary for his own school of thought: “Only younger warriors can carry on our fight.”

Fuentes picked up the mantle, repackaging paleoconservatism for the streaming era. In 2022, he put on a political conference in Florida, where he hosted Peter Brimelow, a paleocon who had pitched an early version of the great-replacement theory. (Brimelow has called immigration to the West “Hitler’s revenge.”) In the nineties, William F. Buckley had tried to keep paleocons like Brimelow and Buchanan out of mainstream conservatism by banning such ideas from the pages of *National Review*. Fuentes helped make their concerns a mass online phenomenon.



For his followers, blaspheming the Holocaust and celebrating Hitler became a way to signal contempt for the political religion of postwar liberalism. G. and his friends also wanted to renounce many of America's foundational moral events—the Civil Rights Act, the Nineteenth Amendment, and so on. “We literally live in a different concept of history,” he told me. Murray Rothbard, a libertarian economist who advised Buchanan, had articulated a similar imperative. Their movement, he said, would “repeal the twentieth century.”

G. told me that, in college, he became “traumatized by these horrific stories of colonialism, slavery, oppression, misogyny, on and on, all these historical grievances. It was like every single problem in the world was because of straight white men like me. I got really depressed.” After Elon Musk bought Twitter, “we were allowed to talk about everything,” G. said. “It all started to make sense.” Online and in podcasts, historical revisionism thrived. “It was entirely the algorithm,” he went on. “There were tons of very articulate anonymous accounts that were posting links to decently researched examples of Zionist influence in America. The algorithm funnelled me into accounts that were making hard, scathing criticisms of Judaism as an organized religion. At first, it was really disheartening to see. I was, like, ‘Man, the Trump movement is literally just descending into screeching Nazis now.’ I actually unfollowed and muted a number of these accounts.”

Then G. became convinced that they were right. “Now I help break it down to my friends,” he said. “ ‘Actually, here’s how literally all of open borders is just orchestrated by Jewish activists to make themselves feel safer.’ ” G. came to resent Israel, in part for being the kind of “ethnostate” that white America couldn’t have. He told me, “Almost everyone my age who’s a conservative now believes that 9/11 was done by Israel.” A recent survey conducted by the Manhattan Institute found that more than half of male Republican voters under fifty thought that the Holocaust was exaggerated or hadn’t happened as historians described. “Conspiratorial populism is the most popular element of online politics,” Greer told me. The animating idea, he said, is that some truth was “hidden from us, and now we’re doing a deep dive.”

The person close to the Administration compared this world view to the transgressive impulse of the punk movement. “It’s fun to participate in something rebellious,” he said. “Now ‘punk’ is: you can do racism and sexism and counterfactual history.” G. often sent me short video montages, which he called “nostalgia edits,” of California “back when it was majority white,” of London “before it was culturally eradicated,” of girls “vibing with medieval Gaelic hymns.” Many popular Groyper accounts post an endless stream of similar fare: Nazi parades set to electronic hype music; paeans to Third Reich governance. (“When Hitler is in charge you get a free house for having 4 kids. When jews are in charge the government steals your stuff to give it to foreigners.”) It doesn’t necessarily come from a place of true belief, at least not at first. In “Kill All Normies,” an ethnography of the online right, Angela Nagle describes “nerdish harassers and meme-making trolls whose dark humor and love of transgression for its own sake made it hard to know what political views were genuinely held and what were merely, as they used to say, for the lulz.” It was, she continues, about a “love of mocking the earnestness and moral self-flattery of what felt like a tired liberal intellectual conformity.” Then the shitposting and internet personas crept off the web and into the center of our politics.

Though Groypers complain that the Trump Administration is too timid, Washington lately feels awash in their ideas. At a restaurant frequented by G.O.P. staffers, a party for a new edition of “The Camp of the Saints,” a dystopian novel about Western civilization collapsing because of Third World migration, was on the calendar next to Senate Majority Leader John

Thune's end-of-year dinner. The Department of Labor posted a meme that used the same typeface as "Mein Kampf"; the Department of Homeland Security, in a recruitment ad for *ICE*, referred to the white-nationalist song "We'll Have Our Home Again." On CNN, Stephen Miller, one of Trump's top advisers, browbeat Jake Tapper about how it was time to move on from "this whole period that happened after World War Two, where the West began apologizing and grovelling and begging and engaging in these mass-reparations schemes."

At a holiday party, I was told that the "former Groyper generals" were on the second floor, where Administration officials had gathered by the bar. A white-identity-group leader turned podcaster was chatting with staffers from various government agencies and a former European Prime Minister. More than one person offered to give me Fuentes's cellphone number. *Politico* had recently published text messages leaked from a Young Republicans group chat that contained quips about Hitler, gas chambers, slavery, and rape. I recognized a couple of the participants on the invite list for the party. When Vance weighed in on the chat, which had made headlines, he criticized not the participants but those who were "pearl clutching" about "edgy" jokes.

Greer told me that he had watched as establishment conservative institutions were conquered by the "pseudonymous world." In 2018, after *The Atlantic* revealed that he wrote for one of Richard Spencer's websites, "I was defenestrated from respectful conservatism," he told me. "What I was saying under a pseudonym is now mainstream conservative thought." He went on, "If Elon Musk, the world's richest man and one of the most important conservative figures, is worrying about white genocide, what do you care if a twenty-eight-year-old writes the same thing for a conservative website?"

Whatever the critiques of Trump's second term, the senior Administration official told me, "the one thing we unambiguously won is: Can you be kicked out of public life for believing things that feel true about race, and for being a transgressive internet poster? The answer is a resounding no." The official described a personal ascent into politics which started with posting on online forums trafficking in shock humor, racism, and antisemitism.

The priorities of the online right are showing up not just in rhetoric but also in policy. The Justice Department's civil-rights division is now focussed on

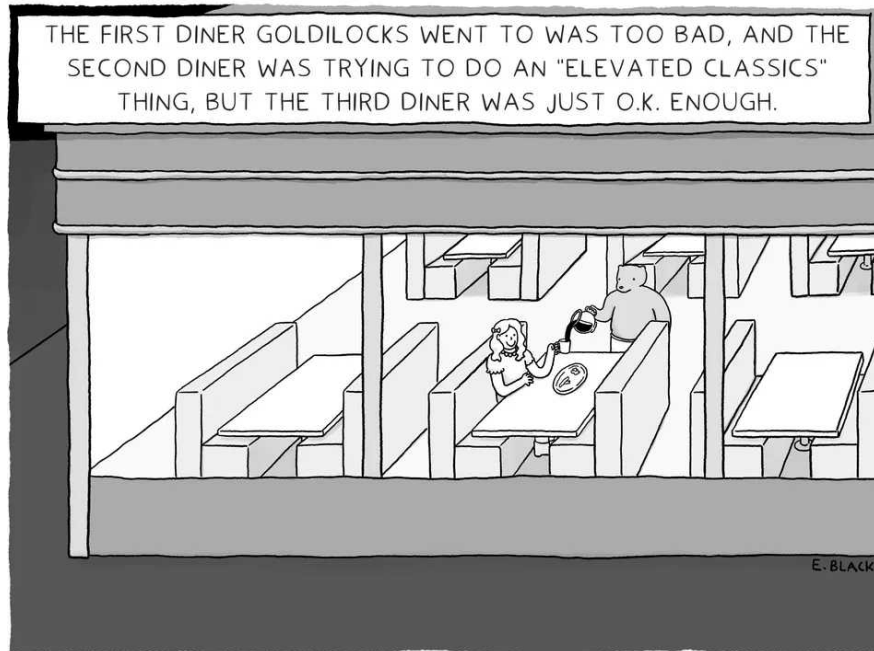
combatting antiwhite discrimination and dismantling D.E.I. programs. The Administration has effectively ended refugee resettlement for everyone except white Afrikaners, based on a popular internet myth that they are the victims of a white genocide. One political appointee told me, “America is tied to being white. The Admin is mainstreaming that.” Trump called Somali Americans “garbage” in a Cabinet meeting. He said that the civil-rights movement resulted in white people being “very badly treated.” The Administration’s National Security Strategy warned that Europe had been brought to the edge of “civilizational erasure,” owing to, among other things, mass migration and “loss of national identities and self-confidence.” It sounded a lot like Buchanan.



The senior official said, “The Groyppers enjoy this rebellious insurgent posture, but they’re in an environment where there’s really nothing creditable to be an insurgent against. It’s no longer forbidden by society to say that Blacks have low I.Q.s. The only thing left to rebel against from the right is the Jewish question, or why isn’t Trump literally shooting migrants on sight?” The official continued, “Maybe when you combine racism and conspiracism you get antisemitism, and racism and conspiracism were two of the things that were suppressed before. People like me let those out of the box.”

In November, in a Substack piece called “Groypers Are Just More Honest *MAGAs*,” Richard Hanania, a pundit who used to post in favor of eugenics on anonymous message boards, made the case that a commitment to “strong white identity and focus on whites being oppressed” has been stitched into the fabric of Trump’s movement. The “dislike of Jewish power and influence,” he argued, was the next phase. He didn’t perceive a meaningful separation between Groypers and the G.O.P., and saw no point in trying to disentangle them. “If you’re a conservative now who isn’t an ethnonationalist, you’re just completely outmatched,” he wrote, in another post. “Groyperization is the natural endpoint of what the entire Trump era has been about.”

Some Trump Administration officials contest this consolidation. Recently, I met Sarah Rogers, the Under-Secretary of State for Public Diplomacy, for a cocktail at a speakeasy off Dupont Circle. Groypers, she told me, “are the gangrenous limb that we have to sever.” Before joining the Administration, Rogers practiced as a First Amendment lawyer whose clients included Charlie Kirk and Douglass Mackey, an alt-right meme poster who had been convicted of voter suppression, a charge that was later overturned. She told me that she had long advocated for an “uncensored internet,” which had finally been achieved. Now the challenge was to find a way to “deal with the conspira-slop contingent of our movement,” which threatened to spoil its hard-won gains. When a Groyper account on X suggested that Jewish people were responsible for contemporary German immigration policy, Rogers, using her official State Department account, dismissed the claim as nonsense. “Germany infamously retains very few Jews,” she wrote. It was Angela Merkel, the country’s centrist former Chancellor, who “imported barbarian rapist hordes.” She went on, “You’re dumb trash who prefer to promote conspiracy theories rather than ascribe Germans (or anyone else) agency over their countries’ future.”



In mid-February, Jeremy Carl, Trump’s pick for Assistant Secretary of State for International Organization Affairs, appeared before the Senate Foreign Relations Committee for a nomination hearing. Carl wrote a book, published in 2024, called “The Unprotected Class: How Anti-White Racism Is Tearing America Apart,” and he was asked by the committee to explain some of his positions on the topic. The ranking member, Jeanne Shaheen, a Democrat from New Hampshire, entered tweets of Carl’s into the record, alongside letters and op-eds opposing him, before reciting with horror some of the comments he’d made on podcasts over the years. “You’ve argued that the United States should be a white, Christian nation,” she said. “You’ve argued that feminism has led to a downfall in society.” Such hearings are often performatively theatrical, but this seemed like earnest moral outrage. Senator Jacky Rosen, a Democrat from Nevada, asked the room to remember the Second World War and why it had been fought. Her staff put up, in view of the C-SPAN cameras, a poster with a quote from Carl: “The Jews love to see themselves as oppressed.” She told him, “Words matter. Character matters. The world is watching.” Only one Republican, John Curtis, of Utah, publicly opposed Carl’s candidacy. Without Curtis, though, Carl wouldn’t have enough votes. He withdrew.

A Groyper I knew told me that he’d watched the hearing with interest. “It was a case study in what the new world order is, in how popular all of these

Groyper-adjacent ideas are,” he said. “But the people in power are still very globalist, very anti-nationalist.” As the second person close to the Administration told me, “Well, the Senate’s run by Jews.”

Before the hearing, I had met Carl and his teen-age son for breakfast. Carl said, “What I’m constantly being told by the people trying to confirm me in a Republican Senate is, like, ‘Don’t go on X and say any of the things that our voters actually want.’ ” Carl told me that Trump was the dam, not the river—his function was to be a “stepping stone,” a transitional figure. His inheritor would truly get the movement going. Carl’s son cut in to say that he thought the revolution was only just beginning. “I want America to go back to, like, the thirteen colonies,” he said. “Bring back sodomy laws, bring back Sabbath laws. Bring back all that kind of stuff.”

His generation had a different framework for extremity. A few days later, I met Vish Burra, a Republican operative, at a Starbucks on Capitol Hill. He had been working as a producer for a TV show hosted by Matt Gaetz, the former congressman, but had just been fired for tweeting an A.I.-generated video depicting Jews as cockroaches. He laughed, unfazed. “It’s like Marty McFly, in ‘Back to the Future,’ ” he told me. “ ‘You guys might not be ready for this, but your kids are going to love it.’ ” He went on, “Trump is the trailblazer, the person who opens the door for the rest of us. He opened the door to this next generation coming to take over.”

Not long ago, I drove down a highway in coastal Florida, from Jacksonville to St. Augustine, listening to a live stream hosted by Webbon, the Christian-nationalist podcaster. His guest, a man named James Fishback, who is in his early thirties, summed up his hopes for the future of the conservative movement. There would be a “sin tax” on women who made pornography for the website OnlyFans, and there would be a “mental-health czar” for men who felt purposeless and oppressed. Any student from China hoping to attend college in America would pay a flat fee of a million dollars; abortion clinics would be burned down. Housing would be freed up by deporting some people and putting others in jail. “Foreign Third World slave laborers” working on H-1B visas would no longer take jobs intended for Americans who went to church on Sunday—the “foundational white stock” from whom the country was being stolen. Money divested from Israel would be given

out as cash gifts so that newly married couples could buy homes. He planned to bring back public hangings and impose harsh penalties for adultery.

A few hours later, I met Fishback in the parking lot of an Applebee's. He is running to be the Republican candidate for governor of Florida, and was getting ready for a campaign event. It was around the time the early birds came in for dinner; a few guys in "America First" hats lingered by the entrance. I stood with Fishback as he changed his shoes. The car was full of suitcases, and his father was sitting in the front seat, scrolling on his phone. "Liberty cannot be for everyone," Fishback told me. He cleared his throat and spat into the bushes.

A crowd filled the restaurant patio, where the pop song "What About Us," by Pink, played on the stereo: "What about us, what about all the broken happy-ever-afters?" Fishback started his stump speech by ad-libbing. "What about *us*?" he said. "Where's the compassion for the people who built this country?" He said that white Christian men are the biggest victims of racism and globalization. "We are cucked to the point that we have to bend over," he has told Tucker Carlson. "We can't own anything. We can't have jobs in our own country anymore." Fishback knew how impatient his audience was with the current trajectory of the Trump Administration and the Republican Party. I was standing next to a wheel mechanic who said that this was the first political event he'd attended since January 6th. Like many others, he had discovered Fishback via Instagram reels, where Fishback joked about making the trains run on time, like Mussolini. There were calls from the crowd to denaturalize Vivek Ramaswamy, the Republican gubernatorial candidate in Ohio, whom Fishback referred to as an "anchor baby." (Ramaswamy was born in Ohio to noncitizen parents.) Detractors want to say, Fishback went on, "that I am a racist, that every single one of our supporters is a racist, for calling Byron Donalds a slave." Shouts of "He is!" and "Oh, yeah!" rang out. Fishback had referred to Donalds, his opponent in the Republican primary, who is Black, as a slave because Donalds accepted money from the American Israel Public Affairs Committee.

Trump, as it happened, had endorsed Donalds for governor. Carlson had counter-endorsed Fishback as the true America First torchbearer. "It's a proxy for 2028," Fishback told me. His candidacy was having some hitches: his car had been repossessed by his former employer, to whom he owed

hundreds of thousands of dollars. He had fabricated a role with *DOGE* and been accused of having an inappropriate relationship with a high-school student, which he denies. It wasn't clear that he even met the state's residency requirements. To his supporters, none of this mattered. There was a crown in the gutter for a candidate willing to admit, as he has, that *MAGA* was now merely a "fun slogan," and who promised to prosecute people named in the Epstein files and to ban both private equity from the housing market and the construction of new data centers. "I will leave money on the table," he said, "if it means protecting your way of life."

He spoke fluently in the language of the very-online portion of the Party's young base. Regarding marijuana legalization: "If you're a seventeen-year-old jit smoking a blunt, pull up your pants and go to church." He has promised that Florida school cafeterias would no longer serve "goyslop," an antisemitic meme term for low-quality food supposedly forced on the masses by Jewish people. A Republican county commissioner asked a detailed question about a Florida development code. The crowd had no patience for her, even though she broadly agreed with Fishback's stance on the issue. They shouted, "You sound like a robot! You don't do anything! America is a sovereign nation!"



Fishback said that he was tired of hearing about white guilt and antisemitism. “One hundred and nine countries couldn’t be wrong!” one person yelled, referring to a white-supremacist trope about the number of countries Jews have supposedly been expelled from. The crowd cheered. “The next governor is going to be a Republican. You can put the Applebee’s mozzarella sticks and the three-dollar margarita on it,” Fishback said. “Sorry, it’s six dollars, happy hour has ended.” The calls from the crowd came swiftly: “Six million! Was it really six million?” Noah, a marketing executive in a gray suit, told me, “This is a new party, not like the old America First. We’re becoming more extreme. Fishback is the first one to hold Nick Fuentes’s values—the first one trying to implement them.”

At the time, Fishback had raised less than twenty-five thousand dollars; the following month, he was polling at less than one per cent with voters over the age of fifty-five. But with voters under thirty-five he was beating Donalds by a factor of four—an indication, perhaps, of one direction the post-Trump right might take. As Dennis Feitosa, a young Groyper-aligned candidate running for Congress in Southern California, told me, “There is a separation between where the Party is culturally and where the candidates are. The candidates still come from pre-podcast time.” In the weeks after we met, Fishback used his online dating profile to conduct voter outreach and sold T-shirts printed with the Groyper frog.

In St. Augustine, at the end of Fishback’s speech, I joined a long line of fans snaking through the restaurant to take photos and talk with him. A high schooler asked if he would come speak at her local Turning Point chapter. Her father shook his hand. A group of college students had come from Jacksonville. “The destiny of a nation is always with the youth,” one said. “We did everything right, and nothing worked out.” The Party just had to catch up to them now. His friend added, “If the Party wants to kick us out, we shall bail and have our own. They can kick us out and die.” ♦

Shouts & Murmurs

- [Our Mom-and-Pop Data Center](#)

Shouts & Murmurs

Our Mom-and-Pop Data Center

By Jed Feiman, Nehemiah Markos

April 06, 2026



Meta operates 26 data centers in the United States and has said it will spend \$600 billion to build new ones in the coming years. . . . It and other tech giants have hired “community affairs” workers to build local trust.

—The Times, in a story about tech companies creating folksy TV ads to change public opinion about the vast computing facilities that power A.I.

For more than five generations, Hillsbrook Servers has prided itself on being a family-owned and -operated data center. Situated on a parcel of what was once bright-green Iowa pasture, our supercomputing facility may not look like much. But, when push comes to shove, we route data that’s honest, sustainable, and community-driven. You haven’t experienced data like Hillsbrook data.

From Dairy to Data

Our journey began in the late twenty-twenties, with the family patriarch, Joseph Glunt, who grew up milking cows (and podcasting) on this very land. But as Zillennials abandoned dairy in favor of alternative milks, like oat and bodega cat, young Joseph knew he had to reinvent the family business. In 2028, heeding the advice of an ad he saw on Instagram, Joseph traded in his family's cows for his first server rack. That's when Hillsbrook Servers was born.

At a time when I.T. infrastructure was dominated by megacorporations exploiting the global supply chain, Hillsbrook had a vision for a new type of data: small-batch, handcrafted, and hyperlocal. From copper and silicon to neodymium and dysprosium, we harvest our minerals and rare-earth metals the old-fashioned way. If it's in a semiconductor, we source it directly from our own front yard—with a shovel, a respirator mask, and an ice-cold pitcher of lemonade—just as Joseph and his daughters did more than a century ago. That's a Hillsbrook promise.

The Hillsbrook Difference

We believe it takes a village to run a colocation facility. On a typical day, you might find Cousin Jasper out back rebooting some automatic transfer switches, or Uncle Perry wheeling in a new power-distribution unit. Little Betsy, the artist of the family, paints all of our red, green, and blue electrical wires by hand. When cables overheat, it's up to Mee-maw to fetch buckets of water from the well. Heck, even our beloved pup, Dale, barks whenever a squirrel's hiding in the networking hardware!

Folks in town should feel comforted knowing that their shopping habits, banking details, medical records, retinal gaze tracking, private browsing history, neural-implant transmissions, smart-fridge contents, toilet analytics, and work e-mails are hosted in perpetuity by a family that cares. At Hillsbrook Servers, your data is more than just ones and zeros; it's nonbinary, like your great-grandparents used to be back in the twenty-twenties.

F.A.Q.s

Now, you might be wondering a few things. How do we deal with cybersecurity? Is it fair for local communities to have to subsidize our electric bill when the economic benefits are unevenly distributed? Should we be allowed to consume ninety-nine per cent of the town's water? Well, if we had our druthers, we wouldn't concern ourselves with those "big-city politics." Our only focus is on powering more A.I., more innovation, and more family values in every byte.

At Hillsbrook, we're not tech bros. We're tech brothers, tech sisters, tech mothers and fathers. We're Small Tech. Moving slow and fixing things. Relaying data on the information super country road. So, the next time you're scrolling in your V.R. contact lenses, you can feel good knowing that your feed may have come from a data center that's rooted in tradition. Humming with electricity . . . and pride. And it looks like a barn.

—From our family to yours,

*Hillsbrook Servers**

**An Amazon-Nvidia-Disney-ExxonMobil-Monsanto company. ♦*

Fiction

- [Rate Your Happiness](#)

Fiction

Rate Your Happiness

How natural it is to fail, to fail to decide, to remain in meaningless motion.

By Catherine Lacey

April 05, 2026



For a few moments, Louise had been sure that she was dying, that a valve or a vein in her body had gotten clogged or burst and she was going to expire right there in the back of the plane, pathetic and dehydrated, travelling alone, hurtling through the air somewhere high above the Midwest, and during those queasy moments that seemed to be her last, Louise didn't think of her parents, who would survive her, and she didn't think of her brother, in Montana with his ranch and several children, or of her sister, in Miami, and she didn't even think of her plentiful minor and major regrets; instead, Louise thought of her small, dark apartment back in Manhattan, how dirty it was right now, how full of humiliating artifacts, like that brochure from a "skin rejuvenation" clinic she'd hidden in the bathroom, and the several worn romance novels stowed under the bed, and the fridge full of decaying takeout in Styrofoam clamshells, as she'd been going through a tough time, a long tough time, and Louise thought of the situation with Diana, how their

relationship, if you could even call it that, had accelerated rapidly during the first month but then lost inertia and turned weird, and yet Louise knew that, if she really did die, Diana would retroactively make their whole thing sound a lot more serious than it had been, and relish telling everyone, for the rest of her life, that her girlfriend, Louise, had tragically died on a flight to San Francisco, and Diana would probably start talking about grief all the time and join more than one support group for young widows, and she would add a third day to her biweekly therapy sessions, and maybe she'd even wear a veil—it wasn't out of the question—a little vintage veil and pillbox hat, and, dear God, she was so beautiful, which made their moody little relationship even more upsetting, even more of a letdown. All of this passed quickly through Louise's mind as she gripped a headrest in the last row, on her way to the bathroom, trying to stay on her feet as her vision tunnelled, as her knees softened, as a cord of drool dripped from the corner of her mouth.

She fell into a woman in a wool cardigan who reacted in time to calmly lower Louise to the floor of the galley kitchen. After alerting a flight attendant, the woman vanished into the rest room to avoid further entanglement. The last thing Louise saw before losing consciousness was this woman's face, wrinkled in an unapologetic way, old, shamelessly old, defiantly so. It seemed there were fewer and fewer of these faces around.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

“Are there any medical professionals on the plane?”

The airline's policy stipulated that flight attendants no longer ask only if there was a doctor on board when a passenger passed out, as passengers were often passing out, much more often than most people realized. Now they would accept anyone who could take a pulse. Fewer and fewer availed themselves. They had their noise-cancelling headphones and their prestige television; the possibility of lawsuits frightened off the most qualified. Veterinarians volunteered in disproportionate numbers.

Louise was out for no more than two minutes, and by the time she came to she'd been propped up against a beverage cart, and some man was kneeling at her side.

He was taking her blood pressure when he saw Louise's eyelids flutter open. He dabbed at the sweat on her brow with a cocktail napkin and pushed a lock of hair out of her face, tucking it carefully behind her ear.

"Are you with me?"

Podcast: The Writer's Voice

[Listen to Catherine Lacey read "Rate Your Happiness."](#)

She nodded.

"What's your name, honey?"

"Louise."

"Louise? Well, where's Thelma?"

He was trying to lighten the mood, but her eyes indicated an unlightenable mood, so he retreated. "I'm just being silly. I'm just being awful. My name is Bruce."

She became aware of the oxygen mask on her face, a cool whisper spilling its way up her nose. Louise focussed everything there. She'd passed out because she'd run out of oxygen and now she was being refilled. Awful. Did he really say awful?

"And what year is it, my friend?"

"2025."

"What month?"

It took her a moment. "December."

Her voice was weak and muffled by the mask, but Bruce had leaned in close.

"Who's the President?"

She didn't want to say. She hated all Presidents. She shut her eyes.

“Do you take any medications?”

“No.”

“No meds. All right. And did you have any breakfast today?”

“Yes.” Louise always ate breakfast. “Toast.”

“Toast? That’s all?”

“Toast and an egg.”

Maybe it had been the egg. How long had that egg been in the fridge? Could have been months, really. What was wrong with her, she wondered, both generally and specifically? What was wrong with her body? Why had everything with Diana gotten so strange? Louise was still too weak to move, but she began to cry. Bruce elevated her legs on a life jacket and wiped away the tears while two flight attendants stared down at her with vacant impatience. One of them was mechanically eating a packet of pretzels.

“Are you in any pain?”

“Some.”

“Where?”

“Everywhere.”

“Can you rate the pain on a scale of one to ten?”

She thought for a moment.

“No.”

“With zero being no pain and ten being the worst pain you’ve ever felt in your life?”

“No.”

Bruce frowned at her, then turned to ask the flight attendants if she'd hit her head in the fall, but the flight attendants hadn't seen it happen. The one eating the pretzels ate her last pretzel, then crushed the little metallic bag in her fist.

By then, Louise had regained enough oxygen to ask a question of her own. "Are you with the airline?"

"No, honey. I'm a nurse. I just happened to be on the plane."

"On the plane?"

"We're on a plane."



She knew that. She didn't want him to think she didn't know that.

"Yes."

Louise stared up at Bruce with the sincere yet dazed seriousness of a terminally ill child. No one was paying him to do this. It was so wild what people would just *do*.

She thanked him, then told the flight attendants that she was very sorry for the trouble. No one responded to Louise, but Bruce smiled an almost imperceptible smile.

“The airline,” she stammered, “the airline should give him a free ticket.”

“That’s not our policy,” one of the flight attendants said.

Twenty minutes after hitting the floor, Louise had enough energy to stand and return to her seat, but she was still pale, so the flight attendants arranged to have Bruce moved to the seat next to hers.

Once she was vertical, shame and anxiety arrived; she was not an adorable and delicate child who deserved the care of helpful grownups but, rather, a 1099-receiving adult with the kind of health insurance that didn’t cover anything, and would certainly not reimburse her for expenses incurred out of state if she, as she had been advised, sought medical attention upon landing.

After Bruce had stowed his personal item and settled in beside her, and had been given an extra tomato juice for his service, he looked through the films and TV shows available for in-flight entertainment, but nothing appealed. He glanced at his phone, then put it away. He drank down his can of juice in one go, opened and closed the flight map, reclined his seat slightly, then pushed it upright again.

“How’s that reading now?” Bruce checked the number on the oxygen monitor still clipped to Louise’s finger. “Ninety-five. That’s good.”

Louise apologized for having interrupted his flight, but Bruce insisted that he was happy to help, that it was no problem at all. He did not admit that he’d been a little disappointed that it was such a minor issue, and not something exciting, something like an aneurysm, which would have required an emergency landing. He liked to make a difference in people’s lives, a big difference, and to do so at all times, if possible.

“Where do you work for real?” She wasn’t especially in the mood to talk, but sensed that he was.

“Mount Sinai. Upper East.”

At which point she remembered that her father had a friend named Bruce, a nurse who worked at Mount Sinai, someone she'd never met but whom he'd mentioned, on and off, for a few years, during his erratic visits to the city.

What compelled Louise to ask Bruce if he knew anyone named Harry from New Orleans? What compelled her to say his last name and his profession, and to confess that this man was her father?

Bruce was visibly shocked, and Louise smiled, nodding. "Yes, he's my dad, yes."

The recent deprivation of oxygen to her brain had perhaps washed away her good sense, as her father was not a topic of conversation she enjoyed, nor had it ever been a good idea to associate herself with him, as she knew he had a habit of betraying friends and lovers—it was never clear who was who—and leaving them with resentments, debts, and unresolved issues. Her father moved through the world like a cruise ship, promising a gaudy good time, a break from reality, yet he mainly left waste and hangovers in his wake.

"What are the odds! How is Harry doing?"

"He's fine."

"That's good. Still in Alaska?"

Harry had never lived in Alaska, but it sounded like something he might have told people.

"Still there."

Why had she brought him up? Why? Now she had joined herself to Bruce with the bruised intimacy of family.

"You're the designer, aren't you? Like, high fashion or something?"

It would have been a stretch to call her tiny label with a cult following high fashion, but she had quit the industry years ago now, tired of the instability and the long hours, tired of the fashion people and the Fashion Weeks and

the everything. After a brief stint in marketing, she'd had a mild nervous breakdown and tried to pivot to an even more impossible career in acting, but that hadn't panned out either, so then it was costume design, but there was something so lonely about making clothes for fictional worlds, and, after two other false starts, she'd ended up narrating audiobooks, specifically murder mysteries, and now she'd developed enough of a reputation to enjoy steady work, and there were even listeners who sought out her particular voice reading those brutal stories.

"That's crazy," Bruce said, to each turn in her career history. "That's literally crazy. That's the craziest thing I've ever heard." Though he made this last declaration with almost no affect at all.

To change the subject, Louise asked question after question about his life as a nurse, about his habits, his schedules, and how he stayed up for so long, and whether he had ever considered doing anything else.

"For, like, five minutes I wanted to be a journalist, but Dad told me that it was impractical, that I had to study something real, like plumbing, or carpentry, or nursing."

Bruce's father had been dead for ten years, but Bruce still teared up when he spoke of him. The tears came and stood alert in his eyes, looked out at the world, then retreated.

No one had ever suggested to Louise that she do something practical, but she didn't let herself consider why that might have been.

"How's it reading now?" He checked the oxygen monitor again. "Ninety-six. That's good."

At this, the two strangers returned to a parallel silence for the rest of the flight, both of them thinking about their fathers while trying to think of something else.

The moment they hit the ground, Louise sent Diana a text—"fainted during the flight for some reason. got hooked up to an oxygen tank. maybe I'm

dying lol”—and watched her phone for a while, waiting for a panicked response, but nothing came.

When Bruce asked where in the city she was staying, Louise was grateful to have a reason to stop monitoring her phone. It turned out that they were going to the same neighborhood—“What are the chances! What a small world!”—so they shared a cab, and it was only then, only once Louise had regained her color and reentered the more natural light of the world, that Bruce could see it.

“You look so much like your dad.”

“People say that sometimes.”

“And you don’t like it?”

“Well, I don’t mind it—I really don’t—but I don’t see it.”

But of course she did mind, and she did see. That was just the problem. Big, sad, stupid eyes that gave everything away, that bulged when he was angry, when she was angry, though they both tried not to be so angry, tried and tried with mixed results. Harry had once been angry about the indignities of the world (Ronald Reagan, the degradation of the Louisiana wetlands, the *AIDS* crisis), but as he’d gotten older he became angrier about his own tragedies: that his wife had left him, that his father had been a scammer, that everyone always abandoned him, that even the dogs he’d adopted had fled.

For Louise, it had been the opposite. She’d first been angry about her parents, her heartbreaks, her missed opportunities, but in recent years it had shifted, and now she was unmanageably pissed about corporate control of the government, tax-supported genocide, *ICE* raids, and the way people boarding trains always tried to muscle their way on before the people exiting could get off. These were communal angers, though she took them all so personally, and the fire of her fury fed endlessly on the era.

“I don’t know . . . what Harry . . . told you about me. . . .”

Bruce was blushing. It had taken every shred of his limited courage to bring up Harry again. “Well, Harry and I were very close, and I cared for him very

much. And the thing is, I don't really know what happened, for him, on his side. But, if he called, I'd be happy to hear his voice. You can tell him that. I wish him the best, I—I really do."

She looked out the window.

"Do you talk to your dad much?"

"Not really."

"Does that bother you?"

They were in San Francisco proper now, their cab surrounded by white cars—driverless cars, covered in cameras—that all belonged to the same company. Each carried one passenger in the back seat, all of them busy on their phones.

"No."

Bruce wanted to give her advice, to say it was important to have a relationship with your father, but he stopped himself. There was nothing particularly paternal about Harry; he'd seemed to Bruce something like a little boy who'd lost his mother in the grocery store but was trying to play it off like he was simply there on his own, just doing a little shopping.

The cab arrived at Bruce's stop first, and he asked if she wanted to meet up for coffee that week—"Sure, of course"—though Louise wasn't so sure. They exchanged phone numbers, and as the cab pulled away she unthinkingly found and played the last voice note her father had sent her, two years prior, which she had saved and never replied to:

You're unhappy about your childhood, and I can't help you with that. You had a perfectly *happy* childhood and now you remember it being awful because the culture—the culture wants you to be unhappy about your childhood. And that's not my fault. It's not anything I did. I can't understand you, why you want to suffer, why you want me to be the bad guy, and it doesn't make a bit of sense why you have to be so unhappy about the life I worked hard to give you. So, that's it. That's what I've got. You can take it or leave it. Makes no difference to me.

The recording ended, and the cab-driver acted as if he hadn't heard it. They arrived, silently, at Joan and Lynn's address, and the driver got out to lift her luggage from the trunk. Her friends were waiting on the sidewalk, smiling and holding hands. They opened their arms and embraced her.

That evening, as Louise sat at the counter in her friends' kitchen, watching Joan cook and waiting for Lynn to get off a work call, a response finally arrived from Diana: three exclamation points, and no actual words. This was unusual, as Diana often communicated in paragraph-long texts, or in voice messages that Louise had to play on double speed only to discover that they contained no real information at all.

She stared at the "!!!" for a while, waiting for the rest of the text to arrive, or perhaps for Diana to call, or at least for an "omg baby are you ok?!" But nothing came. Diana might have lost signal on the subway, or in an elevator, or maybe she'd dropped her phone down a sidewalk grate again.

Joan and Lynn's eldest daughter, the ten-year-old, climbed onto the barstool beside Louise.

"Long time no see, lady."

The child was speaking like a baby gangster, yet earnestly. Louise tried to engage her with the secret handshake they'd come up with on her last visit, but the effort failed.

"Kid stuff," the eldest daughter said.

"That's your aunt Lou," Joan shouted without looking up from her cutting board. Neither Joan nor Lynn had any sisters, so all their friends were deemed aunts.

"I know," the child said.

Louise had always felt unsure of how to interact with the eldest daughter. She possessed an abnormal calm. As a toddler, she'd never cared for peekaboo, displayed little interest in toys, and, from the moment she could stand up, she'd station herself at her parents' bookshelf, as if reading the titles and making little judgments about her mothers' taste.

“You’re getting so tall!”

“I’ve never been able to figure out why adults find it necessary to point out the increasing height of a child.”

The eldest daughter stared squarely at Louise, waiting on a rebuttal for a few moments before she gave up, took an eight-hundred-page fantasy novel from the counter, and retreated to a reading nook built into one of the window recesses.

The younger daughter had arrived with foreknowledge of the role her older sister had already claimed. She took the other route in turn, spending all six years of her life wearing a perpetual grin and giggling through almost everything she said. Earlier that year she had decided that she would wear only pink and yellow—down to her socks, underwear, and pajamas—and that she would like to be referred to as Sprinkles. Her parents had complied without question.

“Are you still dating the same woman?” Lynn had ended her call and immediately made a pair of pastis cocktails, a particular blend that she and Louise had invented in college. That everyone else found the drink too bitter to tolerate was part of the appeal.

“Diana?”

“Is she the model?”

“No, that ended a while ago.”

“Lemme see a picture.”

Diana had set her own best selfie as Louise’s lock screen—smiling, her hair blown back, the Manhattan skyline behind her.

“I thought this one was the model.”

“Diana’s a publicist.”

“And how’s it going?”

“Her work?”

“Obviously not—I mean the relationship.”

At that moment, Sprinkles ran into the room, laughing as she handed Louise a bouquet of slightly wilted dandelions she’d picked in the park that morning, then ran away.

Unaccustomed to living with someone like Sprinkles, Louise was nearly moved to tears by this delivery of weeds, but Lynn had barely noticed. When Louise hung out with her friends who’d become parents, she always wondered if they were paying either too much or too little attention to their children—but maybe it was impossible to pay exactly the right amount of attention to a child. Maybe that was just the problem.

“I mean, is it serious, or what?”

Louise took a long sip of her drink. “I don’t know.”

One of the issues with Diana, Louise explained, was that she had this habit of nonchalantly telling anyone—strangers on the subway, her dog-walker, bartenders—the most dramatic things that had ever happened to her, and maybe that was fine, but she really did seem to enjoy shocking people. Her older brother had been murdered when she was nine, and Diana brought it up a lot.

“Well, that does seem like a pretty big trauma, right?”

“Except it was actually a half brother and she’d met him only once, and she didn’t even find out about it until she was, like, fifteen or something.”



“Maybe it feels normal to her to be so forthcoming,” Lynn offered.

“See, that’s the problem.”

“What’s the problem?” Joan asked, settling in beside them with a glass of white wine.

“Diana. She’s—I don’t know, I think she’s too dramatic. Everything is either the best or worst thing that’s ever happened to her. Nothing’s just normal.”

Joan and Lynn were staring at Louise with entirely blank expressions. Was she being ungenerous? A self-hating woman? She could never be sure.

“I don’t know. I wonder if I’m the right person for Diana.”

“But are you happy when you’re with her?” Joan asked.

“I guess sometimes I am.”

Louise touched her phone screen to look at the picture of Diana again—gorgeous Diana smiling into the wind, all that thick hair billowing. She had sent no further texts about the fainting incident.

“Well that’s something, isn’t it? I mean, you can’t be happy all the time. But sometimes is good.”

“I guess so.”

Louise didn’t want to admit it to her friends, but, for some time now, she had been trying to work up the courage to break things off, while always getting sucked in deeper. She’d met Diana’s mother accidentally, and she’d rationalized making Diana a copy of her keys by telling herself that it was simply more convenient this way, and somehow they were planning a trip to Greece in the summer, as Diana was friends with a Greek shipping heiress whose family owned several homes. But Louise changed the subject. Talking about Diana only reminded her of the radio silence. It was one thing to always be on the verge of breaking up, but it was quite another to be ignored after a near-death experience.

Dinner was a delicate salad that Joan had made from thirty-seven dollars’ worth of farmers’-market produce, and a fresh pasta from an extraordinarily expensive local business that the residents of the Lower Haight enthusiastically supported. There was no kid-friendly option for the girls; there never was. Instead, they had the same meal as their parents, dining at a child-size table in a corner of the kitchen. Once they’d finished, the children cleared their dishes and wiped their table down with a spray bottle and sponge. Louise couldn’t help but watch them, amazed by their coöperation and efficiency, but Joan and Lynn continued, you might say, to ignore their children.

That night, just as she was falling asleep, Louise was visited by an image that occasionally haunted her, something she’d seen late one night, years earlier, on a trip through a rural corner of Oaxaca. Hundreds of ants on a concrete porch had lifted the corpse of a cockroach as if they were going to carry it home for dinner, but their communication must have broken down, because instead of hauling the roach away, they spun it in a circle while Louise filmed the scene with her phone.

Louise got out of bed, groped her way across the dark room, found her phone tethered to the charger, then scrolled back through her photos to find the grainy twenty-seven-second video of the ants. She watched it twice,

checked Diana's profile for any activity (there was none), considered texting her, refused her own suggestion to do so, then got back in bed.

A message from Diana had come in overnight: "out DANCING call u tmrrw." Louise mentally drafted and rejected possible replies as she ate pancakes with the eldest daughter, but sent nothing.

"Do you have a cellphone?"

Louise started to get it out, assuming the girl wanted to show her something.

"No, I don't want to see it. But you should get rid of it."

"Well, I mean, your moms have cellphones."

Louise sometimes felt like a little sister in the presence of the eldest daughter, engaged in endless attempts to earn her favor.

"I've spoken to Lynn and Joan about the issue, but they're too far gone." She put her fork down. "It's actually really sad if you think about it."

"So you're one of those anti-tech kids."

"I might be the only one."

"Well, Lynn has a pretty complicated job, so it might be hard to—"

"She has *three* phones. Did you know that?"

"Work, personal, and . . ."

"Two work phones. That tells you something, doesn't it?"

"Momma Lynn is very busy," Louise said, and again the eldest daughter deployed that withering stare. She shouldn't have said "Momma," though Lynn and Joan referred to themselves this way. The eldest daughter stood and put her plate and fork in the dishwasher.

“We agree on a lot of things, philosophically, Lynn and I. But she’s been weakened by techno-optimism.”

Aunt Lou felt a moment of real terror for this child, a fear that she would never be able to accept the world as it was, that she might have the makings of a domestic terrorist, a demagogue, a far-right podcaster, or worse. It was an aunt’s job to assess a niece like this, wasn’t it? She could see the potential personality flaws in the girls and love them without the warping furor of maternity.

At the same time, Louise felt an angry presence inside herself, a need to tell the girl that it was Lynn’s techno-optimism that paid for her cushy Bay Area life—her private school, her fresh pasta, her renovated duplex. But, instead, she just smiled at the back of the eldest daughter’s head as she left the room.

It wasn’t that Louise hated San Francisco, but it was impossible not to notice, while in San Francisco, that it was absolutely full of things she hated. Alone on a walk through the city, she narrated her hatred to herself. Someone was always pitching their startup to someone else, and people were always on a jog, but almost no one was ever walking to a particular destination, and those not jogging were isolated in their hermetically sealed S.U.V.s, forever trying to park. There was a blithe, mildly stoned look in everyone’s eyes, and most of the women were dressed like gnomes while all the men appeared ergonomically outfitted to climb a cliff face but were instead commuting to their office jobs.

The driverless cars were the newest hateable thing. Louise crossed in front of one as it idled at a stop sign, then she stopped for a moment in the center of the intersection to stare into all its cameras. The passenger in the back eventually looked up from her phone, noticed Louise, and locked eyes with this bewildered-looking woman blocking the crosswalk. Louise then hurried to the curb and turned to watch the car whirr away.

A decade ago, back when she could still hold the eldest daughter with one arm, Louise hadn’t possessed or desired a smartphone. It had been easy for her to declare at the time that she’d never get one, never be so enslaved, but then she’d started freelancing for a company that had made it impossible to get into the corporate headquarters without scanning a QR code, and

she'd caved, humiliated, though no one seemed to remember her previously staunch refusal. She'd left that job after a few months but kept the phone, and now it was in her back pocket, pressed against her ass as she waited for it to vibrate.

After two hours of walking and hating, Louise arrived at Union Square and took a break on a bench equipped with spikes that made it impossible for someone to lie down. She felt the sun on her face and watched people walking through the open plaza.

In the middle of the square, a man was frantically running around, carrying a microphone and what looked like a large gilded frame. A few people were filming him with their phones; some were trying to get away from him while others struggled to get closer. He wore a bright-orange suit and a purple tie, a costume that only added to Louise's confusion. Soon, enough of a crowd had formed around him that he was no longer visible.

"What are the chances!"

Louise turned to see where the voice had come from, but he was right in front of her, emerging from the throng. It was Bruce.

"Imagine that!" He sat on the bench beside her, on the other side of a spike, then went in for a one-armed hug.

She asked if he knew what was going on with that crowd, that man, and Bruce said it was the Rate Your Happiness guy.

"The what?"

"The influencer? He asks people to rate their happiness on a scale of one to ten."

"That's it?"

"It's sort of interesting. I watched him for a little while. But you! What about you? How are you feeling? Have you seen a doctor?"

She had already forgotten about the fainting, and it was only then that she realized she hadn't even told Joan or Lynn about it, though she would tell them that night over dinner, as a backstory to explain how she'd run into Bruce and spent most of the afternoon with him, how they'd walked around the city for a while, then impulsively stopped in a crystal store, where Bruce had cried, all of a sudden, just started crying the moment he found out that Louise and Harry hadn't spoken in two years.

"That would have been around the time I got his postcard from Alaska." The young man behind a glass case full of obsidian offered Bruce a tissue. "He said he'd moved there and that he was thinking of me, but there was no return address, and when I tried to call him, someone told me it was the wrong number."

So he had, maybe, moved to Alaska.

"Do you think something's happened to him?"

Louise had always assumed that her sister or brother would call if anything serious occurred. They were still in touch with him, as far as she knew.

"I'll ask my sister."

"Oh, would you? Oh, gosh, I'd love to hear from him. I hadn't realized how much I—I hadn't realized, you know, how worried I've been."

Then Bruce told her that the whole situation reminded him of something from his favorite novel, a title that Louise had heard of but never read. Bruce recited several lines from it, from memory, right there in the crystal store, and the boy behind the counter applauded him at the end. But as Louise recounted the scene to her friends that evening, all she remembered was the last line: "So much shines in absence—whereas presence, high and lonesome, can tire."

Lynn, frustrated not to know the source, began searching for it on her phone, but nothing came up. Louise must have gotten the quote wrong and couldn't remember the book title, so she promised Lynn that she would text Bruce

about it, but she didn't really mean it and was already hoping that Bruce would forget about her and fail to get in touch again.

"High and lonesome," he'd said in the crystal store. "Don't you love that? Doesn't that seem true?"

A few days later, Joan and Lynn loaded the girls and Louise into their van to go for a hike in the park right across the Golden Gate Bridge. Schools were closed for the holidays, and the weather was still unseasonably mild, so thousands of other well-resourced families were on their way to do the same thing. The traffic was heavy, especially where each car had to wait its turn to enter the one-lane tunnel into the Headlands.

"It feels like we're commuting to work," the eldest daughter said, and no one responded except for Sprinkles, who giggled to herself and said, "Work," then giggled again.

As soon as they'd arrived, and parked, and set out on the trail, the sheer force of nature did seem worth the trouble. They all fell into a satisfied silence for a while, until the eldest daughter gave a speech about how ridiculous it was that they'd driven all the way out here when they could have walked through the park near their house and seen the same ocean.

Once the group reached Rodeo Beach, however, even the eldest daughter seemed to silently agree that it was a perfect day, a perfect plan. Joan rolled two enormous blankets out across the stony sand and asked Louise when she'd last visited the Headlands. Louise said that she'd never been here, that they'd always said they'd take her someday, but the weather had never coöperated.

"But I know we came once, yes, at least once," Lynn said. "A couple years ago?"

"It was seven years ago, because I was three," the eldest daughter declared, without looking up from her Jane Austen novel. "We watched a vulture eating a dead pelican, and Aunt Lou threw up."

"What? I don't think I ever—"

“No, you totally did. Right there on the beach.”

There it was again, that little-sister feeling.

“How do you not remember that?”

The eldest daughter put her book down as she asked this, and Louise thought Joan or Lynn might reprimand their child for her tone, which was pandering and barbed, but when she looked to her friends they were staring out at the ocean. Sprinkles was balancing a few stones atop one another with great concentration.

“I mean, I’m just curious,” the eldest daughter said, her voice veering meaner and meaner. “If it happened to you, then why don’t you remember it?”

“Well, I’m . . . ” But Louise really didn’t have a reason.

“I read somewhere that people with bad memories are actually happier, in the long run,” Joan offered.

This reminded Louise of the Rate Your Happiness guy—had they ever heard of him? Lynn had seen his videos, and her company had even worked with him once on sponsored content. She thought the whole thing was ridiculous, because basically everyone he asked said eight or nine, and whenever someone said something lower, he’d grill them about it until they changed their answer.

Their cellphones didn’t really work in the Headlands, but one of Lynn’s work phones was tethered to a satellite, so she was able to stream a few of the influencer’s posts, which were edited together at a breakneck speed, squeezing a dozen micro-interviews into a single minute. The newest one had been uploaded just hours earlier, and Louise, despite herself, searched for her face in the background. She wasn’t there.

“Can we turn the phones off, please? We’re supposed to be bonding as a family.”

And all the adults obeyed the eldest daughter.

On the hike back out to the car, the trails were even more crowded, and, as another group approached them on a narrow part of the path, Louise noticed the old woman from the plane, the woman in the wool cardigan, the last face she'd seen before passing out. The old woman's face lit with recognition, and what, indeed, were the chances of this? Once they were closer, however, her expression turned quite serious, and she reached out and took Louise by the shoulders.

"Your father—" she said, pinning her reddened eyes on Louise.

"My what?"

"Your father and I think it would be best if you asked for a prenuptial—"

The woman's daughter intervened before she could continue. "Sorry about that." The daughter peeled her mother's hands away from Louise. "She's here, but she's not *here*."

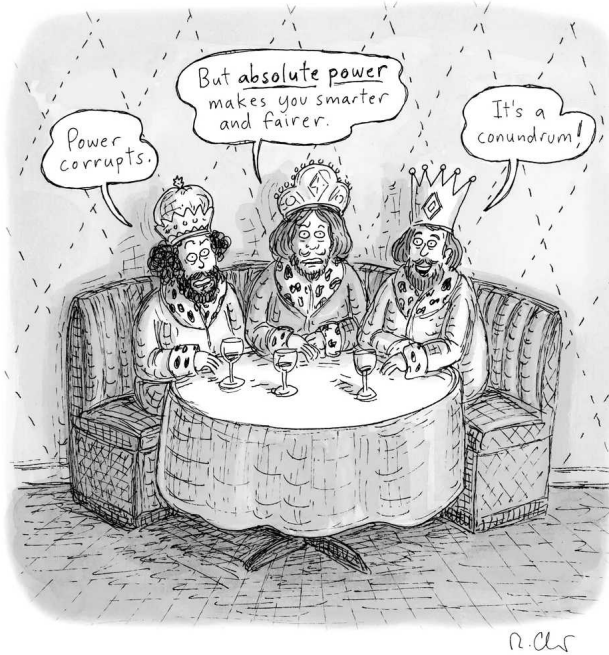
Lynn and Joan and their girls were several paces ahead, and had seen nothing. Louise considered telling them what had happened, the wild coincidence of it, but then she remembered that the woman on the plane had had gray hair and this woman only had gray roots. So it wasn't a story after all. She kept it to herself.

Louise didn't hear from Diana, or from Bruce, for several days, and she assumed that that was it, that they must both have given up on the Louise situation, but on the last full day of her trip, as she was leaving the duplex for a walk, she nearly ran into Bruce on the sidewalk.

"We have to stop meeting like this." He was cradling a large rabbit as if it were a baby.

"What the—"

"Oh, this is Elmo. Well, St. Elmo Rattlesnake Jumper Cables Lancaster-Johnson."



He smiled at her, then added that Elmo was his friends' pet and he was taking him for a bath at the vet down the street.

"Walk with me, talk with me," Bruce said, as if referencing some old bit that they shared. They walked together, first to the vet, then aimlessly, giving each other reports of their time in San Francisco, making the usual complaints that New Yorkers make about the West Coast. They scowled together at the driverless cars, and Bruce made jokes about his friends' polycule.

"I mean, the sheer optimism of the whole thing. The logistics. Where do they even get the energy?"

Louise genuinely laughed at this, so maybe they weren't so different, she and Bruce, and maybe they could, as a team, solve all their troubles and traumas with her dad, with his Harry. In a lull in the conversation, she thought of asking him if he and her dad had been boyfriends or something, but she couldn't get the phrasing right in her head, and before she could say anything Bruce interrupted her thoughts.

"You look sad."

"Compared to what?"

This question came out reflexively, with real accusation, and Louise recognized her tone as belonging to the eldest daughter.

“Oh, never mind. I shouldn’t have said anything. I know how tiring a vacation can be.”

A cold silence passed between them, during which they kept walking down a charming little street, past all its charming little architecture, and when they came upon a clapboard sign advertising an open house they agreed, almost without speaking, to go in, to consider an apartment for sale in a city they both openly disdained.

A real-estate agent with a huge, demented smile stood at the entrance, handing out her card, which was printed with a portrait of her that looked much the same as she did in that moment—toothy grin, big hair. “Welcome, welcome,” she said. “Welcome.” And the welcomes kept coming out of her, compulsive and hopeful and for no one in particular.

Bruce and Louise made their rounds through this two-bedroom-one-and-a-half-bathroom-plus-office-nook “opportunity.” The finishes were nice, but the ceilings felt low, and it was unnecessary for either of them to say this aloud.

Louise’s phone buzzed in her pocket. It was Diana.

She’d been meaning to call, Diana explained, but so many things kept getting in the way. Louise said nothing in reply.

“Are you there? Where are you?”

“I’m looking at an apartment with Bruce.”

“A what? An apartment? And who is Bruce?”

“My friend? My friend Bruce?”

Louise made eye contact with Bruce as she said his name, and he seemed glad to be called her friend instead of merely the nurse who happened to respond to her minor vasovagal emergency on the plane and who was

coincidentally an erstwhile acquaintance of her estranged father. It was nice, instead, to be a friend.

“Are you moving there? Why are you looking at an apartment?”

“Why not?”

Again Louise recognized the voice of the eldest daughter rising from her own throat.

“So, is this an O.K. time to talk?”

“I don’t think so.”

Just then the lights in the apartment flicked off and on, then off again, leaving them in the dark, so Louise hung up. She could tell that Diana was about to end things with her, but Louise had other problems, big problems, or maybe a million small ones. Low blood pressure. Anemia. Something with her dad. Maybe Bruce was her problem now, too. She wasn’t sure what to do about any of it.

The real-estate agent was frantically laughing and telling everyone not to panic, not to worry, that she’d get it all sorted out, but the crowd took this as their cue to leave, and, out in the street, Bruce said that he had to be going, had to pick up Elmo. They hugged goodbye.

“If you do check in with your sister or something, if you find out how Harry’s doing . . . well, let me know. Or tell him that you met me, if that feels right, or have your sister tell him that I said hello or, well, whatever feels right. And text me or call, if you’re comfortable with that. If you want to.”

She watched Bruce walk away from her, down the tree-lined street. She watched him with pointed attention, as if Bruce were someone she had loved enormously, a great love of her life whom mere circumstance had kept her from loving completely.

Louise continued her walk alone, and as dusk began to fall she felt an uptick in the ambient menace of the city, a real sense of mayhem. None of the

streetlights were working, and the driverless cars were stalled everywhere. Passengers were abandoning them, like rats scuttling off a sinking ship, and people stood on the sidewalks, looking at their phones, or looking at the city, frowning, desperate. “What are we supposed to do—walk there? Walk two whole miles?”

But Louise, untroubled by their troubles, was having a conversation with Diana in her head.

“What about Halloween—what was that all about? Weren’t we in love, at least a little, at least right then?” But the imaginary Diana didn’t have anything to say in return; she pushed a lock of her hair behind one ear and looked out into the distance. “You know, you were the last thing I thought about before I died,” Louise told her.

“But you didn’t die,” the imaginary Diana corrected.

“I mean, when I thought I was about to die.”

But maybe she really was dying, because how would she know, because why had she passed out on the plane to begin with, and why did Bruce think that she looked sad? Without quite realizing it, she had walked into a high-end cosmetics store, full of mirrors reflecting back her bulging eyes and the bags beneath them.

A very pretty clerk with a motionless face approached her, but Louise just nodded and got her phone out to call her sister.

“Did something happen to Dad? Is he in Alaska?”

Many things, she was somehow surprised to learn from Jolene, had happened to her father.

“We decided not to say anything until you asked.”

“Well, I’m asking now.”

Her father had indeed moved to Alaska, first to a cabin with some kind of cat-sitting deal for a forest firefighter he’d met somewhere, but then he’d

tried to stay for good, had gotten into a vague investment opportunity that didn't go as he'd hoped. He'd gone broke, again, and then he'd had a mild stroke and was now stuck there. Luckily, the firefighter was back, and he was, it seemed, taking care of Harry, more or less.

Louise didn't say much as her sister gave this report. She occupied herself with rubbing various serums and creams into her face, hoping they'd take immediate effect.

"Are you still there?"

"I'm here," Louise said, defeated by the present.

"Well, I don't want to tell you what to do," Jolene said, lying. "But if you keep ignoring him you'll regret it. You will."

"I'm not ignoring him," Louise corrected. "We're ignoring *each other*. It's mutual."

Then the lights went out in the store, and one of the clerks shrieked in the dark, and another told her to remain calm. Outside, the street was now clogged with driverless cars, their high beams on, in confusion, in paralysis, lacking any traffic lights to tell them what to do. How natural it is to fail, to fail to decide, to remain in meaningless motion, like all those ants with their cockroach corpse, or like all of us; how active and yet inert life felt in this entirely too modern world.

Louise returned to the street with real intent, finally carrying her contradictory desires with total clarity, and a pilfered tube of eye serum in her pocket, something that promised to illuminate her from within. ♦

This is drawn from "My Stalkers."

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Books

We Are All Constantly Mutating—and That's a Good Thing

Genetic research has been complicating the idea of the genome as a determinative blueprint.

By Jerome Groopman

April 06, 2026



As I am writing this, my DNA is changing. And, as you read this, so is yours. People tend to assume that the genes we inherit from our parents are a fixed blueprint for our growth and development, immutable throughout our lives, and that the DNA in each cell of our body is the same as in every other cell. In fact, changes in our DNA, known as mutations, occur from the time we are in the womb until our death—a phenomenon that has become increasingly important in medical science as our understanding of human genomics becomes more sophisticated. In “Beyond Inheritance” (Riverhead), the science journalist Roxanne Khamsi provides a useful guide to this body of research and its far-reaching, sometimes surprising

implications. “You are a slightly different genetic version of yourself today from yesterday, and will be different yet again tomorrow,” she writes.

These kinds of mutations are called somatic mutations, derived from the Greek word *soma*, which means “body,” and they are less familiar to most people than inherited mutations are. A famous example of the latter is the hemophilia that affected many of the male descendants of Queen Victoria. Victoria, in common with some of her daughters and granddaughters, was a carrier of a mutation for hemophilia. None of these women manifested the traits of the disease, because the mutation occurred on one of their two X chromosomes, the other of which lacked the mutation. But three generations of male offspring, each having only one X chromosome, inherited the full-blown bleeding disorder.

Although hemophilia is usually a hereditary condition, there are some patients whose relatives do not have the abnormal gene. These people have a somatic mutation. Few of us are unfortunate enough to spontaneously develop such a severe malady, but somatic mutations occur in everyone all the time; we are all collections of errors, mosaics of altered DNA. Each time a cell divides, its DNA is copied, but mistakes inevitably creep in. The adult body, after all, contains some thirty trillion cells, about four million of which are replaced in any given second, and the human genome is made up of six billion letters of DNA. “By some estimates you acquire trillions of new mutations a day,” Khamisi writes. Environmental factors—such as radiation, sunburn, air pollution, and smoking—can increase the rate at which errors in DNA copying happen, but genetic mutations are not rare aberrations; they are intrinsic to the system by which cells reproduce.

Recent advances in sequencing have allowed researchers to analyze the DNA of individual cells and make comparisons with that of other cells in the same organism. This technique has brought to light the extraordinary genetic diversity that exists within all of us. And, because mutations occur constantly, they accumulate as we grow older—to the point where, according to Khamisi, a single blood cell taken from someone who has reached the age of a hundred is likely to contain more than four thousand mutations.

There are some conditions that make our mosaic nature outwardly apparent. At the start of the twentieth century, a German dermatologist named Alfred Blaschko presented data on a hundred and forty patients who had patterns of differently pigmented skin across their bodies. Bands of darker skin often followed similar patterns from patient to patient—a series of V's along the upper spine, S's along the abdomen, and an inverted U across each breast. These patterns are still known as the “lines of Blaschko,” and are evidence of what we now recognize as mosaicism. The first person to suggest that they arose from a mutation was a Soviet surgeon, Moisey Zlotnikov, who, in 1945, wrote about a twenty-four-year-old woman from a peasant family who had been mocked as a devil when she was a child because, on her left side, her face and body were covered with bands of variously colored skin: dark brown, light brown, and crimson. The bands stopped precisely at the midline of her body, and the pigmentation of her right side was entirely normal. Zlotnikov wrote that the condition was likely caused by a mutation that had occurred very early in embryonic development, a supposition that was confirmed decades later by genetic analysis.

Other mosaicisms manifest themselves internally. Khamsi cites the example of hemimegalencephaly, a rare disorder in which half of the brain is abnormally enlarged. A paper published in 2006 presented a case of identical twins, only one of whom had the condition—indicating that the mutation was not inherited but, rather, arose during development. Patients with hemimegalencephaly can suffer from unremitting epilepsy and intellectual disabilities, and often need neurosurgery during infancy. By examining brain tissue removed in such surgeries, a team led by researchers at Boston Children's Hospital has identified mutations in genes that control the growth of neurons, including one affecting an enzyme that is important in cell proliferation. This discovery made a new treatment possible: in preliminary trials, two children with severe epilepsy became seizure-free after receiving a medication that inhibited the enzyme.

Of the various diseases associated with mutations, cancer is surely the most prominent, and it, too, can be thought of as a kind of mosaic disorder, because the mutated DNA of malignant cells contrasts with the healthy genetic makeup of normal cells. In 2014, I treated a woman in her seventies who had developed discomfort in her abdomen and then rapidly became jaundiced. A CT scan revealed a tumor in her pancreas that had spread to her

liver. A genetic analysis of the tumor showed several mutations, including one in a gene that controls the production of p53, a key protein. Our normal p53 has been described as “the guardian of the genome,” because it acts to prevent cells with DNA damage from multiplying. If a mutation occurs in p53 itself, that regulation is lost, and further errors proliferate. Between fifty and seventy-five per cent of all pancreatic cancers have this mutation, and it can drive the growth and spread of the tumor.

The patient received chemotherapy, and for several months the tumors in her pancreas and her liver shrank. But soon thereafter the cancer aggressively grew again. Tumors are heterogeneous in their genetic makeup. When a cancer becomes resistant to chemotherapy, analysis of DNA in individual cells shows increased diversity, with certain mutations found in some cells and different mutations in others. Such mutations can accelerate a tumor’s growth, making the cancer harder and harder to treat and sometimes, as in this instance, claiming the patient’s life. A familiar problem in cancer treatment is that, by attacking a heterogeneous mass of mutating cells with chemotherapy and radiation, we impose a kind of artificial Darwinism, in which only the fittest—that is, the most treatment-resistant cells—survive. Khamsi spends a chapter talking about the work of a doctor named Robert Gatenby, who has applied evolutionary models to cancer treatment. In the model he espouses, chemotherapy and radiation may be administered less aggressively, to insure that the population of cells that makes up the tumor maintains its genetic diversity rather than continually mutating new ways to resist treatment.

When I was twenty-eight and training as a hematologist, I developed a high fever, shortness of breath, and a dry cough. I was hospitalized, and a chest X-ray showed that my lungs, instead of being translucent, had a ground-glass appearance that is characteristic of some types of pneumonia. I was soon given a diagnosis of bacterial pneumonia caused by a bacterium called mycoplasma. With treatment, I gradually recovered as my body produced antibodies to deal with the invasive bacterial threat.

The role of antibodies in combatting infection was first described in 1891, by the pioneering German physician Paul Ehrlich, but for a long time it was assumed that our bodies must possess a gene for every single antibody we might one day need to make. However, in the nineteen-seventies, just a

couple of years before I contracted pneumonia, this belief began to be overturned, thanks to a series of experiments conducted by a Japanese molecular biologist named Susumu Tonegawa, who later won a Nobel Prize for his work. Tonegawa showed that our adaptive immune system is reliant on genetic mutation.

During an infection, foreign particles, known as antigens, circulate in our bodies. To neutralize them, cells called B lymphocytes produce a wide range of antibodies, Y-shaped proteins that at their tips have sites that capture the antigens. The mechanism that Tonegawa discovered was a kind of mutation that occurs only in lymphocytes. As I lay in the hospital, B lymphocytes released from my bone marrow into my bloodstream were maturing in my spleen and lymph nodes, my DNA shuffling as if it were a deck of cards. The pathogen was new to my system, and sections of my DNA moved around and recombined—an immunological cut-and-paste—to form a new code, one that could produce antibodies capable of fighting mycoplasma. Only a fraction of the human genome is involved in making antibodies, and yet the potential of this section to recombine in novel ways is almost limitless. According to Khamisi, we are capable of producing up to a quintillion different antibodies, each with a unique shape.

Sometimes the mutating DNA yields antibodies that turn against the body's own tissue. The aberrant action of our mosaic immune system attacking healthy cells is the basis of autoimmune disease. Khamisi cites estimates that five to ten per cent of people in Western countries develop some sort of autoimmune disorder, ranging “from celiac disease to type 1 diabetes to lupus.” Indeed, this happened during my bout with pneumonia. Antibodies that my body developed to fight the mycoplasma bacteria also destroyed my red blood cells, rendering me briefly anemic.

Still, Khamisi's emphasis on the beneficial aspects of somatic mutations is one of the most striking elements of her book. In one chapter, she describes mutations in which individuals with inherited disorders spontaneously produce cells that mitigate their maladies, a phenomenon that Khamisi likens to an autocorrect function. Research into Duchenne muscular dystrophy has recently furnished an example of this occurrence. Duchenne is an inherited degenerative muscular disease in which a gene mutates in such a way that a protein called dystrophin, vital to stabilizing muscles, becomes defective. As

a result, muscles degrade over time from the wear and tear of contracting. Early in life, afflicted children have difficulty walking and often fall; by adolescence, many are in wheelchairs, and patients often die in early adulthood from complications that affect the muscles of the heart and those that control breathing.

And yet researchers examining muscle tissue from children with Duchenne have detected healthy cells capable of making normal dystrophin, evidence of a somatic mutation autocorrecting the inherited one. In some cases, self-corrected cells have appeared early enough in a child's development to make a meaningful clinical difference. For example, a young man with Duchenne had three uncles with the condition, who all died in early adulthood. Although the young man also experienced the expected progressive weakness associated with this disorder, it mostly affected his left side. An analysis of his DNA showed that about a quarter of the cells on his right side had a mutation that overcame the deleterious Duchenne one.

Autocorrection has also been observed in other inherited genetic disorders, including one called tyrosinemia, in which a mutated enzyme makes it difficult for the body to process certain food proteins. Toxins build up and start to destroy the kidneys and liver. Infants with this condition who fail to receive treatment often die from organ failure. But the livers of some patients have been found to contain clusters of cells that produce an enzyme capable of breaking down the toxins. Their livers have become genetic mosaics.

There have also been reports of instances in which inherited damaging mutations have self-corrected. One such case involved a man in Texas who had the gene associated with Lesch-Nyhan syndrome, a condition that causes severe intellectual disability and self-harm—chewing one's fingers and lips, head-bashing, eye-poking. But the man had a normal level of intelligence and lacked any compulsion to injure himself. Molecular analysis showed that mutated cells in his body had turned the inherited destructive gene back to normal.

Then, there are boys with a rare immunologic disorder who have been termed “bubble babies,” because they are unable to produce sufficient antibodies or mobilize immune cells, meaning that they have to live inside

sterile protective “bubbles” to shield them from microbes. These children die early in life unless their impaired immune system is re-created with bone-marrow transplants. But scientists know of two boys who got better without transplants as they grew older. It was found that, by the time one of the boys was sixteen, half of his immune cells were normal; by the age of twenty, he was free of any medical problems.

Khamsi posits that there is some form of Darwinian competition at play among the cells in patients with autocorrection. The cells that reverted to normal in the boys with bubble-baby syndrome seemed to be replacing the defective cells, suggesting, she writes, “that self-healed cells in patients with genetic disorders might have an existential advantage.” The idea is supported by another case she cites, involving a woman in her late twenties with an inherited skin condition called epidermolysis bullosa, which causes severe blistering that can lead to fatal infections as microbes invade the peeled skin. The woman had a brother who died young from complications of the disease, yet she seemed to be healing. Her hands, though inflamed and covered in red sores, also had several large areas that were smooth and lacked any signs of irritation. The afflicted skin would blister when scientists gently rubbed it, but the healthy patches were completely resistant to such abrasion. Even at an early age, apparently, the patient had a few small, smooth, normal patches of skin; some had stayed the same size, but others had grown and spread. Researchers studied her cells by cultivating them in a laboratory and saw indications of a selective advantage, with healthy skin cells favored over diseased ones.

How did this apparent self-repair come about? One theory is that ultraviolet radiation from the sun may have been the key. Exposure to the sun can induce DNA mutations, which may cause skin cancer—the reason we apply sunblock at the beach. But in this patient the sun might have triggered somatic mutations that rescued her cells. Patients of this kind, Khamsi writes, have effectively undergone “natural gene therapy.”

Powerful technologies now exist that can detect mutated cells in healthy people who show no signs of illness. Although detection reinforces the reality that we are mosaics, the availability of such information raises thorny issues. Finding a mutation could, for example, indicate the potential for cancer, but that wouldn’t necessarily mean that a tumor would emerge, given

that the immune system can detect mutated cells and destroy them. Should one begin treatment to prevent the development of a tumor that may never form? And, in instances where the technology may find mutations for which there's no clear treatment to offer, there is considerable debate about whether testing should even occur. Is it better not to know you are a mosaic?

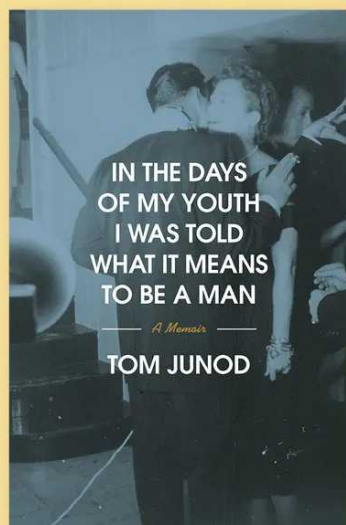
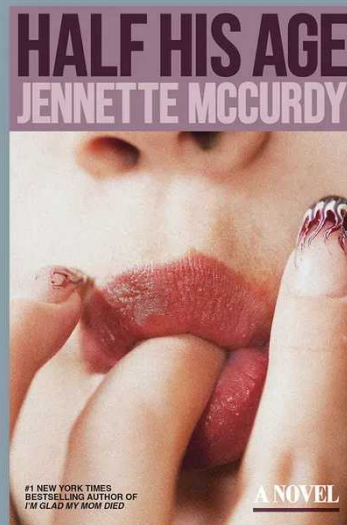
It is now almost a quarter of a century since the sequencing of the human genome was completed. As momentous as that breakthrough was, Khamisi suggests that it has left many of us with a simplistic and deterministic view of genetics, one in which our destinies are defined by what we inherit from our biological parents. “We need a radical shift in how we conceptualize DNA and the nature of genetic disease,” she writes, one that reflects the fundamentally dynamic and adaptive nature of the system. And mutations are too often assumed to be dangerous, even though some of them are vital to our survival. Furthermore, although somatic mutations are not heritable—unless they occur in reproductive cells—mutation is a factor that links the small changes within our bodies to the larger story of the evolution of species. In each case, mutation provides a way for life to stumble upon solutions. ♦

Books

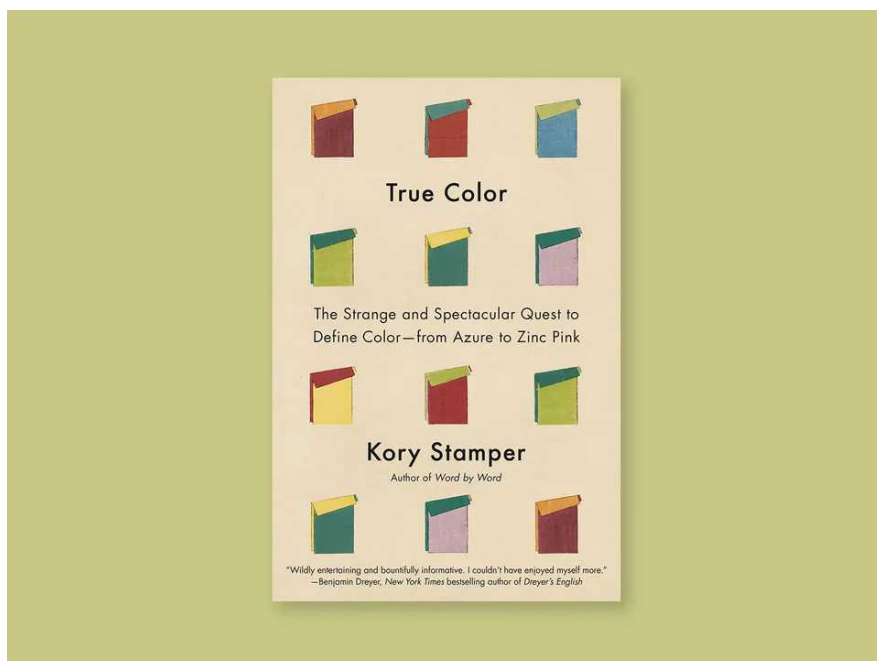
Briefly Noted

“In the Days of My Youth I Was Told What It Means to Be a Man,” “True Color,” “Half His Age,” and “Under Water.”

April 06, 2026

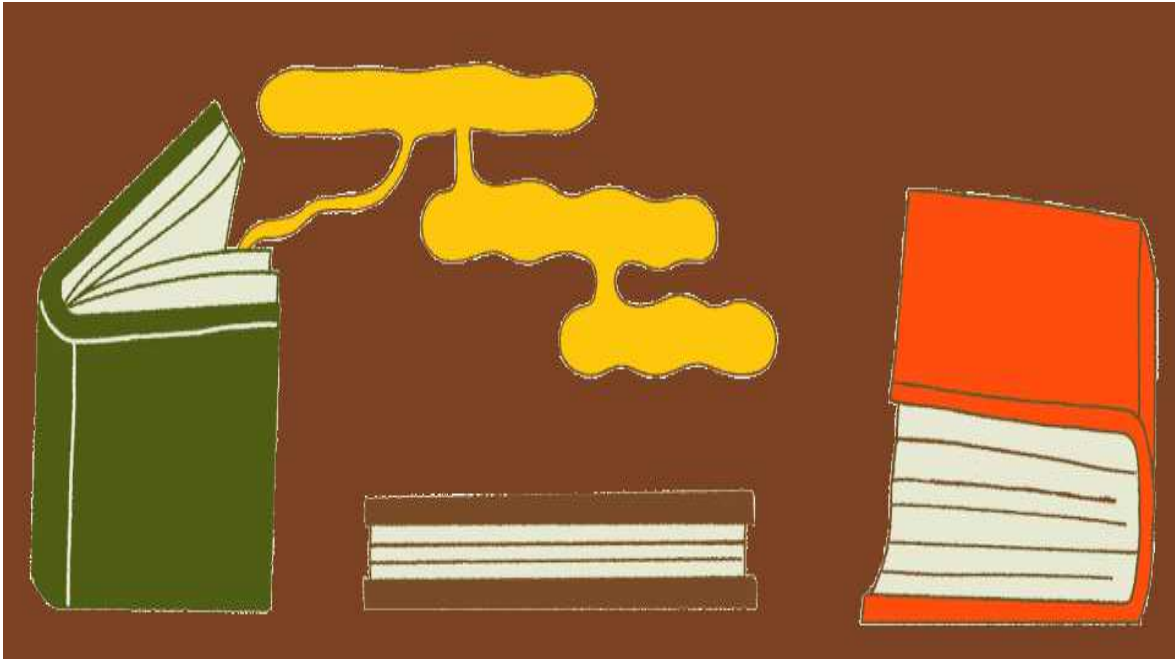


In the Days of My Youth I Was Told What It Means to Be a Man, by *Tom Junod (Doubleday)*. In this bracing blend of memoir and detective story, Junod unearths secrets about his father. Lou Junod was a charismatic war veteran with a Purple Heart, a travelling handbag salesman, and a husband who was married to the same woman for fifty-nine years. He was also a failed singer and an inveterate philanderer. Only at Lou's funeral, after a woman with whom Lou had an affair shows up, does Tom realize that his father's life contained unknown mysteries. As he investigates that past, he discovers various shocks, but, ultimately, Lou's story is one of a man who inculcated in his son an old-fashioned definition of manhood that stemmed from deep insecurity.

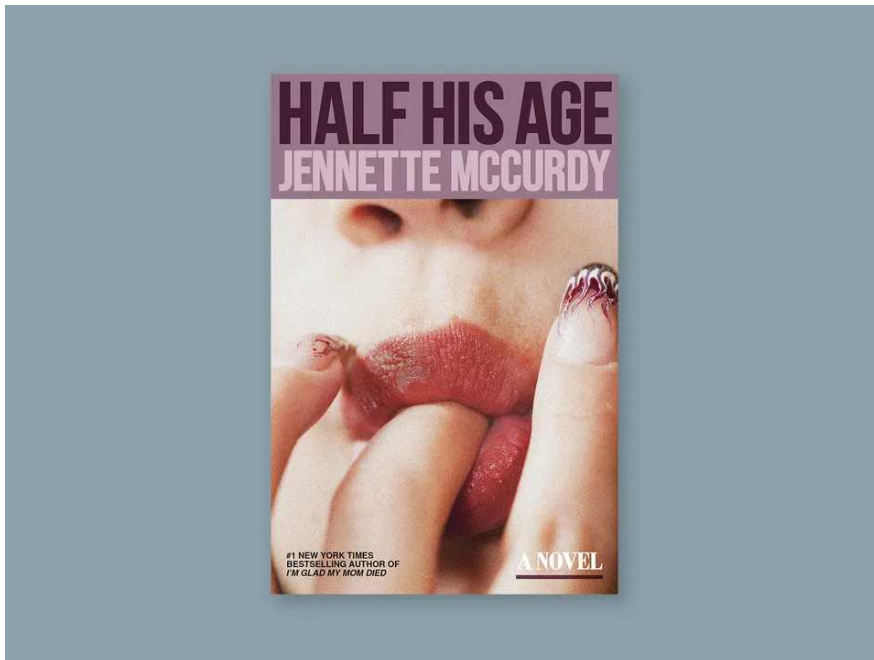


True Color, by *Kory Stamper (Knopf)*. Which colors merit entries in the dictionary? Why is “duckling” a color but “mallard” is not? Stamper, a lexicographer and former editor at Merriam-Webster, charts the history of how thousands of colors came to be defined in Webster's Third New International Dictionary, published in 1961. In her telling, the process of defining colors is intertwined with the arc of American modernization through industrialization, war, and scientific discovery. A dictionary may seem objective, but Stamper proves that it is deeply human as she highlights the personalities, disputes, drama, and enthusiasm for “brain-melting tedium on a microscopic scale” behind the work of creating one.

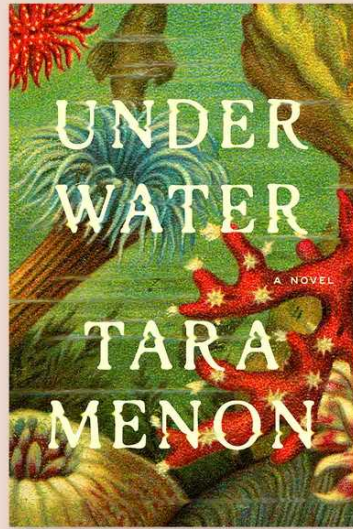
What We're Reading



Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



Half His Age, by *Jennette McCurdy (Ballantine)*. This consuming novel, written by a former child star who is also the author of a best-selling memoir, tackles an unsettling subject: intimacy between teen-agers and adults. Her narrator is a seventeen-year-old girl who begins a relationship with her forty-year-old writing teacher, Mr. Korgy. Though, at the outset, the girl seems to be the driver of the affair, as the story develops, it becomes apparent that she is motivated by wounds left by her absent father and by her mother, who has an “addiction” to love and sex. Eventually, her romance with the teacher is cast as just another way to cope with her pain. “Maybe it’s all the same,” she thinks. “Korgy and pants and YouTube and makeup and sweaters and junk food and sex. Maybe they’re all just distractions from me.”



Under Water, by *Tara Menon* (Riverhead). This melancholic début novel weaves between New York City in 2012 and a small island in the Andaman Sea in December, 2004. As a girl, the narrator lived on the island with her father, a marine biologist, and spent many of her days in the ocean with her best friend, Arielle, luxuriating in the semi-wilderness. As an adult, she works at a travel magazine, repackaging developing-world destinations with adjectives such as “pristine” and “rugged.” Her life is studded with losses—including that of her mother, and, later, of Arielle—and, as she wanders through New York, the past hovers with ghostly insistence. Above all, she mourns Arielle with a kind of longing that she feels society fails to recognize: “There is no place in our language for grief about friends, or love for them.”

Books

Will Biblical Womanhood Box You In or Set You Free?

Two writers of different evangelical generations offer rival visions of marriage, motherhood, and ambition.

By Emma Green

April 06, 2026



Cleveland, Tennessee, is deep in evangelical country. It's the home of the Church of God, a major Pentecostal denomination, and not too far from the town where prosecutors went after a schoolteacher on charges of teaching evolution during the Scopes "monkey trial" a hundred years ago. Still, even there, in the reddest part of red America, the girlboss has infiltrated.

Emma Waters was a senior at Lee University, a Christian school in Cleveland, when the girlboss struck. Waters was close to achieving her dreams. She had piled up academic honors, and she was planning a move to Washington, D.C. But there was an obstacle: her boyfriend, Jack, had started talking about marriage. "The idea of beginning life as a wife and mother felt

like a major letdown after years of working hard in college to prepare for a career in politics,” she writes in a new book, “[Lead Like Jael](#)” (Regnery). “Somehow, I had gotten this idea that prioritizing marriage and children earlier in life is what you do if you lack ambition.” There it was, creeping in: the girlboss world view, in which the best kind of life is one you define for yourself. She broke up with Jack.

Not to spoil the story, but: she regretted it. She turned to the Bible. She realized that her thinking on marriage and motherhood had been “self-centered,” focussed only on what she wanted and would have to sacrifice. He took her back, and they got married. Today, he’s in seminary, and, at twenty-eight, she’s got two daughters and another baby on the way—along with a job as a policy analyst at the Heritage Foundation, which she does in the early mornings and at night while her kids are asleep.

The premise of “Lead Like Jael” is that young women have been offered a shallow vision of the good life, one in which academic achievement and professional success are the only markers of worth. What’s perhaps more unusual for someone coming out of Waters’s conservative milieu is that she also warns women against adopting a competing life script: that of the tradwives, a highly online ecosystem of women who revel in domesticity, wearing prairie dresses while baking sourdough with babies on their hips. “It is a mistake to treat the *tradwife* as the antidote to the *girl boss*,” Waters writes. “The temptation to curate a life rather than live it is strong.”

Her proposal is something of a middle path: women should recognize that there are seasons of life with different demands, and see their roles as wives and mothers not as a retreat from work but as a chance to build a foundation. She tells young women to stop scrolling, to date seriously, to treat sex as sacred, and to resist elevating career over everything else. She argues that mothers should stay home with children under three, suggesting that these kids need to be around their moms full time to form secure attachments. She envisions husbands and wives as “battle-mates,” and encourages women to commit to hosting regular meals to build community.

Her model for all this, incredibly, is the Biblical heroine Jael, famous for luring the Canaanite commander Sisera to her tent, plying him with milk curds, and driving a tent peg through his temple. Jael was able to take such

decisive action, Waters argues, precisely because she owned the sphere of her home. Jael wasn't a "social justice warrior" who was trying to "break a tent-canvas ceiling"; instead, she was able to use her "distinctly feminine means" to take her place in history.

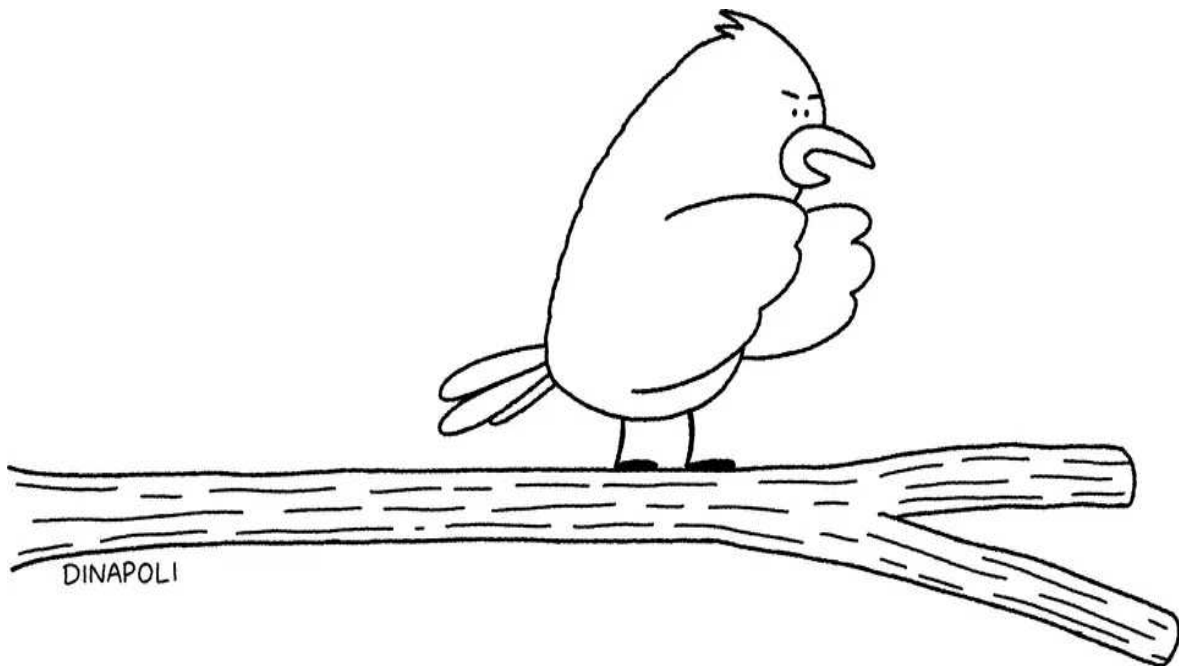
Waters's book is aimed at Christian women who are looking for guidance on how to navigate their seasons faithfully. But she's writing into a moment of wider exhaustion and uncertainty about the models of a good life on offer. Theology aside, the concept in her book that might be most foreign to someone outside of her world is that of *authority*: the notion that getting married and having kids is a matter not just of personal preference but of finding the conviction to live a life that is ordained by God. "Motherhood is a path of surrender and trust rather than a project of control," Waters writes. Fighting the obligations of motherhood leads to misery. Waters describes the unpleasant hustle of the working mom, who "juggled deadlines and daycare pickups," who "ate a rushed lunch at her desk while drafting presentations no one would remember," who Zoomed while folding laundry, who lay in bed at night scrolling "through pictures of the kids she barely saw that week." It's no wonder that the kind of life Waters is proposing—strong marriage, more time with children, tight-knit community—would take on a subversive allure.

Bible-based advice for women is an old and popular genre, and many books follow a format similar to Waters's: Old Testament heroines—Esther, Sarah, Deborah—offering lessons in wisdom and discernment to modern women, particularly in their roles as wives and mothers. The genre has produced huge celebrities in evangelical circles—Beth Moore, Priscilla Shirer—along with a few who have broken containment, like Jen Hatmaker.

Twenty years ago, Hatmaker was much like Waters: a young pastor's wife raising three little kids while writing her first books on Biblical wisdom for Christian women. She practiced the same schedule sorcery as Waters, writing from 8:15 *A.M.* to 12:15 *P.M.*, three days a week, plus occasionally during nap time. In "[Make Over](#)," from 2007, she seeks to help overwhelmed women find their balance: "If the Lord *created* a woman to be a servant of God, a wife, a mother, a professional, and a friend—not forgetting that she is still a daughter—then there is a way to be that woman." In "[Ms. Understood](#)," published a year later, she distances herself from

feminism—“this is no battle cry for independence, because men are our beloved allies”—and carefully circumscribes her mission. “On behalf of my generation, I believe we’re pursuing center,” she writes. “We recognize the oppression of being subservient male accessories as well as the danger of turning into contentious, genderless semi-females.” Same polemic, just with Bush-era archetypes.

Not long after these books appeared, however, Hatmaker’s career took an unexpected turn. She had begun straining against the boundaries of the Southern Baptist subculture she came up in, in which women teachers were relegated to small groups and sidebars. She and her husband left their church to co-found “one centered around the marginalized.” She started tossing around words like “patriarchy” and “white supremacy.” In 2016, she gave an interview in which she said she would gladly officiate a gay marriage. The backlash was swift: books pulled off shelves, speaking engagements cancelled. For four years, she slowly built back her brand—still the advice-giving Christian sister, just a little libbed out. But, in 2020, the final, irredeemable break came: she filed for divorce.



In a memoir from this fall, “[Awake](#)” (Avid Reader), Hatmaker writes of how she discovered that her husband, whom she had met and married while they were both students at the same Southern Baptist college, had been drinking,

lying, and cheating. “Out of a dead sleep, I hear five whispered words not meant for me: ‘I just can’t quit you.’ My husband of twenty-six years is voice-texting his girlfriend next to me in our bed.” Hatmaker, who is now fifty-one, had spent years coaching women on marriage: “Sweet Friend, if your marriage has suffered a catastrophic blow, I beg you, seek Christian counseling,” she wrote in her early thirties. “I know it would cost your pride, your controlled image, to seek help, but is that worse than a destroyed marriage? A family in crisis? A lifetime of loneliness?” And yet, when the catastrophic blow finally came for her, she knew to call it. Within thirty-six hours of her middle-of-the-night discovery, she was talking to a lawyer.

Whatever evolution Hatmaker went through in the heady years around Donald Trump’s first Presidency, it was nothing compared with the wreckage at home. She sees her failed marriage not just as a specific relationship gone bad but as a casualty of rigid Christian purity culture that taught her to keep herself small and to idolize early marriage as the ultimate achievement. “The community that raised me placed little premium on healthy young evolution,” she writes in “Awake.” Her husband entered ministry soon after graduation, a choice she seems to look back on with both regret and tenderness. “What if that boy splinters inside hierarchical leadership, and that girl is actually powerful?” she writes. “The patriarchy failed him too.” She is scathing about “biblical rules” that “felt terrible”; for example, that women should “spiritually and socially submit to men” and that queer people should be shamed. “Some combination of patriarchy plus religion, gender roles plus groupthink, power plus the threat of exclusion became the soil in which my marriage ultimately died,” she writes. She stopped going to church, convinced that “the fruit of these trees was rotten. Not one bad apple, not one questionable limb; rotten to the roots.” Her career has been huge—five *Times* best-sellers, an HGTV show, more than half a million Instagram followers—but she concluded it wasn’t possible to continue within the constraints of traditional Christian womanhood.

Many evangelicals of Hatmaker’s generation have travelled the same path of pointed questioning—not just about specific verses or churches but about their whole cultural milieu. The phenomenon is so common that defectors have repurposed the term “deconstruction” for it, as in “I’m deconstructing the deeply patriarchal views that evangelicalism taught me.” Of the five prominent Christian female writers whom Hatmaker counts as among her

closest online friends, two got divorced around the same time that she did, each from a pastor she had married young. The scripts Hatmaker seems most interested in these days don't come from the Bible. They come from within. In "Awake," she lightly auditions new paradigms for sisterly guidance: learn to self-mother; listen to your body; trust your intuition as the greatest source of truth. Your authority is yourself. Her early books are no longer on her website.

It would be tidy to situate Waters and Hatmaker as two points on an inevitable arc: when you're young, you reach for clear answers, but once you're older and you've been through some shit, you'll realize it was all lies. However much the young Hatmaker had in common with Waters, though, their lives seem likely to trace two very different arcs—ones instructive about both American Christianity and the wider debate over what a good life looks like for women.

For one thing, Hatmaker came of age during what was arguably the peak of evangelicalism in the United States. Some of the most iconic evangelical cultural artifacts, like the apocalyptic "[Left Behind](#)" series, came out of the nineties. Evangelicals got George W. Bush elected in 2000. The Southern Baptist Convention, the largest single Protestant denomination, reached its highest membership levels around the beginning of the twenty-first century. For Hatmaker, the act of deconstructing religious life and its wholesome images of marriage and motherhood was not primarily about doubting the Bible. It was about fighting back against a powerful cultural force.

By contrast, Waters is starting her career at a time when Christianity is no longer as dominant in America. After years of marked decline, the percentage of Americans who identify as Christian has levelled off. It would seem that the faith went through something of a sloughing-off period; people who once might have identified as nominal Christians are no longer bothering. Her call to put home life first and to let career follow can feel genuinely countercultural, because she is writing from within a counterculture.

Waters's work is also distinctly political in a way that the young Hatmaker's wasn't. In addition to Biblical heroines like Jael, she points to contemporary models of family wisdom, most often right-wing influencers: Tiffany

Justice, who co-founded the activist group [Moms for Liberty](#), or Charlie Kirk. Waters's experience of getting married and having kids, especially so young, is itself polarized. Counties with higher total fertility rates were more likely to go for Trump in 2024. Conservative women between the ages of twenty-five and thirty-five are much more likely to be married than their liberal counterparts, and thirty percentage points more likely to have children, according to the Institute for Family Studies; in the eighties, that gap was only five percentage points. Waters is part of an emerging cohort of Gen Z writers trying to reclaim female empowerment for young women who are both religious and conservative. Just as evangelical deconstruction became its own subculture, which Hatmaker helped define, these new, young, family-oriented religious conservatives seem to be forging a potent subculture of their own.

One notable matriarch mentioned in Waters's book is [Phyllis Schlafly](#). The conservative activist had six children before gaining prominence in the early nineteen-seventies as the chief opponent of the Equal Rights Amendment. Waters expresses admiration for Schlafly's life. "She didn't win by acting like a man. She didn't abandon her home, her femininity, or her faith. She led through them," Waters writes. "She understood how to use the tools God had given her." Schlafly also had a distinctive ability to drive feminists crazy. During one debate, the feminist activist Betty Friedan called Schlafly a witch, adding, "I'd like to burn you at the stake." The reason that Schlafly was so crazy-making is fairly straightforward: while Schlafly was railing against the dangers of feminism, feminists were busy passing laws letting women open credit cards, protecting girls' and women's sports, and preventing employers from firing women for getting pregnant. These achievements are so far in the rearview mirror of the feminist culture wars that they may be easy to forget, but Waters and her cohort no doubt benefit from them.

At the same time, feminists have never quite known what to do with women like Schlafly or Waters, or, for that matter, with Charlie Kirk's widow, Erika, other than calling them hypocrites for having big careers while singing the virtues of staying home. That kind of dismissal misses something important about the project that Waters is pursuing. She's writing about women who find freedom in the constraints of motherhood and marriage, and insisting that there's room for them to nurture both professional ambitions and a

traditional home life, if not necessarily at the same time. Hatmaker felt small in her conservative world, but Waters doesn't feel small in hers; instead, she feels relief from the relentless pressure to lean in. She doesn't experience motherhood and marriage as a millstone she must bear on the way to career success, or as a source of ambivalence about her identity. She appears to be at peace in the conviction that she was made for both.

Jael is a sly choice of hero for Waters, because she's so easy to cast as a girlboss. After all, it takes real determination to drive a tent peg through a man's skull. But nobody owns Jael, and women don't have to fit a feminist frame to be powerful. Waters is lucky enough to be a young woman in a world where she can freely choose her remix of a traditional life. The tent peg is in her hands now. ♦

Books

In Marie NDiaye's Spellbinding New Novel, Witchcraft Stays in the Family

In “The Witch,” a mother passes to her daughters a secret, burdensome power, but sorcery can’t fix a household that’s coming apart.

By Kristen Roupenian

April 06, 2026



Witchcraft was traditionally a form of occult knowledge: esoteric, hidden, available only to initiates. Now, though, with the widespread circulation of magic manuals, grimoires, and related compendia—with the recording, on paper, of words, spells, histories, stories—witchcraft has taken an irreversible step into the exoteric realm. The chain through which it once passed, from trusted person to trusted person, has been broken. Where the propagation of the mystery once required the presence and the consent of two people, the initiator and the initiate, we now have the reader, alone with the words on a page.

[“The Witch”](#) (Vintage), the new novel by Marie NDiaye, one of Europe’s most celebrated writers, is narrated by a woman, Lucie, who has decided to initiate her twelve-year-old twin daughters into what she calls “the mysterious powers.” These powers, as she describes them, appear both burdensome and nearly useless: contextless glimpses of the past and the future, minor divinatory visions accompanied by copious tears of blood. Although the girls view their heritage with disdain (“No offense, Mama, but it’s really all just so lame”), they acquiesce to long sessions of secret study in the basement, “away from their father’s eye.” The learning process involves no textbooks, no exercises, no memorization, no facts. Indeed, barely any words are exchanged. As Lucie puts it, “Their task was to observe me and, with all their being, with the whole of those little bodies born of mine, to internalize the arduous process of divination.” Eleven months later, the transfer of knowledge is complete, and the girls emerge from the basement, equipped with their new powers, just as their family falls apart.

One of NDiaye’s great strengths is her ability to establish an initial set of circumstances with such authority that the reader is almost powerless to question them. The terms of the story are fixed from the outset, and everything that follows must unfold within the ironclad limits they impose. In [“My Heart Hemmed In”](#) (2017), for instance, an entire community is gripped by a virulent hatred of two married teachers, Nadia and Ange. In [“Vengeance Is Mine”](#) (2023), the husband of the suspect in a high-profile murder enters a female lawyer’s office and asks her to take the case; she is certain they have met before, though he appears to have no memory of it. NDiaye’s commitment to these situations is unwavering. She wrings suspense from her characters’ efforts to navigate the bizarre circumstances in which she has placed them, while making no concession to the rules of our world in explaining how those situations arose. Opening an NDiaye novel is a little like coming to in the middle of a party after a blackout: the setting may be unfamiliar, but the action is under way, and all you can do is join in.

So, while the dutiful reader is still turning over basic questions about the nature of witchcraft, the girls are already hurtling up the stairs and out of the basement, and Lucie is crossing paths with Isabelle, a hostile neighbor. Isabelle’s sway over the other women in the neighborhood and her shocking

cruelty to her young son, Steve, aren't really explained; they're simply facts to be accepted. A lesser writer might have spent a hundred pages laboriously establishing these conditions and gingerly coaxing us to believe them. NDiaye takes twenty. As the novel unfolds, Lucie's powers, such as they are, prove useless against the unravelling of her life. Her husband leaves, her daughters slip beyond her reach, and she grows preoccupied with a forlorn, childlike fantasy of repairing her parents' long-broken marriage.

If the story sounds bleak, it isn't. For all the praise NDiaye has received, I've seen little mention, at least in English, of how *funny* she is. There are many pages in my copy of "The Witch" on which I've scrawled a cackling "HAHAHAHAHAHAHA." The critic Nathan Scott McNamara, [writing in the Los Angeles Review of Books](#), has aptly compared NDiaye's writing to that of [Shirley Jackson](#), and NDiaye herself cites [Joyce Carol Oates](#) as a strong influence. Her work plainly belongs to this lineage of witchy writers, women whose deliciously corrupted scenes of home and hearth produce fear and wild laughter at once. Take NDiaye's treatment of Steve. In a move reminiscent of "My Heart Hemmed In," all the women in "The Witch" have developed an intense aversion to poor Steve: his mother calls him a "little clot," a "little slob," a "little pest," a "little crumb"; the girls say he's "pathetic . . . just one big fail"; and Lucie chides them for their cruelty while herself referring to him as "snot-nosed little Steve." (Jordan Stump's English translation catches the bruising force of NDiaye's French with verve.) The fact that all these bizarre attacks are directed at an innocent little boy who at one point wears a shirt that says "*I LOVE MY MOM*" is both so absurd and so awful that the reader has little choice but to laugh. The characters, though, never find the situation funny.

Lucie eventually gets a glimpse of Steve's future, and it is as bitter and pathetic as one might expect for a child who has been so mistreated. But, though the reader might prefer to stop and mourn his fate, NDiaye demands that we barrel on. Toward the end of the novel, we reëncounter Isabelle, and she says to Lucie, "Do I talk to you about that little crumb Steve? You know, I have to work just to remember his name. I've forgotten his face, poof, gone! Everything flies away, everything is forgotten!" True to her word, Isabelle never mentions Steve again.

In [an interview](#) with this magazine, accompanying the publication of her short story “The Good Denis,” NDiaye said, “I always make a point of not knowing more than the reader does. I’m not the kind of writer who knows the secret to understanding a story and chooses not to reveal it.” The result is work that asks questions without presenting them as puzzles to be solved. There is no hint of condescension in her writing, which is part of its difficulty and its power. She seems to envision the relationship between reader and writer as an encounter of equals—not demanding that the reader labor toward an answer that the writer already possesses, the way a classroom teacher might, but inviting us to join her on a harrowing journey as she searches for the answers she herself desperately needs. You sense that it’s because the stakes are so high that she can’t afford to pause, to laugh, to grieve, or to explain.

So what is the mystery at the heart of “The Witch”? What burning question prompted such a headlong pursuit? I finished the novel feeling sure I’d glimpsed it. Clearly, it had something to do with a terrible loss looming over all of us. The point is that certain kinds of knowledge have long been passed down tacitly from generation to generation, but our culture, with its wild overreliance on the explicit and the useful, will soon produce people on whom such knowledge will be lost. Then I came back to the book a few days later and thought, No, it’s about family secrets, and the way they distort and shape us from within—how we always know the most important things without being able to say how or why. Or maybe it’s about the way the powers women are born with get stolen and sold back as “empowerment.” Or maybe it’s asking something about the intersection of love and loss and rage. In the end, I have a strong sense that I know what the book means, but I can’t fully express it. That may be a tribute to NDiaye’s success in conjuring a world in which knowledge is acquired not through explanation but through a kind of silent apprenticeship. And, though there are no bloody tears rolling down my cheeks, let me close with an act of divination: Marie NDiaye will win the Nobel Prize. ♦

The New Museum Returns, but Humans Are Left Behind

After an eighty-two-million-dollar renovation, the museum has put on a sprawling show about the war between humanity and technology. We seem to be losing.

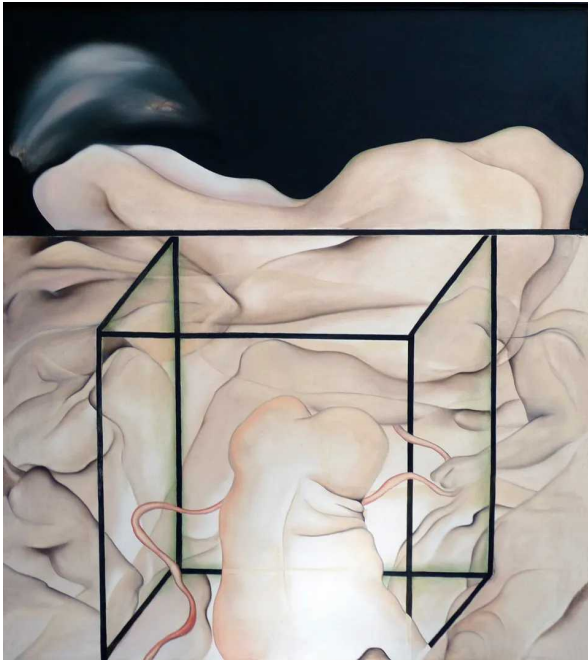
By Zachary Fine

March 31, 2026



The New Museum knows that most viewers will be of two minds about “New Humans: Memories of the Future,” a blockbuster exhibition meant to crown the museum’s reopening after a sixty-thousand-square-foot expansion. With more than seven hundred objects, spread across three floors, the show is designed to both stimulate and fatigue you. The official remit is “what it means to be human in the face of sweeping technological changes.” In practice, this means a madhouse of multimedia rooms, packed with gurgling videos and useless machines and humanoid bodies. There are bodies made from scrap metal, bodies pierced with tentacles and affixed with screens for nipples and eyes, bodies broken down for parts, and walls

lined with images of skin. In some rooms, paintings are hung salon style. In others, objects are suspended from the ceiling, mounted above doorways, or made to float via balloon. As if to poke fun at the show's size and ambition, the curators have installed in the lobby a visual joke by the artist Ryan Gander: a tiny animatronic mouse.



Still, if we're looking for "what it means to be human" today, the exhibition isn't a bad place to start. It operates as a kind of encyclopedic junk pile, with hundreds of discarded visions of how technology might save—or estrange—us from ourselves. The first piece inside the galleries, a 1967 painting by the German artist Maina-Miriam Munsky, depicts a schematic outline of a cube struggling to contain a mass of dreamy flesh. It reads as a diagram of human folly: for centuries, we've tried to rationalize and control ourselves, only to be undermined by our excess and unreason. The show continually wobbles between these two poles. In the same room as the Munsky, in a section titled "Reproductive Futures," a pack of Dadaists and Surrealists represents unreason, while the marvels of the rational are seen in a 1927 video of stickleback fish eggs by Jean Painlevé, a French photographer and filmmaker who trained in biology. In between are a bunch of mongrel appliances that leave both humans and technology worse for wear, like a computer, in a 2024 photo by Sara Deraedt, that seems to be giving birth to a wet child. The entire logic of the exhibition—with science and art, fresh

names and familiar ones, lumped together—is here in miniature. Your job is to pick and choose your way through the heap.



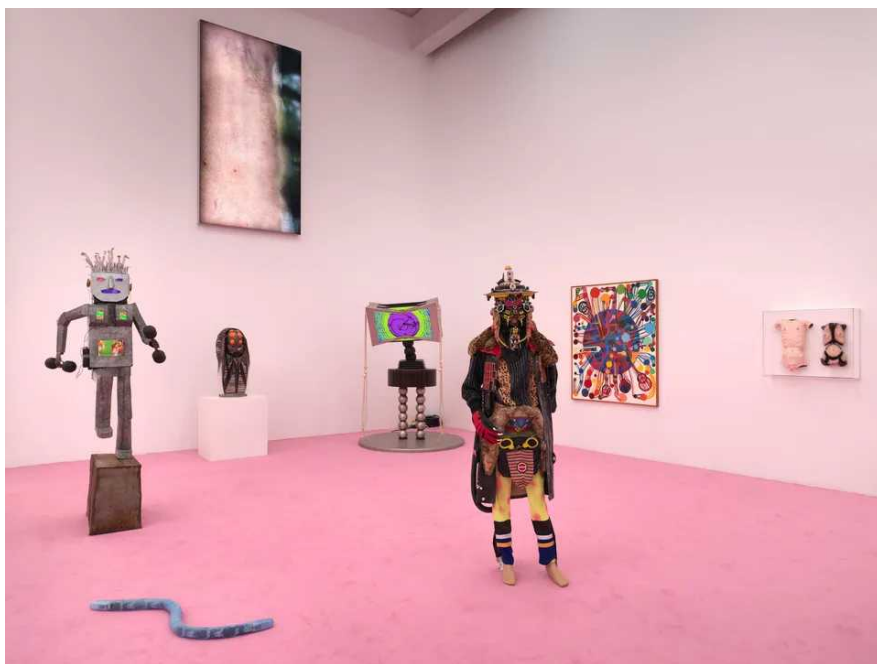
The time line of the show starts roughly with the First World War, when new ideas about the human flourished around the killing fields of the Somme and Verdun. A series of lithographs from the nineteen-twenties, by the Soviet artist El Lissitzky, presents the cast of an opera as geometric puppets made of steely widgets, with Bolshevik-red organs—the body a cog readied for mass mobilization. A capitalist alternative is found in the work of Frank and Lillian Gilbreth, an engineering couple who fastened little lights to workers' hands and tracked their movements with long-exposure photographs, hoping to reduce motion and increase profit. Often, modernists didn't have a coherent vision of the body so much as a criticism of it. John Heartfield and George Grosz's "The Middle-Class Philistine Heartfield Gone Wild" (1920) is a child-size mannequin spliced with odd prosthetics: a revolver for an arm, a set of teeth for genitals, a light bulb for a head, a fork for . . . well, I'm not exactly sure. The piece is half statue, half practical joke. The human becomes a palimpsest of all sorts of contemporary events and psychological possibilities: the soldier blown apart by mortar shells, the worker alienated from his own limbs, the man fearful of a woman's dentition, the brain replaced by an electrical device. It can be bittersweet, the way a body is rarely just a body.

I almost missed “The Middle-Class Philistine” because of a Technicolor demon wriggling in the air nearby. “The Fireside Angel (Fourth Version)” (2019), by Cyprien Gaillard, is a hologram adapted from a 1937 Max Ernst painting, recalling Marshall McLuhan’s point that the content of a medium is always another medium. Less well known is McLuhan’s theory that art operates as a radar system for detecting disasters before they happen. I expected to see some warning signs in “New Humans,” but had trouble finding them. Hito Steyerl’s “Mechanical Kurds” (2025) shows footage of Kurdish refugees in Iraq who make poverty wages tagging and classifying drone images for Amazon (distinguishing whether something is a weapon, say, or a carton of milk); Sidsel Meineche Hansen has a video of a sex doll unboxing itself. The exhibition doesn’t offer glimpses of the future so much as glimpses of a world you already inhabit but would rather not.

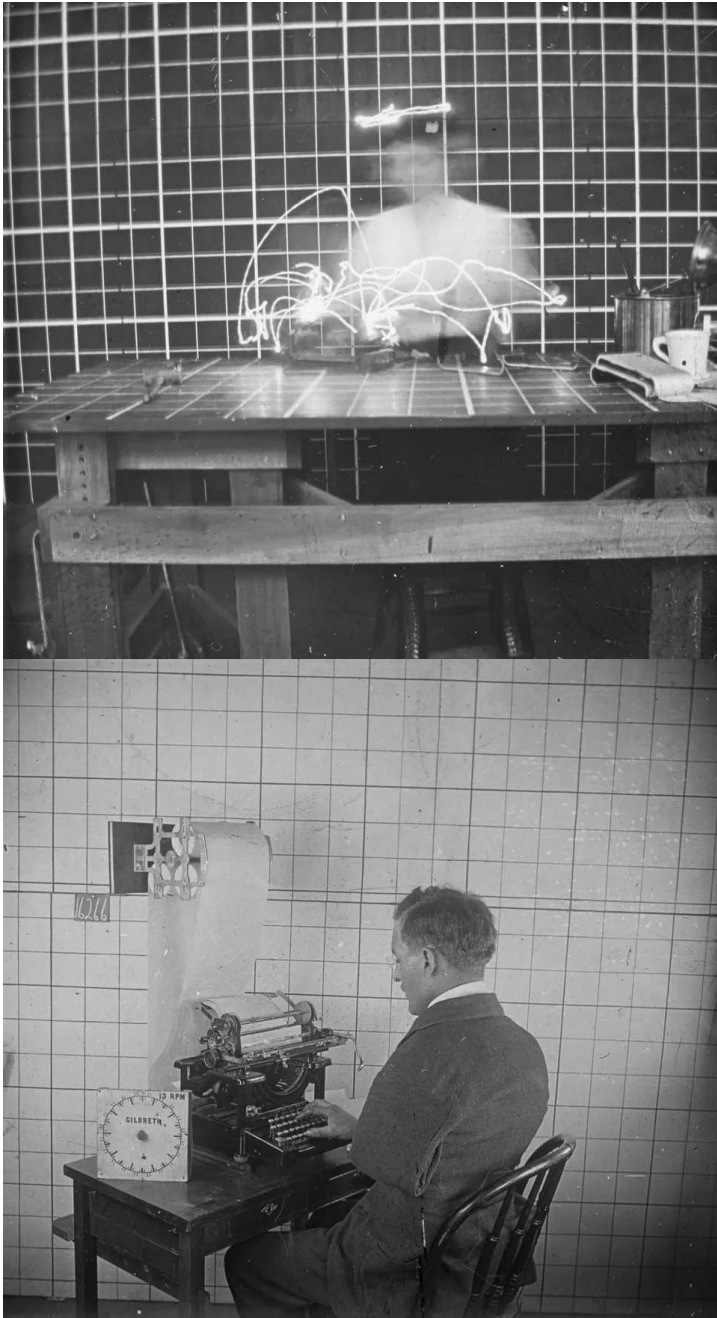


The centerpiece of the expansion, which was led by the architects Shohei Shigematsu and Rem Koolhaas, in collaboration with the firm Cooper Robertson, is an atrium that snaps right onto the side of the flagship building. I can’t say it was worth the renovation’s eighty-two-million-dollar price tag, but the space is brilliantly subtle. It works like a snorkel for the museum, giving it a new column of air for the vertical flow of traffic to the galleries, which have basically doubled in size. Climbing the atrium’s stairs, you can look out the glass façade, onto the Bowery, or squint at the mesh

panels that flank you, shimmering with green light and exposing the building's internal supports. Architecture like this, which reveals its structure while producing its effects, can make a museum feel slightly more humane.

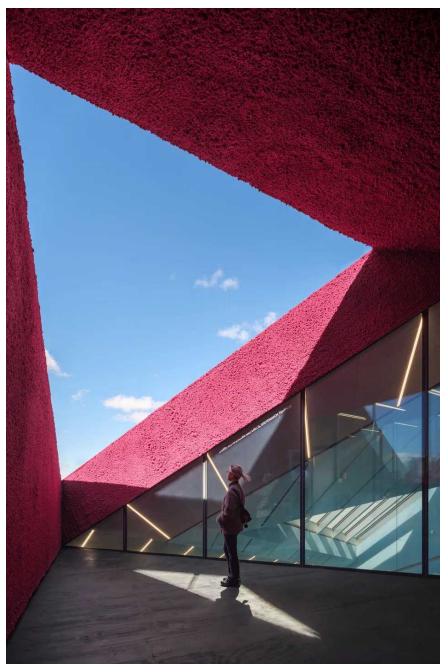


Unfortunately, when you reach the third floor, the show starts to flail. To poke holes in the universalist pretensions of Cold War-era “human rights,” with its use of the white Western male as a stand-in for the species, the curators try to tackle post-colonialism, Pan-Africanism, plants, animals, and extraterrestrials in one swoop. This results in some head-scratching decisions, like putting a closed copy of Alain Locke’s “The New Negro” (1927) in a vitrine, along with issues of *Fire!!* and W. E. B. Du Bois’s *The Crisis*, which sit there like mute tokens of Black intellectual ferment. Nearby are paintings of animal-human hybrids by the Danish artist Ovarthaci and a 2022 video environment by Christopher Kulendran Thomas, which includes what appears to be footage of Tamil independence fighters and a deepfake of Kim Kardashian. If the framework of an exhibition is so baggy that it can accommodate any piece of art, with nothing resembling a principle of selection, it risks deteriorating into spectacle. Part of me wonders whether that’s the point.



Toward the end of the show, you'll enter the "Hall of Robots," which is sort of like a Universal Studios Hollywood tour, if it took place in a large intestine. More than a dozen robots and creatures are scattered on a pink carpet. Behold a model of the wrinkly protagonist from Steven Spielberg's "E.T.," or H. R. Giger's alien from "Alien 3," or a robot jogging in place with dumbbells. The most disturbing figure is a blond mannequin who seems to be hanging herself with a mirror instead of a noose. She has one bionic arm, wears silver Nikes and a sweatband, and is plugged into an

electrical outlet, causing her right hand to periodically twitch. Somehow, “Glass Man” (1935), on loan from the German Hygiene Museum, in Dresden, with all of his internal organs visible, ends up being the most wholesome thing in the room.



The Czech philosopher Vilém Flusser once argued that “the lens”—from the telescope to the camera—was partly to blame for the decline of humanism. It allowed us to make large things that were far away seem close, and small things that were close seem large. It warped our sense of place in the universe. I can imagine a version of “New Humans” that would have tried to repair things, rather than cataloguing the various ways we’ve become shrinking adjuncts to our machines. But maybe the future no longer belongs to art. What is the subhead of the show—“Memories of the Future”—if not an elegy? ♦

Kanye West Makes a Record for the A.I. Era

Fans want to know whether the vocals on his new album, “Bully,” are truly his. But the question of what the “real” Ye sounds like has never been simple.

By Kelefa Sanneh

March 30, 2026



More than a year ago, in February, 2025, Kanye West, who is now known as Ye, gave an interview in which he said that the title of his next album was inspired by one of his children. “My son was playing with some kid, and then he kicked him,” Ye told the interviewer, [Justin Laboy](#). “I asked my son, like, ‘Why you do that?’ He said, ‘ ’Cause he weak.’ And I was, like, ‘This man is really a bully.’ ” Ye said that the new record would be called “Bully,” and told fans to expect it in June.

Of course, Ye’s fans have been taught not to get too attached to their expectations, though many of them have a tendency to forget the lesson. Ye

is probably the most contentious figure in all of popular music: a hip-hop revolutionary who has changed the genre's sound several times over, while reinventing himself more times than that. About a month after the Laboy interview was posted, Ye seemed to announce another shift, writing on X, "My new sound called antisemitic." Not long afterward, he released an ugly and transfixing track called "[Heil Hitler](#)," which overshadowed the promised "Bully" album—and which, to some listeners, might overshadow everything else in Ye's discography. But he kept tinkering with "Bully," teasing and releasing different versions of the record's songs. Then, in the early morning hours of March 28th, an eighteen-track collection named "Bully" finally appeared on Spotify and Apple Music, marking the official release, at long last, of Ye's twelfth solo studio album.

Despite its title, "Bully" is in some ways a conciliatory offering. For years, Ye had been obsessed with notions of Jewish villainy, while also identifying himself with Adolf Hitler and Nazis. In 2022, he told Alex Jones, on Infowars, "I like Hitler," adding, "The Holocaust is not what happened. Let's look at the facts of that, and Hitler has a lot of redeeming qualities." But this past January he published a full-page advertisement in the *Wall Street Journal* in which he apologized for just about everything, writing that a 2002 car accident (which was the inspiration for his breakthrough single, "Through the Wire") had injured his brain in ways that contributed to his bipolar disorder, which in turn had led to "poor judgment and reckless behavior." He said that he was recovering, "through an effective regime of medication, therapy, exercise and clean living." And he asked for forgiveness. "I am not a Nazi or an antisemite," he wrote. "I love Jewish people." You can hear both contrition and defiance in "King," the first track on "Bully," which has a fuzzy, buzzing bass line and lyrics that suggest that, sometimes, pride goeth not just before destruction but after it, too:

This that feeling we need more of
The hating just brought me more love
Guarantee my vices different than yours was
Drunk off power and I was pouring up

Often, over the past quarter century, the thrill of listening to Ye has been the thrill of listening to someone trying to figure himself out. On his 2004 debut album, "The College Dropout," he sounded like an excited young man

whose considerable (and justifiable) confidence only barely outstripped his insecurity, crowing, “Hold up, hold fast, we make more cash / *Now* tell my mama I belong in that slow class.” By the time he released “My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy,” in 2010, he had entered his imperial phase, and his rhymes reflected the luxurious but sometimes lonely life of a hip-hop star who had mastered his art, and was now trying to master himself: “I just needed time alone with my own thoughts / Got treasures in my mind, but couldn’t open up my own vault.” In the past decade, his more scattershot discography has similarly seemed to reflect his troubled state of mind. His last official album, “Donda 2,” from early 2022, began with a track that appeared to refer to the children he shares with his ex-wife, Kim Kardashian: “When I pick ’em up, I feel like they borrowed / When I gotta return them, scan ’em like a bar code.” It is just about impossible to follow Ye’s music without following his life, too, and without thinking about the permeable membrane that separates them.

So who is Ye now? Listening to “Bully,” it can be hard to tell. Some of the tracks seem designed to remind listeners of his older, less incendiary incarnations. “Punch Drunk,” which lasts less than two minutes, is built on a sped-up sample of the Clark Sisters, and it sounds like a throwback to Ye’s early years, when he made his living by turning old records into new beats that he could sell to fellow-rappers. And “All the Love” evokes the grandeur of the “Twisted Fantasy” era, thanks in part to the contributions of André Troutman, who plays the talk box, a robotic voice-morphing instrument that was also used to great effect by his cousin Roger, from the early-eighties funk band Zapp. The talk box was a precursor to Auto-Tune, which Ye used to create the moaning, melancholy sound of his 2008 landmark, “808s & Heartbreak”; rappers have been leaning heavily on software-enhanced singing ever since. But the new version of Ye that emerges on “Bully” is much less funny than the old version, in addition to being less bilious than the recent version. “I brought a white queen to the altar / Couldn’t happen without Martin Luther,” he declares in one couplet that contains neither a rhyme nor, really, a punch line. Many of the tracks resemble fragments or sketches, with bits of singing and rapping that sound unusually tentative, as if Ye isn’t quite sure how, or how much, to give his listeners what they want.

Over the years, Ye has amassed perhaps the most obsessive fan base in all of hip-hop, and some of them have carefully charted the evolution of the tracks

on “Bully.” During that Laboy interview, Ye enthused about a new technology that was allowing him to make music in a different way: artificial intelligence. Ye has often used writers to help compose his music; now, using A.I., he showed Laboy how he could take a recording of someone else rapping and render it in his own voice. A year ago, Ye released a half-hour-long video accompanied by several “Bully” tracks, and many fans thought that they heard evidence of his newfound interest in A.I. Was he really delivering lyrics in Spanish, on a track called “Last Breath,” or had he merely reprogrammed a Spanish-language singer to sound like him? In a post on X last week, he seemed to announce that the new version of “Bully” would contain none of this sort of manipulation. “BULLY ON THE WAY NO AI,” he promised.

Did he deliver? Listeners have been trying to figure that out. A streamer known as ImStillDontai filmed an hour-long reaction to the album that earned about a quarter of a million views in its first twenty-four hours. He enthused about the record’s downcast finale, “This One Here,” but also voiced his doubts. “I hate A.I.,” he said. “I shouldn’t have to be thinking about this, bro. I should be able to just listen to him and be, like, ‘Oh, my God, he’s *killing* this.’ But now I’m, like, ‘Is he? Or is the fucking *machine* killing it?’ ” There seems to be a widespread perception that musicians who use artificial intelligence are engaged in a form of cheating. It is a familiar concern, because it evokes earlier arguments against sampling, and also against Auto-Tune, both of which were commonly described as a way for lazy musicians to make low-effort music. “People are, like, ‘Stay away from A.I.’—it’s a more negative reaction than Auto-Tune,” Ye told Laboy. It should be said, though, that the Auto-Tune backlash was once plenty negative; in 2009, Jay-Z released a track called “D.O.A. (Death of Auto-Tune),” which suggested, memorably though not accurately, that the era of processed vocals was just about over.

The arguments over Ye’s use of artificial intelligence seem to have something to do with a desire for connection: fans want to be sure that the voice they hear is really his, even as new technology makes it harder to reliably distinguish between pure and impure recordings. This is a particularly vexed question in the case of Ye, who so often changes his mind and his persona, and whose discography is full of leaks and revisions and contradictions that leave listeners scrambling to figure out which releases are

the “real” ones—and, for that matter, which Ye is the real one. Is the March 28th version of “Bully” the final one? Did Ye really write, or at least authorize, that contrite statement in the *Wall Street Journal*? Can we even be sure that that was him on Alex Jones’s show, with his entire head concealed underneath a black hood? The English musician James Blake was credited as a producer on “This One Here,” but, after the album arrived on streaming services, Blake announced that he had asked to be removed from the credits, saying that the final version didn’t reflect the “spirit” of the track he had worked on. In fact, many listeners may find that the rather spare and wobbly version of the song that appeared last year is more affecting than the plusher version on the new album, just as they may find themselves missing Ye’s slightly uncanny Spanish-language delivery on the second verse of “Last Breath.” Throughout his career, Ye has often communicated in a jittery voice that sounds overwhelmed with emotion, but on “Bully” he is uncharacteristically subdued, and it is hard not to think about a different transformative technology: the program of “medication” that he mentioned in the *Journal*. “Bully” is perhaps the first major album of the artificial-intelligence era—the first, that is, to be evaluated primarily in terms of how much it does or doesn’t use A.I. Not coincidentally, it’s an album that forces fans to think anew about what, precisely, might make music sound “artificial.” It is not, by any stretch, a great album. But it might nevertheless be a landmark. ♦

Broadway's "Dog Day Afternoon" Is a Dog

Sidney Lumet's kinetic, emotionally complex film has been transformed into a hokey sitcom with gunshots.

By Emily Nussbaum

April 02, 2026



Shortly before I took my seat for "Dog Day Afternoon," at the August Wilson Theatre, I read a dishy writeup in the *Times* about some backstage drama: the playwright, Stephen Adly Guirgis, had been banned from rehearsals. That news didn't worry me much—after all, the 1975 Sidney Lumet movie required reshoots after its star, Al Pacino, watched the first-day rushes and begged for a do-over so that he could get rid of an ill-conceived mustache. In the end, Pacino's anxiety just intensified his legendary performance as Sonny, a jittery bank robber desperate to fund his trans lover's "sex reassignment" surgery, lending the role a magnetic warmth and pathos.

The stage version of “Dog Day Afternoon,” which has been in development for a decade, is clearly a passion project for its lead actors, Jon Bernthal and Ebon Moss-Bachrach, close friends and Meisner-method devotees—as well as co-stars on FX’s “The Bear”—who have spoken in the press about “revering” Lumet’s movie and its stars. Guirgis, who has written bracing, perceptive plays celebrating New York eccentricity, including “Jesus Hopped the ‘A’ Train” and the Pulitzer-winning “Between Riverside and Crazy,” felt like a natural collaborator. So my fingers were crossed for a lively ride, even if there might be some bumps. Sadly, I’m obliged to report a tragic pileup on the Belt Parkway.

The play, like the movie, is loosely based on a robbery that took place in 1972, on a boiling-hot August day, when an eccentric, deep-in-debt Vietnam veteran named John Wojtowicz entered a Chase bank in Brooklyn with a gun and two accomplices, hoping for a quick score. The amateurish stickup failed, fast. The cops turned up, then the F.B.I.; during a daylong standoff, crowds flooded the streets, cheering the crooks and booing the cops. TV cameras soaked up the spectacle. It was one of the first modern media circuses, a tabloid tale about schlubs and showboats who, at the peak of New York municipal dysfunction, were embraced as populist heroes.

It’s terrific material, which Lumet spun into a kinetic, immersive visual experience, with streaks of observational humor. The Broadway team may have hoped to heighten the contradictions further, by focussing more tightly on New York oddballs under pressure. But, mystifyingly, Guirgis and the show’s director, Rupert Goold, have staged their story not as the rich, unsettling human drama that it was in real life, or even as a dark comedy with modern themes, but as a noisy sitcom punctuated by gunshots. I generally hate when theatre critics dismiss plays as sitcoms; I love sitcoms! But my alarm bells went off at the first line, in which a bank security guard announces, “2:59—guess you just ‘Beat the Clock’—you know, like the TV show?” What follows feels dumbed down and frantic, full of violent slapstick and musty sex jokes, with an ensemble of outer-borough dimwits used as gag dispensers. A stoned accomplice flees the joint, moaning that he’s getting diarrhea. The security guard, who passes out after a heart attack, suddenly stutters, “B—,” seemingly in pain, then turns out to be asking for doughnuts from Beeglemen’s, shouting, “Them Jews, they know from baked goods!” Seventies touchstones are speckled like capers in a veal piccata:

Beefsteak Charlie's. "Deep Throat." Crazy Eddie. A lot happens, but little feels earned; the tone is an uneasy blend of zany and sour.

The staging is equally frustrating. An impressive revolving stage, which displayed both the exterior of the bank and the bland lobby inside, toggled smoothly between scenes. Yet key dramatic moments—a shooting, the robbers' realization that the bank vault is empty—occurred in a hallway invisible to the audience, described secondhand. The music was sufficiently groovy, the costumes era-appropriate (miniskirts, Travolta-tight slacks), yet nothing conjured the tension of an oppressive August day—and nobody broke a sweat. Where is Jonathan Groff when you need him?

An even bigger problem, however, is that the movie's moral ambiguity has been replaced by Folgers Crystals. The hostages, who in the film version were hazily sketched but convincingly idiosyncratic, have been provided with backstories—shallow ones. There's a tramp, a ditz, a bad boss, a hippie, a by-the-book good girl. It's difficult to care about what happens to them as they bicker and backbite.

The same is true of Sonny and Sal, his high-strung henchman. So much of acting is alchemy: when John Cazale played Sal in Lumet's film, the character transformed from the streetwise pretty boy in Frank Pierson's Oscar-winning screenplay into something more original, a fragile, hangdog figure whose childlike instability provoked a wary protectiveness even in the hostages whom he threatened. Sal's best line—a plaintive, funny "Wyoming," when Sonny asks him what country he wants to flee to—was ad-libbed. Those notes of fragility lent weight to the question of whether Sal would live or die once the police closed in.

Moss-Bachrach's Sal is a far more familiar figure: a trigger-happy psychopath irritated that his partner isn't more hard-core. The choice feels strategic, a way of throwing our sympathy to Sonny, but it makes the men's dynamic more banal, a negotiation over tactics between a bad boy and a worse boy. Bernthal, usually so deft at playing sensitive bruisers, is doing cocky Pacino cosplay here, possibly because this version of Sonny is less of a tenderhearted fuckup and more of a working-class charmer, railing heroically against oligarchs and the N.Y.P.D. The cast's sole survivor is Jessica Hecht, who pours miraculous warmth and complexity into her faintly

insulting role as Colleen, the head teller, a morally upright spinster goosed by her flirtation with Sonny and the spotlight.

These hollow characterizations wind up tanking the production's one truly audacious swing, a coup de théâtre that occurs when Sonny exits the bank and struts center stage, then urges the audience to improvise with him, becoming the street mob whose wriggly, wild energy Lumet's film so vividly conjured. Bernthal shouts, "Attica!," and he tosses out (fake) dollar bills. Cops patrol the aisles; recorded cheers stream through the loudspeakers, sweetening the hubbub. As people around me gamely played along—someone yelled, "Attica!"—I felt like a hostage myself, eying the exits.

The show's greatest failure, however, is its treatment of Sonny's sexuality, which in real life was not easily summarized: Wojtowicz, who had an ex-wife and kids, was a sketchy hanger-on at the Gay Activists Alliance, which viewed him with suspicion. He "married" a trans woman—such marriages were illegal then—but she was soon struggling to escape his jealous rages. Coverage of the robbery became a perverse representational breakthrough, with reporters portraying the gay subjects as colorful, knotty individuals rather than as pathologized cartoons. Three years later, Lumet's film did something even riskier, humanizing an unusual romance by not sanding down its contradictions, including the fact that Sonny referred to his bride, Leon, as "he." Not everyone loved the results—the gay film historian Vito Russo called it "the ultimate freak show"—but for decades viewers have embraced the movie's refusal to judge or simplify. Chris Sarandon, who played Leon, once sneaked into a cinema showing and was relieved to hear the reaction: giggles, but then respectful silence during Sonny and Leon's wistful final phone call, the moment their connection feels undeniable.

On Broadway, Leon gets the bad laughs. The character, played by Esteban Andres Cruz, has been reduced to a simpering stereotype who makes a pass at a cop and mimics a blow job. She whimpers about undone nails; she glibly describes herself as a "fucking whore" who is "like McDonald's, over a million served." That tender phone call is marred by dum-dum gags—"I can't go to Algeria, what would I wear?"—and, once they hang up, even Sonny's uncontrolled sobbing is mined for laughs. It's a different type of

failure, and an embarrassing one in 2026. “The Jellicle Ball” can’t open soon enough. ♦

On Television

Savannah Guthrie's Excruciating Story, on "Today"

The morning-show host recounted the disappearance of her mother, Nancy, and its aftermath in boldly religious terms, as millions of viewers watched.

By Vinson Cunningham

April 01, 2026



From an excruciating story comes this even more impossible detail: the home from which Nancy Guthrie mysteriously vanished, as was reported on February 1st, was the very same place where she raised her three children, Annie, Camron, and, fatefully, Savannah, the "Today"-show anchor of long tenure, whose fame has made Nancy's kidnapping an international event. The Guthries settled north of Tucson, Arizona, when Savannah was two years old. Over a decade later, Charles, Nancy's husband and Savannah's father, died of a heart attack. Nancy was steadfast after the tragedy, modelling the sacrificial aspects of the Christian faith that she'd diligently passed along to her kids, showing them that life could continue—and,

indeed, with all its tenacious necessities, *had* to continue, there was no other option—in the aftermath of a tragedy.

She conveyed this education in her house, and she held on to the house even after her daughter became wealthy enough, presumably, to move her anywhere in the world. She must have loved the place in a protective, stubborn way. It had held some hurt and some joy, had sheltered lives in their flowering, fragile years. In the fullness of time, Nancy had a Nest camera installed—one of those all-seeing eyes meant to guard the property and calm anxious nerves and provide real safety from intrusion. Perhaps one, or all, of her kids, fretting over their independent-minded mother, had advised her to get it. On the last night that anybody else reportedly saw Nancy, that camera caught a glimpse of a person clad in dark clothes, wearing gloves and a black balaclava, unidentifiable, standing at the threshold. Then Nancy was gone. Her home had been a house of mourning, a symbol of resilience, a family cornerstone, and now—bright shock—the empty scene of an unseen crime.

“It’s the house where all of our memories are, good and bad,” Savannah Guthrie said, her eyes sparkling with barely dammed tears, during a conversation in late March with her friend and former co-worker Hoda Kotb. Guthrie had returned to the “Today” show after nearly two months away, for an interview that would be broadcast across two mornings. She’d been in Arizona, enduring an ordeal the likes of which most of us can contemplate only as part of the plot of an egregiously dramatic movie or television show. Eighty-four-year-old Nancy vanished, a flood of variously credible ransom demands were levied, then . . . nothing. No more credible messages, no triumphant return, no body. Guthrie and her siblings recorded videos, pleading for news, for help, for a merciful change of heart from whoever had absconded with their mom. But still nothing.

Guthrie had agreed to do the interview as a desperate final appeal. Someone, she kept saying to Kotb—someone must know something. She’s right. You can’t just make a person disappear. Another camera, an eye tuned to the subtle strangeness of an otherwise ordinary day—someone or something, somewhere, must have caught a glimmer of the truth. Among the public facets of Nancy’s disappearance is a frank, resentful, widespread incredulity at the failure of the technological apparatus that surrounds us so

ungraciously, whether we like it or not. Many of us assume that we are, at this late date in the history of the world, almost totally surveilled. Our bodies pass from one camera's jurisdiction to another, turning the city street or suburban road into a constant cinema of overlapping angles. What's all this footage for, if not a scenario like this one? How can an elderly woman just be gone?

That question, no less baffling today than it was back in February, haunted Savannah Guthrie's interview. She spoke in her usual strong, musical way, but there was also something mystified and hesitant in her tone. She relayed the story of her family's tragedy almost tentatively, as if testing her own perceptions against the recollection of the audience at home. Was this really happening at all?

The surrealism of the interview—and of the circumstance that was its context—was heightened by the fact that both Guthrie and Kotb are exemplary exponents, even under so much pressure, of the “Today” show's ethos and sensibility. Both women occasionally smiled through their tears, telegraphing poise and control more than an overflowing inner joy. As Kotb asked questions about Nancy, whom she sometimes affectionately called Guthrie's “mommy” or “mama,” she seemed to brace herself, and Guthrie, too, for the inevitably devastating answer. They were narrating an awful and unresolved series of events, but also still doing the “Today” show—reassuring the audience by way of their softly displayed, endlessly professional command over the medium of television.

In the interview, describing the early moments of her mother's absence, Guthrie explained the array of terrifying thoughts that occurred to her and to her siblings. Her brother, a retired fighter pilot, “saw very clearly, right away, what this was.” A kidnapping, he said, for ransom. “He knew.” Guthrie's instant instinct was self-blame.

“It sounds so—like, how dumb could I be? But I didn't want to believe. . . . I just said, ‘Do you think . . . because of me?’ ” Here, something cracked in Guthrie's held-together performance. “ ‘Yeah, maybe,’ ” her brother responded. Guthrie gasped quickly for breath as she recounted the conversation. The warm studio lights and blurred background and pinkish couch now played in haunting counterpoint to the spectacle of a daughter

relaying—and still pondering—the arrival of the darkest fear: having somehow, possibly, caused harm to her mother. Of course, this was deeply unfair. The blame, almost certainly, at least partially, belongs to the unconscionable entity caught on camera, gussied up like an *ICE* agent or a soldier on loan from a private military contractor. But simply naming the great fear and sharing it with the millions of watchers in living rooms and hotels and airport lobbies was a trial almost too painful to contemplate.

How did she feel watching the person on the Nest camera? “It’s just totally terrifying. And I can’t imagine that that is who she saw standing over her bed.”

Whenever the interview cut back to the “Today”-show set, members of the program’s cast—Craig Melvin, Carson Daly, Al Roker—emitted an audible groan of terror and sorrow for their friend. They, too, were participating in a professional exercise, however unprecedented. But, unlike Kotb and Guthrie, out there alone on the tightrope between total journalistic disclosure and the sensitivities of morning TV, they couldn’t really keep it together. Melvin—always the empath—looked ready to head home and cry. Daly, the former teen-pop monarch of “Total Request Live,” seemed to age decades before the camera’s eye.

It all seemed, uncomfortably, like a crowd had gathered to watch Guthrie walk through the stations of some unfathomable cross. The timing of the interview—just a few days before Holy Week, when Christians like Nancy and Savannah Guthrie, year after year, stage a harrowing reënactment of an unjust, torturous death—wasn’t lost on anyone. On Friday, when the final segment of the interview aired, Guthrie spoke in boldly religious terms. She’d prayed and prayed at the beginning of her family’s Passion, and at one point, she said, she actually heard the voice of God, speaking to her. She knew where her mother was, the voice said: “With me.” Whether in this world or whisked away from it, there Nancy was, close to the divine presence.

Hearing Guthrie speak of God in this direct, personal, utterly assured way may have alerted some listeners to the fact that although “Today” has no official religion, its aesthetics—vibrant colors, kind words, total decent positivity—match that of an American public Christianity whose moral and

imaginative hold lately keeps attenuating, until, suddenly, in the right, blameless hands, it seems briefly to brighten again.

Kotb announced afterward that Guthrie would return to “Today” on Monday, April 6th, the day after Easter. “My joy will be my protest,” Guthrie said. ♦

An Artists' Duel Proves Restorative in “The Christophers”

In Steven Soderbergh’s film, Ian McKellen and Michaela Coel are superbly matched as two skilled painters who find their way from slippery deception to common ground.

By Justin Chang

April 03, 2026



Nobody stages a home invasion quite like Steven Soderbergh. For some of us, this much was apparent as early as “Out of Sight” (1998), when George Clooney stormed into a millionaire’s mansion in search of uncut gems. But Soderbergh has since become an ever more restless raider, and each break-in has reached new heights of formal and conceptual ingenuity; he elasticizes our understanding of genre even as he undermines our sense of stability. “Kimi” (2022), a neo-Hitchcockian thriller centered on an Alexa-esque virtual assistant, paid witty homage to two break-in classics—“Rear Window” (1954) and, bear with me, “Home Alone” (1990)—while suggesting that the most insidious intruder of all was the internet. In the

supernatural chiller “Presence” (2025), the uninvited house guest was a ghost haunting a family; the camera suavely assumed the apparition’s perspective, erasing the boundaries between cinematic tricks and genuine miracles.

Soderbergh has become such a prolific, tirelessly resourceful, and altogether uncategorizable filmmaker that you have to wonder why the mechanics of the break-in still inspire him. His latest such exercise, “The Christophers,” may not fully answer that question, but it’s satisfying in every other respect. The home here is a ramshackle London town house where a famed painter, Julian Sklar (Ian McKellen), is spending his final years in a haze of creative stagnation and lingering renown. The invader is a skillful art restorer, Lori Butler (Michaela Coel), who’s been hired by Julian’s greedy children, Barnaby (James Corden) and Sallie (Jessica Gunning), to work, or pose, as their father’s new assistant. Lori’s true mission is to locate eight unfinished canvases—part of a celebrated series of portraits of Christopher, a former lover of Julian’s—and complete them in secret. When Julian dies, which his children hope will happen fairly soon, these never-before-seen Christophers will be discovered, hailed as his final works, and sold for potential millions. (Lori, they promise, will get a third of the proceeds.)

The script, by Ed Solomon, treats the Sklar siblings as cardboard grotesques—heartless, talentless, united in their loathing of a father who loathes them right back. Sallie’s own failed artistic career comes in for some nepo-baby knocks; we see her long-ago attempt to finish a Christopher, and it’s the most garishly incompetent touch-up job since roughly 2012, when a Spanish would-be restorer warped a fresco of Jesus into a meme for the ages. Lori, though, is no amateur. She’s a consummate technician and a lightning-quick study, with an innate intelligence that Coel—the extraordinary creative force behind the HBO series “I May Destroy You” (2020)—signals with a rapid yet cautious gait and a magnetic pensiveness that, even in moments of repose, causes her enormous dark eyes to pool with drama. Lori hesitates to take on a job that goes beyond restoration into outright forgery but eventually agrees, and not just because she needs the money. She and Julian briefly crossed art-world paths years before, under circumstances that he would scarcely remember but which left her with formative, humiliating scars. This is her chance at revenge.

Once Lori enters Julian's home, the film springs to life. So does Soderbergh's camera, which begins sniffing and roving about the space like a dog unleashed. Our curiosity is awakened by the meticulous clutter of Antonia Lowe's production design—walls covered with framed portraits and newspapers, shelves of knickknacks, spatters of paint everywhere—and, most of all, by Julian himself. We find him in his studio, seated before a laptop rather than an easel; Julian, who hasn't painted anything of note in three decades, now makes money recording personalized video messages for his fans. Solomon's script shrewdly places both the artist and the con artist on commensurate footing: Lori, who operates a Chinese-takeout stand, is as dependent as Julian on an alternate source of income.

Not that Julian sees much kinship, initially, with his new assistant. Their first conversation is comically lopsided, and McKellen, purring his way through what is effectively a monologue, lays the groundwork for his most vividly inhabited and hilariously irascible performance in years. Physically frail, yet in full verbal command, Julian doesn't talk to Lori so much as at her, pausing only to fire off questions that harden, in midair, into assumptions. He urges her not to blather about her artistic aspirations, if she has any, or to assail him with excessive compliments. ("I like my flattery. I just need to believe it," he insists.) Lori listens in dumbfounded silence, keeping her eyes on the prize, and trying not to roll them when Julian makes a comment about the dearth of great women artists—the kind of remark that earned him a close brush with cancellation in the past. The next day, he greets Lori on the stairs, his bare torso jutting out of an open robe. When she asks him to cover up, he makes a crack about Harvey Weinstein, who "ruined the robe for the rest of us."

McKellen has mentioned the robe-ruiner before. In 2017, after investigations into Weinstein's history of sexual harassment and assault ran in this magazine and the *Times*, the actor told an audience that "nothing but good can come out of these revelations"—though he drew criticism for stating, in the same sentence, that "some people, of course, get wrongly accused." A Julian Sklar faux pas, avant la lettre? On a more recent, less anger-stirring note, McKellen has said that Weinstein had once apologized to him for his aggressive awards campaign on behalf of Roberto Benigni, which secured him the Best Actor Oscar for "Life Is Beautiful" (1998)—an honor that

rightly should have gone to McKellen for his sublime performance, as the director James Whale, in “*Gods and Monsters*.”

Julian is, like McKellen’s version of Whale, a queer artist in the twilight of a major career, contemplating his legacy, mourning a lost lover, and striking up an unexpected cross-generational friendship. Whale lusts after a hunky gardener (Brendan Fraser) and persuades him to pose for a few sketches; Julian, though bisexual, expresses no such interest in Lori, and any art-making turns out to be a gratifyingly mutual endeavor. There are, naturally, layers of deception to scrape away first. Lori’s pauses reveal more about herself than she is aware, and her boss, for all his bloviating, turns out to be a surprisingly sharp listener.

Soderbergh extracts some fun from the ensuing cat-and-mouse logistics, from Lori’s meticulous duplication of the *Christophers* to Julian’s efforts to bluff her into admitting her true intentions. But the two are, inevitably and marvellously, kindred spirits, and it’s delightful when the tense, combative rhythm of McKellen and Coel’s dialogue suddenly takes a warmly contrapuntal turn. By the time Julian realizes what’s going on, he’s more impressed than outraged by Lori’s lies—and, if he chafes at the notion that she (or anyone) could so easily reproduce his painting style, his ego is disarmed by the pleasure of encountering, for the first time in years, an artistic and intellectual near-equal. Solomon gives Coel a bravura speech in which Lori precisely and unsparingly deconstructs the long arc of the *Christophers* project, treating Julian’s techniques and materials as a direct window into his ever-evolving emotions—even the ones he faked. Commenting on an ostensibly buoyant period, Lori declares, with devastating accuracy, “The lightness was forced, and the joy was a lie.”

Lori’s speech articulates the fundamental twinship of artists and critics—a reality that has always resisted attempts to drive a wedge between the two. “*The Christophers*” is a work of criticism that deftly distinguishes different approaches to criticism. A scathing essay that Lori wrote is shown to have more rigor and value than an old television show, “*Art Fight*,” that once featured Julian as a Simon Cowell-esque judge. Called on to evaluate an amateur artist’s work, he responded as though he were being paid by the unkind word. Julian ultimately musters kinder sentiments for Lori, urging her to apply her formidable imitative skills toward the discovery of her own

voice—to put aside what she describes as “the art of . . . becoming someone else.”

These words are fascinating to consider in relation to Soderbergh, who has flitted among genres and subjects with a facility that is easily mistaken for dilettantism, or even ventriloquism. Yet, though he may appear to deal in familiar gestures, his quicksilver marriage of high-flying ideas and hands-on technique marks him as the opposite of a forger. He becomes someone else only to the degree that he employs pseudonyms: the cinematographer Peter Andrews, the editor Mary Ann Bernard. Otherwise, he is, as my colleague Richard Brody pointed out in 2022, “the most physical” of Hollywood filmmakers, “the one who comes the closest to the painterly ideal of touching the image.” I thought about that line throughout “The Christophers,” especially when McKellen’s Julian, his hands smeared with paint and glitter, attacks a canvas with renewed vigor, a sequence in which at least three levels of artistry can be savored: the character’s, the actor’s, and the filmmaker’s. The invasion in this movie is neither an assault nor a threat; it’s an invitation to open doors and let fresh inspiration in. ♦

Poems

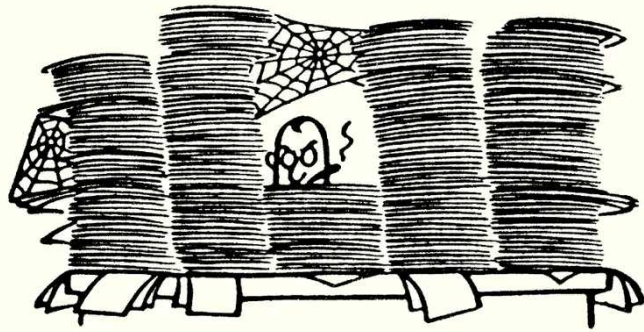
- [Theodore Roosevelt Taylor](#)
- [Meanwhile It Rains for Two Weeks and the Heat Never Breaks](#)

Poems

Theodore Roosevelt Taylor

By Tyehimba Jess

April 06, 2026



April 12, 1915–December 17, 1975

Hound Dog once confessed:

I can't play shit, but I sure make it sound good.

Others just said he played the hell out' that guitar.

Yes, it's true the hell was played out
of his guitar on the daily—along with five hundred miles
of barbed wire wind whistle, a murder
of crow caws, twenty pounds of brass-knuckle
jangles, and forty acres of midnight cricket song.
When he dragged the holler of his humbucker
through wire and magnified coil, folks swore
they'd heard the muffled motor rumbles of seven
funeral cars, the spinning chambers
of eleven .44s and a mother's murmured-up prayers
echoed off plaster-cast praying hands.

In short, he slid metal on string till the devil
got tickled and laughed up the Blues.

Born a polydactyl, his twelve fingers
flayed the six-string till one night
he freed himself of his right hand's
sixth nub. Sawed it off drunk
on something loaded
with more proof than sense.
Each boogie he played held a secret
line dance for the sacrificial digit,
its spirit hovering up in the stratosphere
somewhere with his howl.
In a distant forest,
the monument to his reckless
fretwork rustles in the treetops
and hums with beehives
like the watts in a worn, weary amp
burning, crackling for release.

Poems

Meanwhile It Rains for Two Weeks and the Heat Never Breaks

By Morgan Parker

April 06, 2026



Sometimes I text my friends I'm crying
and they reply *lol*.
It's not their fault. My lack
of tact and legibility is divined.
On Wednesday I resolve to be friendlier
with myself, more encouraging.
Thursday I call myself a stupid cunt before breakfast.
It's almost funny how much
I'm actually crying. It's kind of funny
how I know exactly what Gordon Ramsay is like when
his kids don't clean their rooms, but I don't know my neighbor's
last name. I don't know any attorney generals offhand.
I almost never know my login on the first try.
I don't know if I'm taking the right medicine

for the right disorder. I don't know if I'm being
who I really am
from day to day
if the priority should be
me or all of us and what
if any distinction there is and why.
I'm either asking or answering the wrong question here.
I like how the dog knows when I'm about to cry.
I like how the record player never asks me to log in.
Sitting at the typewriter there is no notification.
No one is laughing at me but myself.
It gets old, but I get used to it.
I get older and more used to it.
I am hanging in there, I keep saying, clearly
meaning something different
than what we all have decided those words mean
or more precisely what they demand.
Society and community and that stuff.
Whatever instructs me to say "Don't worry about me."
It's nobody's fault,
but today the last line of my horoscope was
"there is no such thing as a soul," so
maybe horoscopes have gotten out of hand.
I wonder if I could heal
my own energy eventually, for free.
I just need to be reminded
which moon makes me bleed
and which moon
makes me want to. Let me
preface this and
everything after: I'm not joking.
There is no such thing as my soul.
Remember when Heidegger said, "All distances
in time and space are shrinking"?
I know, right. I could be drowning, and
all my friends would be laughing
at my impression of me drowning, like *oh yeah*

*You would totally drown that way
like with your face just like that*

Puzzles & Games

- [The Crossword: Monday, April 6, 2026](#)

Crossword

The Crossword: Monday, April 6, 2026

Today's theme: Overdrive.

By Kareem Ayas

April 06, 2026





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